

The Empire Invades! Arc

Chapter 137: A year of Progress

After Yuuki escaped, we were unable to immediately pursue.

As they say: haste makes waste.

One could say that Leon's impatience led to Yuuki escaping, but the real reason is the fact that we couldn't trust each other.

As such, I noticed that we need to establish order amongst ourselves first.

I mean, there's no question that all of us desperately want to save Chloe.

But no good will come from acting rashly, and who could have excepted Yuuki to slip into the Empire.

Fighting the Empire along with him puts us at a disadvantage. We need to prepare.

I was tasked with handling Milim, while Leon would handle information-gathering. But that entailed basically waiting for his spy to report in.

With regards to the resurrected red knight, the blue knight was delighted and Leon thanked Ruminas. Thus we decided on our future actions.

Leon will collect information while refraining from impatient actions.

Though Leon's anger was easy to understand, the fact remains that he let Yuuki escape.

Well, maybe he can just create a barrier around the battlefield—though whether a bearer of an ultimate skill would be affected is a different story—but I still believe that we should not act independently.

Sure, we won't come to trust each other with our lives; but we do share a common goal.

This common goal is the only thing that binds our group together. Should that common goal disappear there's no way I'll be able to control the other two.

While Leon is gathering information, there are places which we must visit.

For now, we need to return and prepare our countries for an eventual confrontation with the Empire.

But first, I have to deal with Milim.

Life got a bit complicated for me once I separated from Leon and Ruminas.

Soothing the raging Milim.

Telling her that her pet was resurrected, and getting thanked by a delighted Milim.

And have her “guardian” come right after Milim anger was soothed.

In short, I had to prevent Milim from rampaging.

I guess you could even say that I needed to manipulate her.

Her “guardian” (Frey) should have come sooner. She seems to have come the moment Milim regained her composure, but I don’t want to think that Frey was just waiting for the right moment to return.

In short: my life sucked, and I couldn’t help but wonder why I had to suffer through this.

Right... Leon forced me into this.

Well, since Milim’s mood improved quickly, I guess it wasn’t that bad.

From within the orb I carried the Chaos Dragon's soul formed into a small monster.

A dragon hatchling... a DATCHLING!!..

He basically appeared from within the egg the moment Milim came.

「... Gaia, is that you?」

「Kyuuui!!!」

The dragon and the girl embraced each other.

A touching reunion.

After that, we “partied”... by going to the labyrinth and power-leveling Gaia.

What? No! We weren't just playing around. I mean, we only got into our avatars—Ramiris, Milim, Veldora, and I—and delved into the labyrinth.

Since Gaia could fly, he followed close behind me.

And as you would expect from a Chaos Dragon,

The dragon got used to fighting after only a few battles, and quickly started using miasma breath against multiple opponents—miasma breath would drive our enemies mad.

The dragon also had a skill etched into his soul—gravity manipulation—which he used to create shield around us, thus becoming one of the most valuable members of our party.

The barrier is rather strong, and now, even if the enemy is a mage, my magic barrier and Gaia's gravity barrier creates an impenetrable wall.

As a result, though we had previously struggled against the

boss of the 30th floor, we have now cleared him with ease.

「Kua-ha-ha-ha! He's no match for us now!」

「Yep! It's only Gozule, after all!」

「Wahahaha! This made my day!」

「Kyui!!」

That was fun.

Hmm? No! We weren't just playing around!

Stop saying such foolish things. We're trying hard for Gaia's sake!

As long as it's for Gaia, what's the problem with us having a

bit fun?

But soon we... no, I couldn't help but be overcome with worry over Chloe.

No matter how much you enjoy the present such thoughts just creep up unexpectedly.

But, no, I must not worry. 'Tis not an emergency yet, and undue worry harms one's heart.

I wonder if Milim and the rest suggested we come here because my worry was showing on my face?

If so, I would be very grateful.

As soon as we tried advancing to the next floor, Frey appeared.

And though Milim protested, it was useless.

Even though Milim was crying and wailing like a child not wanting to leave the arcade, Frey's iron smile and words of "persuasion" won in the end.

Figuring that Milim came over to play, Frey made sure that Milim understand that she'll be working without a break for a while.

「I'll be back!」

Milim said, leaving.

In and out like a storm.

As for Gaia, he continued wandering the Labyrinth in his current form.

It was too soon, he said, to have Milim train him, so he planned to return to her side after becoming slightly stronger. The labyrinth has an magical energy level, and Gaia has Ramiris' bracelet, so he should be fine.

And thus another companion joined us in our labyrinth adventures.

By the way, we didn't know of this at the time, but our five member team came to be known as the unique bosses of the labyrinth. Inhabiting the floor above the first, a bosses of unbelievable strength, they say.

In other words, when we controlled our avatars, we were so strong that adventurers would just roll over and die.

I found out about this later when these rumors reached me.

This, though, is how we appeased Milim's anger.

None of us would dare to have fun while Milim was away.

So we decided to actually do some work. Well... I'm not sure what I can do actually.

There was that thing, about doing a joint research venture?

I was supposed to supervise it and make any requests I could think of to them, I think.

Thanks to Gerudo's efforts in building a road and setting up barriers along it, the preparations for our various joint ventures are going well.

We'll soon have a road running directly from Sarion to Tempest.

We also have a plan to build a railway heading towards the dwarfs, so as to facilitate faster exchange of goods and materials.

But I worry—should the Empire invade, would these railroads not harm us in the end? That's why we prioritized building a

road to Sarion first.

By the way, the researchers have arrived: the Dwarf Artisans, Sarion's Sorcerers, and Holy Empire's Engineers.

Though the roads have not been fully paved yet, they could easily travel here already.

That's why they arrived even before we completed the roads.

I digress, but must again reiterate that we completed these transportation routes in but a year.

We even set up night lamps and anti-monster barriers for night travelers.

Towards the Dwarf Kingdom we set up a railroad, and half-way along it we built a few inns—those later developed into a town.

That town benefited greatly from the various engineering projects and became rather prosperous.

And because it's close to a river, it's a good place for people to come and rest.

That town, by the way, will later develop to be a central station district.

And yeah, we were wary of the empire's invasion, so it's not like I regret any of the choices then made.

The fact that we so quickly built the roads and railroads actually helped me solidify dominance over Jura Forest entire.

Each tribe pledged their loyalty, and their young joined Gerudo's corps. Thanks to the roads we established a solid trade network of food and goods.

In fact, we may have created as efficient a system as the one back in my previous world.

I thought for a second on whether I should build forts and castles, but decided against it. It would just be a waste of time, I figured.

If the Empire really does invade us, then I'll just completely destroy it. What's the point of being anxious against someone you'll know for a brief second?

We'll just use our entire force and stop them before they even start. So there's no point in building castles.

Though if the Empire does advance we might have to destroy some of the rails; but even if we have to do so, we can just rebuild them later.

And since we don't know when and if they come, there's no point in stalling our development even for a moment.

The matter of the angels is the same.

When they invade I'll annihilate them. What's broken we can

simply repair.

After all, things are not as important as people.

Protect not the art but the artisan, so I say.

Having arranged our affairs around this notion, even I was surprised at how fast we developed.

The spirit research was primarily handled by the Dwarfs' and Elves' joint venture.

Bester was originally involved in the "Magic Armor Research," and this type of research is the most common in this world.

In contrast, Sorcery Studies are veiled in secrecy and taboos.

The genius researcher, Epress Elmeshia basically founded this

field by mixing Elemental Studies with Alchemy.

With many brilliant minds from the Sorcerer's Dynasty here, we're going to have a splendid Sorcery facility here. Of course, no state secrets will be divulged, though.

Then there are the Vampire's researchers, which are unlike anything in this world.

They study not magic, but physics and the laws of the world. Science of our world.

They depend not on magic but on using laws and the building blocks of reality to achieve desired results.

For a world full of magic, this kind of study is the true heresy.

And the amount of information they have is so vast, that it will greatly affect our future research.

The whole point of this was to fill Tempest with research of every kind—to exchange ideas of every kind, and, as a result, to create fields of research and facilities the likes of which this world has never seen.

It is thus paramount that the research is carried out in utmost secrecy.

So we need a location that can be easily protected and difficult to infiltrate.

What better place could you chose than the 95th floor of the labyrinth? The treants have set up a city there, you see.

And this city is also inhabited by elves, some of whom may want to help in the research.

It's easy to defend, easily accessible, so it really is the ideal location.

Even if the angels attack, they will probably not be able to

reach the 95th floor. Even if they do, Ramiris says we can just swap 99th for the 95th floor at a moment's notice.

So this will give me a peace of mind.

So with this, we proceeded to set up sleeping quarters.

And when the research began in the earnest, we immediately ran into disagreement. Every single group wanted to focus on their field and was worried about the confidentiality of their studies.

That, however, would defeat the whole purpose.

So, I decided to divulge all their secrets quickly.

What secret is safe from Raphael? I compiled their research in easy to understand terms and handed such a portfolio to each one of them.

Oh, and I wrote it on valuable paper, not parchment. The paper is low quality—made from wood fibers.

But it is a step in the right direction.

Like this we got them to cooperate.

Of course alcohol played a role. There's a beautiful paradise of alcohol and elves right outside of the research facility. Any dispute could easily be... dissolved in a bar.

The Vampires, too, though they did not need to suck life out of people, certainly enjoyed sucking the alcohol out of cups.

By the way, I too joined them on many occasions but was never paid for overtime work. Unfair, right?

Seems like exchanging cups is a way for people to transcend national boundaries. Thus we all became good friends and brought forth various results.

Ramiris, of course, was also interested in this research.

At some point she became the research facility's mascot and idol.

Oh, and I did not forget that I broke her golem so long ago, so we focused on that first.

Being familiar with both "Magic Armor Plan" and "Spirit Armor," we quickly completed the research. For some reason, most of the researchers laughed an empty laugh when we did.

How long did they work without a single break through? I guess you would get discouraged if that were to happen.

And admittedly, the gem I invited came in handy.

We also were able to push for the release of the "Barrier-kun"—Kurobee's and Bester's Simplified Magic Circle Equipment.

Using their invention and other data, we were able to start absorbing magical energy from the atmosphere and thus complete the Spirit Amor.

The spirits would convert magical energy into spiritual energy, which would then be stored in batteries.

In other words, so long as some magical energy is present, perpetual motion is possible.

I have finally attained unlimited energy!

The first project we built was the Spirit Armor for Ramiris.

7 feet tall, weighing 1.5 tons. Charged with a number of batteries, allowing for individual and high-speed motion via gravity control.

Arming it was also kind of fun. It's one of those things that would excite any military otaku, though its performance is far below Beretta.

So I personally think it's more of a toy than anything.

But this research did come in handy for the Magical Energy Train.

I was considering at first to use golems or demons to power it, but that's no longer necessary.

We took time to design the wheels to fit the tracks, as well as to create passenger and cargo cars.

We emphasized horse-power, efficiency, and load capacity.

And after a few test runs, the train started running. Reaching an average speed of 50 km per hour.

This invention, which redefined commerce, naturally altered history. With trains, you could transport even produce before it spoiled.

We will never stop laying rails.

Not only between us and the Dwarf Kingdom, but also towards the seas, the four corners of this Earth! Too many requests are coming from other countries.

Brumund Kingdom wants a stop, so does Ingrasia, and Sorcerer's Dynasty Sario wants a direct line.

Nonetheless, the rail towards Dwarf Kingdom took a year to develop, so new rails will have to wait for a bit.

We still need to master inertia and gravity control, as well as consider armed trains.

While Fortresses are not needed to counter the empire, armed trains might come in handy.

How about equipping a spirit cannon on it, maybe some rail guns, and also ferry troupes on it.

Well... this really was just a hobby, and I'm not really serious about this. So long as no one takes my words seriously.

As in any world, how fast you can deploy your soldiers decides the war. So it's not like arming the train will make that big of a difference.

It's fine to use the normal train cars.

And thus in a year, we created twenty trains. Each consists of about six-cars.

With these trains, we created a four-thousand-man strong train corps. We could increase that number, and would likely do so soon, but not now.

Right now we're just ironing out the problems of using trains.

Once we're done, a trip between the Dwarf Kingdom and Tempest should take at most three days.

So a roundtrip would take a week. Though hopefully with time we could increase the speed.

And when did announce to the world this invention, countries were in total uproar over it.

So we accomplished lots in this one year.

According to what Leon's spies gathered, Yuuki has been climbing the ranks of the Empire.

But they are still unable to invade us. There's no doubt they are preparing for war, but war will not start just yet.

There may be a chance they'll send assassins, but it's actually rather unlikely. As Ruminas said: it's a waste of men to try to kill us that way.

In fact, that's just how it turned out. Any attempts were basically suicide, and they gave up after the first attempt.

And it's not like we could permit them to see what we're up to.

In any case, it's clear that the Empire is getting ready.

And thus, our research continues.

There's no question that, inasmuch as us, the Empire achieved grand things this year.

And we were not the only ones to prepare.

I actually found out about this just about when we started testing our trains.

The countries neighboring Jura forest, the Council, sent us an invitation.

Asking us to participate in their next meeting.

Of course, at this point, this invitation was essentially fated to arrive.

Chapter 138: A request from the council

The Council is a collusion of the countries that surround the Great Jura Forest.

With congressmen selected from each country, a monthly meeting was held in the Ingrasia Kingdom.

If one had to describe it, the congressmen met first to control profit, and second to manage operations of their countries.

When I say profit, I mean more: damage control and monster control.

There's also the need to balance the trade of country specialties, but because speculations and policies of individual countries often get lumped in, these discussions are often difficult.

In addition, on the agenda is aid for victims of famine and monster attacks.

Issuing subjugation requests to the Freedom Association to mitigate future harm is also the job of the council.

Operation funds are from member countries, the amount they pay is proportional to the country's size.

Along with this financial burden is the opportunity to increase the number of one's congressmen. In other words, gain more say in the council. For example, a large country would need to pay three times as much, but sends three times as many congressmen.

This doesn't have a direct effect on one's nation, but does allow a country to show off its power.

As one's voice in the council increases, so does the opportunity to get preferential treatment. Thus, even though one would profit from the meeting itself, there is profit to be made there.

There is also a minimum membership fee, failing to meet which results in expulsion.

Expulsion means no help during emergencies... a death sentence for smaller countries. The decision to expel a member is also made by the majority, which simply solidified the power of the larger countries.

Membership fees are expensive, and the largest Farmas Kingdom was recently destroyed.

And then there was the recent chaos regarding the Freedom Association. As such, it's natural for the council to panic a bit.

And now terrible news have reached the council.

There's movement in the Eastern Empire!

This was enough to throw the council into full-blown panic.

The council, currently amidst secession and confusion, was faced with a danger capable of eliminating every country.

The one who summarized the situation was the Ingrasia Kingdom's congressman.

For the kingdoms to be in disarray just as empire's beginning to move, this might be the worst case scenario.

To the royalty and legislator of each nation this was a self-evident truth.

If, a certain small nation were to submit to the empire's scheme, the other nations would follow in suit. At that time, the remaining country's defeat would be all but certain.

3 years ago, smart countries had already begun preparations in response to the Eastern Empire's movement. However, matching the Empire's military might with their own did not go well.

Therefore, the main agenda of the day was the formation of an alliance against the Empire.

That day's agenda was looking rough.

Amongst them was the chairman of the Freedom Arbitration Committee was Hinata Sakaguchi.

While a large country can sustain a standby army, a small country cannot afford to do so in times of peace.

While hiring mercenaries at times of war has been a common practice, with every nation stockpiling fighting power simultaneously, they simply ran out of people to hire.

Thus, some of them suggested that every nation should send a portion of their fighting power to form a private army under the direct control of the council

「In other words, aside from the parliament guards, the council should also have an army!

During times of peace they would be used for patrolling and monster countermeasures.

Now that the Freedom Association is no more, it should be possible to hire adventurers as soldiers through the Freedom Arbitration Committee, what do you think? 」

This proposition was also the main topic of today's conversation.

For some time silence dominated the council. Monster countermeasures has also been handled by paying the Freedom Association a certain amount. The name of the supplier may have changed, but that's about it.

Donations and support has been given to the church, from the Council's funds.

In exchange for the aid, the committee has managed to handle monsters without relying greatly on foreign troops. As a result, monster damages has been greatly lowered as compared to previously.

Thus the congressman demanded people to patrol and a permanent standing army.

Hinata looked at the congressman in amazement, and sighed.

「So, you're saying that the Adventurers affiliated with the Freedom Arbitration Committee, will be forced under the control of the council? 」

Hiding her tired expression, Hinata asked the congressman.

Certainly, there are funds in the council. However, it isn't a large amount.

Previously, the council would determine payment based on the rank of the monster the adventurer would face. The Freedom Arbitration Association, on the other hand, subjugates monsters as part of their faith, and require no other reward.

But with the funds that the council already had, the council wouldn't even be able to treat every citizen to a meal. To impose a duty upon free men and women for such a meager amount is akin to treating humans as dogs.

The Freedom Association was an association that had no ties to any country. Therefore, by paying a certain amount of tax, the association had gained the right to settle in a country.

Of course, their stance is a neutral one.

When natural disasters such as monster outbreaks occur, a mobilization order per the agreement with the country would be issued, and they would cooperate with forces affiliated with the country.

However, wars are not natural disasters. There's no reason for adventurers to join a country in a way.

Sure, directors may have changed and several adjustments were implemented, but there's fundamentally no change from the Freedom Association era. Or rather, by being incorporated with the church, the organization's strength has increased and now rivals that of a nation.

The congressman's remark of giving the council direct control over adventurers was absolutely absurd.

However, the circumstances have changed.

The countries feared that, even if they joined hands with the Freedom Arbitration Committee, they still would be unable to repel invaders.

Hinata was aware of this.

The intelligence gathering ability of the man from the Burmund Kingdom, Fuse, was high. The details of each country's inner workings had been reported to Hinata in advance.

Thus, she decided to assess the attitude of the other party without flat out denying them.

As if facing a roaring waterfall, Hinata watched a portion of the legislators nod vigorously, and

「Precisely. As Legislator Giaban mentioned, it is natural for us to unite and face an unprecedented danger. We presume the

association agrees? 」

「Tis true, a good plan. As the Arbitration Committee, you can't overlook this crisis either can you?

It's natural for fellow humans to cooperate. Wouldn't you agree? 」

And so on.

Probably through a secret agreement, murmurs of approval rose simultaneously.

Not everyone was included, however there were no objections from the rest of the legislators. Besides, having trouble with commandeering at times of war was a problem many countries shared.

So, many probably expect a prompt rejection, but can't help but try to get some free soldiers this way.

But it all proceeded brilliantly within Hinata's expectations, and in lieu with the evidence.

Now then, what to do? Hinata thought. Or rather, the answer's a given.

Accept, or reject.

It's easy to flat out reject them. To begin with, they're on equal footing—they can't be forced to accept.

Sure the point is to protect each other, but this is nonetheless a relation of give and take. The Association isn't so weak that they must follow.

And even if she does reject, there's no country among them that has the authority (now) to expel a nation refusing military support. The current council simply couldn't continue to exist if they were to lose even a single taxpayer.

Moreover, the association is indispensable to the council—

they prevent illegal activities and suppress criminals.

Only one group has such influence as to force other countries from the council—what was known as the Freedom Association, and what is now the Freedom Arbitration Association.

However, if this ends with a rejection, then the relation between the Association and the council will turn bitter.

I refuse! I want to say, but they won't take this lying down.

Moreover, if the Association does not cooperate with the council, then they won't be able to match the Eastern Empire.

Being callously commanded around is repugnant, and yet it's hard to reject this. What a pain.

Then must they accept?

This will likely be seen as the Association's fall from grace. No doubt within a year, the Association will be forced to lick the Council's feet.

This must absolutely be avoided. Considering future relations with the group of countries, an equal relation must be maintained.

Sure it's hard, but the Association must refuse.

But there's no way she can simply accept.

And Thus, Hinata made a suggestion.

She suggested that they...

In response to the council's request, I have come to the

Ingrasia Kingdom.

I've been given a VIP treatment, they're prepared a hotel of the highest class. Right now, I wander in the castle town.

I brought Benimaru and Souei along. Also Shuna. It'll be troublesome if I bring too many, but this should be fine.

Shion is busy training the subordinates, and Gerudo has taken command of various constructions.

As for Diablo, he's been out clearing whatever remains of Farmas. He's been saying something about gathering his protégé... whatever that means.

Well, they'll come immediately if I call them, and it's not like there's work for them to do here, so I let them do as they please.

And that's why the four of us travelled to the Ingrasia Kingdom.

We've look around at various shops, and Shuna was especially interested in window-shopping the latest clothes and decoration.

Benimaru has been acting vigilantly as my guard.

Souei has been lurking about, giving me reports from the shadows.

Speaking of shadows, it's been lonely now that Ranga no longer dwells in my shadows—he's with Gobuta.

Gobuta has been called to train with Karion, and he suddenly broke into tears, saying he was going to be killed. With a "it can't be helped"-kind-of-feel, Ranga joined him, but his tail was clear: Ranga too was depressed...

Oh, but I'm pretty sure Ranga likes Gobuta.

And all's swell when they are doing well.

While enjoying a meal in the Ingrasia kingdom, we exchanged opinions about the upcoming council meeting.

Shuna's holding on to the clothing I bought her happily, and is rather talkative. It's fun to see such a difference, compared to the sad-excuse-for-a-secretary Shion.

Doesn't seem like she was listening to us at all though, but I don't think it matters much.

Honestly, I actually don't give a damn about the council. I came out here with Shuna and Benimaru today to give them a well deserved break.

So unlike Souei who's always on some business trip, I would like to give Benimaru and Shuna a chance to enjoy the world.

And that's why we're giddily discussing tomorrow's agenda.

「So, Souei. What's the agenda of tomorrow's meeting?」

Souei then let us know.

Contrary to our expectations, seems like there's a dragon rampaging somewhere, the appearance of a mysterious demon lord... or so Souei's subordinates gathered.

Doesn't Souei like to work hard!

Becoming something like shadow-beings, his troops were collecting information non-stop lately. So the reason for our invitation should already be known by Souei.

And by now everyone knows that I rely on Souei for info gathering.

「Well, we've already got the gist of it. We relied on records of country strengths and our own hypotheses...」

「Ah, spare us the details. So, why were we invited?

We've been treated as a national guest, but they probably want something.

I wonder is it because of the train? Do they want it in each country?

Since we would need to lay rails... it would be impossible even if they asked 」

「Perhaps, they want our help because a war is about to start?

The only ones we're obligated to help is the Burmund Kingdom?」

「Ah, the empire. There's that too. It's about time huh」

Benimaru and I talked about important matters casually.

Shuna isn't here at the moment, so no one can stop us from

divulging state secrets in a café.

But thanks to a barrier we've erected earlier, no one can hear us anyways.

「What Benimaru said is correct.

However, it does seem that the train has also become quite the hot topic. To those who couldn't imagine such a thing, that is. Some merchants contacted Myormiles-dono, but he's not one that can be bought.

The main matter will be on Eastern Empire's invasion, and possibility of Tempest's support.」

「How unfortunate that they want our power and not the train... Well, I am planning on crushing the empire, but is there a reason for us not to accept?」

「Ay. Actually, from the information we grasped, the Empire's forces are a big deal.

In a straight up clash, in terms of national power, we would be at a disadvantage.

It would be a different story if we forcefully mobilize every race of the Great Jura Forest, though」

「That's true.

I mean, they have prepared for war for many hundreds of years.

Worst case scenario, we might even be asking countries here to cooperate」

And so the conversation between Benimaru and I continued.

In reality, it would be great if we could avoid open conflict, considering that Yuuki's there as well.

That's because I hoped to conceal our fighting potentials like Sion and Diablo, who are currently enthusiastically strengthening themselves.

Seems like I inadvertently caused our Department heads to go into a training phase. Even Gobuta is out and about trying to get stronger.

Moreover, even if the countries never requested our support, I can't really imagine a case where we did not join in the conflict.

「I see, there's probably no problem right?

In this situation, the power balance is split between the association and the council

The council reflects the noble's opinions, while the association defends the interest of the commoners.....

The Council pushed to commandeer adventurers, and Hinata proposed to utilize the strength of Tempest instead.」

「Huh? They want to use us?」

「Yes, using us. However, since we've been recognized as a country, our forces will be left to our own discretion.

In other words.....」

「Hohou. I see, isn't it fine... wait how is that different from just being used!?!」

「This sure leaves a bad taste.....

Well, the other party doesn't seem to have any intention of taking advantage of us but it's still hard to stomach. 」

We both nodded and concluded the conversation.

With our cake after a meal, the clerk had come.

Cake.

Such an alluring food.

While a sweet taste can still be prepared to some degree, sugar is still a valuable commodity.

And so, cakes are super high class luxury goods even in Tempest.

Ah, this nostalgic taste.

Even though I ate this every day for too many days, it's still great.

The real reason I brought Shuna here today is for the cake.

This way Shuna will remember the taste of the cake and reproduce it. My memory wasn't enough to recreate the taste,

so I had to bring her here.

「Shuna, this is seriously delicious

During your stay here, feel free to eat as much as you want.
So, remember the taste to the best of your ability」

Shuna, who was puzzled by my words, tried the cake.

First the short cake. It's orthodox, but this cake affects all other cakes. If this one's bad, no doubt the rest will not turn out well.

Shuna took a bite out of the cake.

And turning serious, she looked me straight and nodded. She then intently concentrated on the cake.

Soon, words were no longer needed. We understood each

other on a deeper level. And if she could even replicate ice cream, cake would definitely be a piece of cake.

And so we, completely discarded our earlier discussion and indulged in delicious cake.

The next day, we arrived at the venue of the meeting.

The contents are as expected. Hinata visited last evening, and gave me an overview.

As per Souei's intelligence, the council's objective was to utilize our forces in the name of cooperation.

However, the feeling is mutual.

And so began the clash of wits between the raccoon and the fox.

Chapter 139: The Whole Story of the Assembly

Yesterday's cake was delicious.

Therefore, I will visit again in order to heal my weary mind after the tiring conference.

As expected of the royal capital of Ingrasia Kingdom where the Freedom Association's Headquarters was located.

Yuuki actually did a good job.

He searched for "World Travelers" and sheltered them. Not just people with high ability but those with knowledge and those familiar with technology as well. Since I was mainly obsessed with food, I could learn something from this.

To be honest, there was no satisfaction in a meal at the level of a frontier village. Modern Japan was too luxurious.

Only one boiled potato every day and a tasteless soup made with bitter grass. Such meal was the norm.

Because salt was a high-class item, food that had flavor was precious.

Even bread, since it was eaten when hard, would be nothing more than a hardship. To try and improve the food was a very natural action, but whether or not it was possible was different issue.

Just like with me, the images formed with the knowledge of the former world might not be conveyed properly to the other party. It would be certain that there would be many attempted trial and errors between a “World Traveler” with common sense and the other party.

I could pretty much estimate that much.

Thanks to their efforts, I could eat a cake, even in this world.

Although the reason I came to Ingrasia Kingdom's royal capital was to participate in the Council's conference, I believed this issue could be more important than that.

Today's goal was negotiating with the shopkeeper to see if he would share his recipe.

Shuna said she could make an identical cake, but it would require several months of research in order to make one at the same level.

I greeted Kirsch-san, the shopkeeper. I wanted to ask him to teach Shuna how to make it.

The recipe might have been a secret, but even if it was useless, I had continued to ask him.

「Aah? You want learn how to make my cake?

Do you think a treasured recipe can be taught to other so easily?!

I'm glad that you liked the cake, but this was made with the effort of many people.

So it can't be taught to others so easily.」

Oh well, it was a natural reaction.

There are similar shops in many places in this town, but after my eating spree and comparing them to each other, only this shop had the real deal.

It was certain that the other shops only imitated this shop. This shopkeeper could also be another "World Traveler."

「Could you please do something about that?」

Shuna asked politely while lowering her head.

It was a refined movement that placed her both hands

together and bent at the waist beautifully, charmed all who saw it.

「.....guu. I, I won't fall to such a seductive technique!

But, I will think about it, if you can make a dish that can satisfy me, anything is ok.」

Oops.

It seems Shuna was able to draw out a compromise. I was prepared to have to research it in the worst case scenario, but Shuna's dishes are first class.

It might go well.

「Shuna-san. Cook to your heart's content and end this!

Make that conceited shopkeeper moan by the supreme dish!」

「Yes. I understand!」

Shuna was motivated.

The cake had instigated a fire in Shuna's spirit.

Shuna borrowed the kitchen and prepared the supreme dish.

It was Tamagoyaki.

The supreme dish, that was said could make someone understand the cook's skill, was Tamagoyaki.

Kirsch-san stared at the given plate and gulping, he swallowed his saliva. Saying nothing, with a fork, he put a mouthful Tamagoyaki into his mouth.

「Delicious!!」

It was a single blow.

With Shuna's dish's overwhelming power, Kirsch-san acknowledged Shuna.

「Thank you very much」

A charming smile floated on Shuna's face.

Things had concluded. As the smile pierced his heart, Kirsch-san seemed to fall completely.

「Tchi. It can't be help! It's a special occasion, okay?」

The muscular Ossan responded to Shuna with a shy smile.

Honestly, I could only say he was acting dere-dere. Oh well, it couldn't be helped, Shuna's pale pink hair suited her well, and she was a lovely girl.

Kirsch began to teach Shuna how to make the cake in the kitchen.

Benimaru and I ordered a drink similar to coffee from the clerk, and thought about the conference earlier while waiting for Shuna.

.....

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...

When I had arrived at the assembly hall where the conference was held, several Council members came to greet me.

I heard many stories from the people who came to visit the Tournament, it seemed they wanted to tie diplomatic relations with me.

I considered the future appeal and interacted sociably with them.

「Ahahahaha. Rimuru-dono, though you are called a Demon Lord, aren't you very sociable!」

「Oh my, you're quite right. From now on please call me as you see fit.

By the way, I hear that you produce many interesting items?

Would you mind allowing our country to handle those goods?」

「Oh, about that. We're in the feel the same. We also expect your cooperation.

Of course, the appropriate remuneration would be——saying more than this would be tasteless, right」

Ah, yes.

What should I call it...this speechless feeling?

This wasn't even being rude anymore!

I had believed the other party might have been a noble, it might have been a failure for me to act modestly. It seemed they had misunderstood my response considerably.

Oh well, it was troublesome. Even if I didn't particularly distribute goods to these fellows, it could still be distributed by the guild—as the organization under the Arbitration committee.

「Ah, is that so. Please take care of me at that time」

Let's go with a strategy of juggling conversations without any meaning.

This was a conversation between adults. It was a talk of “If you want to buy something, come buy it yourself!”

I refused the impolite Council member with a smile and left the place after I had finished giving light greetings.

In the midst of a lengthy talk, another committee member also approached.

Although my mood had been ruined since the morning, I endured since I could possibly request something here, and entered the meeting place.

And then the conference began...from then on was the true hell.

At the last meeting, the agenda Hinata had proposed was to appeal for our cooperation. I had heard it from her.

The defense would be entrusted to our country, and a constant amount of money would be paid. Given that the other

party was certainly going to use us, we too would use the other party.

Oh well, we were equal in this regard. Anyway we were located on the Empire's invasion route. If the war happened, it was natural for the rear to work together.

Also, if they paid the defense fee, of course I would accept. I didn't have any reason to refuse.

And then there was the real issue.

The purpose of participating in this conference was to make them hand over their surplus forces.

In other words, I would show off the monster's power and the powerful military strength in my possession.

Each country would pay us their defense budget, and we would be used for good. However, in fact each country possessed large military forces, their size enabled each country

to ignore Tempest.

Tempest had already been recognized as a country. Because we were aiming for co-existence and co-prosperity with human society we should hesitate to hold a role of the defense force for the Confederation.

Besides, by giving support it would be possible to demonstrate our military force to watchful eyes of many countries. It was a strategy that killed two birds with one stone.

Hinata had said that she had also aimed for this.

The soldiers under the direct control of the committee only included a few Holy Knights. Therefore, by building a base for us, they could entrust the emergency response to us.

I approved of that plan, even if I was being used by others I had also intended to make a profit off of them.

How did things turn out like this?

The desk I had kicked up was floating in the air and when it fell I pulverized into very small piece with my heel.

I crossed my legs, sat on the chair arrogantly, and glared at the Council members who turned pale. They looked at me in surprise and I let out a sigh in my mind.

No, I had endured it at first.

Even as an adult, I was considered someone with a heart wider than a sea. I could even brag that this was as famous as the stories of my recent activities.

As someone who was called the embodiment of patience, dealing with the Milim's selfishness was my forte. Because I had a vast, spacious heart, I could even laugh and forgive Milim's selfishness.

But...

What about the committee ossans and their selfishness

covered in greed that didn't have any charm?

The answer to that was the large desk that was crushed before their eyes.

「Ah, you guys. Are you making fun of me?

Saying whatever you please, am I your servant?

Aah? Don't think I don't know even though I remained silent!」

In the conference room that had fallen silent, my voice resounded calmly.

I didn't shout but my voice seemed to inflict the mind of the Council member with fear.

I also did not use the 『Demon Lord's Haki』 .

Because, if I used it on human, the best case would be they panicked, and the worst case would be they become insane and died in madness.

The brainwashing series was usable, but all possibilities of friendship with humans would vanish if I used it. I didn't have the hobby of spending time with uninteresting dolls that can only answer YES for the remainder of its life.

In other words, I only got angry and broke the desk this time, it was just a normal intimidation tactic.

But, the effect was still great.

「No, no, Rimuru-dono We didn't say it with such an intent...」

In the first place, it was that.

To address someone of a higher standing and a King of a country with “Dono”.

Even if we held the status of a country, they only treated me like the king of a vassal nation, not as equal country.

I was sure these fellows were looking down on monsters.

And the contents of the discussion from a while ago...

Geez, share the blueprints for the magic train, give the rights for joint management of the labyrinth, hands over the tax from the people who lived in the satellite town and not the citizens of Tempest...

It was just stating their selfish demands.

I was a Demon Lord, for cripes sake! Because of this, I expected to be treated with proper respect, however they were just acting in an extremely unreasonable manner.

Even if they were nobles who represented their nations, my generous heart had reached its limit.

No, I would say that Yuuki was quite a clever fox if he could lead such tanukis by the nose. It was impossible for me.

《Notification. Therefore, I told you I would be the one represent it》

Raphael seemed to say something but it might just have been my imagination.

Raphael-san who was just a skill should not have able to intrude freely to such an extent.

I was too angry and seemed to have heard an auditory hallucination. But, it was good since it allowed me to collect myself a little.

「Eh? Then, what kind of intent of what you want to relay?

Are you telling me to work like a carriage horse as your guys slave?」

「N, no! That's unthinkable! We don't have such intent...」

I shifted my focus onto the Council member who had spoken frantically, and suddenly I had an odd feeling.

That fellow's eyes were facing towards the inner part of the conference room's door.

When I listened carefully, I heard several footsteps. Apparently, he seemed to have called the guard.

When I noticed that, the door was flung open and several soldiers and a large man entered.

「Oh oh, so energetic. Are you an idiot to call yourself a Demon Lord?

But, you only brought three attendants, aren't you bragging too much?

Stupid!

If I beat you and put you under my thumb, you monsters will be at my mercy!」

The large man immediately barked loudly as he entered.

Eh? What?

You're going to beat me and turn me into your minion?

What is this fellow talking about? Did I become dumb? I didn't really understand what this fellow was saying.

《Solution. This large man (Fool), says that he will win against master and turn you into a minion》

I could understand that!

If it was explained one on one with serious look, I would be really dumb.

「Oi..... Is this the consensus of the assembly?」

In reply to the question posed by my tired self,

「Are you an idiot? Of course it is! Or, are you frightened?

If you grovel and lick my shoes now, I won't make you feel pain.」

The large man answered with vulgar laughter.

But amongst the Council members there were some who were stiffen fear and confusion,

「I didn't hear about this. What is this about?」

「Who instigated this?」

「That soldier is wearing armor bearing the crest of the Ingrasia royal family.

That means, this is Ingrasia's instigation?」

I was able to hear such response from an obviously unrelated, a perplexed person and a person who had made a calm judgment.

That meant that this matter is not a decision by the assembly, it was just a reckless show of power? Oh well, it seemed Hinata didn't know about this, and it was certainly not a unanimous decision either.

I made such a judgment.

「Oi, don't enter without permission.

The Council's assembly hall is in the middle of a conference right now.

You guys, this is not behavior becoming of a soldier」

Hinata calmly demanded the large man and his group to leave.

「Hahaha, Hinata-dono. It's fine.

It is I who called them. It's to teach that outlaw a lesson」

「Gavan-dono], did you lose your mind?

Though I didn't hear about this before.....

Or rather, didn't you guys hand the authority of the Council's decision over to me?」

Hinata's voice lowered and become cold.

Ah, she seemed to be quite seriously angry. I thought it was certainly due to that fool's judgment.

「Shut up, woman. Ah?

I don't know if you're the former Holy Knight leader or what, but I am the leader of the Ingrasia Chivalric Guard Order, Reiner-sama is not your enemy.

Didn't you wet yourself with piss running away after being defeated by that meager Demon Lord? Right, oh Holy Knight Leader-sama.

Anyway, that position too was merely a decoration you obtained after seducing a sex-minded cardinal.

Even if a small fry fought you, it would be a poor and boring fight. To lack the resolution to kill the Demon Lord, it's ridiculous!

But well...your appearance isn't that bad. If you want to become my woman, it would be okay for me to love you as my beloved concubine」

Ah, this fellow is dead meat.

Hinata's expression didn't change. Her cold, beautiful face was like normal.

However, contrasting with her cold outward appearance, inside she seemed to be raging like magma.

「Whoa, Reiner-kyou. Isn't that a little vulgar?

Still, I'm interested in the Demon Lord as well. Monopolizing it wouldn't be good.

That's right.

I forgot to mention it, but this Sir Reiner is an A rank Adventurer that could also defeat the Hero.

He's stronger than you all, no matter how many of you there are.

Don't be conceited when you're just have a little bit of strength.」

Suddenly, as that was announced in a loud voice, a hard to describe chill ran down my back.

It was disgusting. This ossan could even provoke me who was difficult to provoke. What a terrible talent.

「——Oi, you all... Is that, the decision of the Ingrasia Kingdom?」

Hinata asked in a calm voice that didn't let you feel her anger.

「Fufu, that's right. Since the Council, already has passed its decision.

Well, though the voting is going to start now.」

A blond young man stood up and said that.

The meeting hall was filled with commotion and excitement.

「Elric-ouji——. Is this by your instigation?」

「That's right, Hinata. You should sit」

Prince.....?

This idiot, no, this prince, is the mastermind behind this?

He seemed to be the prince of Ingrasia Kingdom, but this

fellow seemed to have somehow incited several Council members.

「Then, let's vote.

I will defeat the Demon Lord on this place and make it our minion.

Anyone that agrees, stand up!」

The prince's voice had echoed loudly, and the majority of the Council member stood up, wearing disgusting smiles.

It seemed they had communicated secretly and had a discussion.

The financial situation of each country, the responses of the royal families, as well as the records of proceedings in each country's assembly and so forth, I had Souei investigate them all thoroughly.

However, I hadn't thought that the Council members would have been bribed individually. It was a failure on my part not to expect such possibility.

《Notification. Nay, there's no problem. It's within expectations.》

Eh? Within expectations?

I felt like I saw an illusion of Raphael sprouting a dark smile.

「Rimuru-sama, this is」

Souei handed me several account books.

Ah.....it's the secret accounts. Was it seriously within expectations?

Before anyone realized, I had secured the account book which

listed the bribes and so forth of the Council members that were in collusion.

It's a blunder-less performance.

The number of account books was in accordance to the number of Council members that stood up at Prince Elric's command.

This was nothing but a farce since I had already obtained unshakeable evidence.

The remaining Council members that had not stood up, perplexedly asked the others,

「I didn't heard this!」

「Even though His Majesty Rimuru especially came here by himself, this treatment will be a problem!」

「Something like this should not be permitted. For what reason is there a Council if there's no fairness!」

They raged and felt offended.

Now, the seated Council members did not seem like they were flexible nor like they had fair dispositions.

I knew it was because they seemed to address me using appropriate manners.

It was uncertain whether the country that those Council members represented were upright or not, but I thought I was more likely to trust them than the countries that sent malfeasant Council members with unacceptable manners.

Anyway, because a Council member is the representative of a country, then the person represents the country.

「The vote is out. Because it exceeded the majority, the hall has approved this agenda!」

Elated by their success, Prince Elric declared that loudly.

The Council members who followed applauded.

The Council members that had remaining seated hung their heads, while Hinata watched the farce with cold eyes.

Because carrying a weapon was not permitted she was unarmed, however if she had held a sword now, she would have been gripping the hilt strongly.

「Well now that permission has been given, choose whether you want to lick my shoes or feel pain」

The fool called Reiner stood before me and said that.

Hinata looked at me. She seemed to be calculating how to move depending on my response.

Well then.

「First, I want to confirm something. Is that okay?」

「Aah? What is?

「No, you guys decision. Is it okay if I take this as the country's decision?」

「Hha! Are you an idiot? Such a thing now, what abou——」

Shuna stood up, took out a folding fan and brandished it.

With just that, Reiner who was in the middle of talking was sent flying. He was cowering after he crashed into the wall, knocking over chair and desk in the process.

「I've been enduring, listening to all this since a little while ago....

Yo, you bastards, to Rimuru-sama that we respect and love, ho-how impolite.....」

Shuna approached Reiner calmly.

Ah, it seemed it wasn't just me who was furious.

Or rather, when another person exploded, I quickly calmed down.

When I looked around, my eyes caught Hinata's, did she calm down too? I felt that we could communicate with our eyes.

「Trash. I will not kill you so quickly. If I'm not mistaken, you had said that you were A rank.

I'll allow you to be serious.

Well now, stand up and come at me」

She pointed the folding fan at Reiner, and Shuna sent him a killer glare.

「Re-Reiner! What are you idling for!? Quickly silence that insolent woman.

You must also defeat that Demon Lord. There's no time for fooling around!」

Prince Elric who could not understand the situation, commanded Reiner to attack.

But, Reiner didn't move an inch.

「Are you not coming? Then I will——」

When Shuna was about to take a single step,

「Hi, hii——!!」

Reiner was cowering while holding his head with both hands.

From his groin, steaming liquid was leaking out.

Whoa, did he just wet himself? I was so astounded that I couldn't find any words to say.

「Shuna, withdraw」

Shuna nodded at my order and she returned to her position behind me.

Reiner began to cry like a child, slobbering with tears while cowering.

The match was already over. His opponent was too absurd.

「Well then, Elric was it?

You picked a fight with me, but what will you do from now on?

You guys too, your countries seem to approve this matter as well.

The same offense, is that alright?」

Everyone's face became pale and their heads hung down when I asked them that with a smile.

The match was decided. The reason these dullard fellow lost was because they had thought that a small fry could defeat a Demon Lord.

No, the Ingrasia Kingdom didn't border the Great Jura Forest. Therefore they didn't know the threat of monsters.

The Council members that approved of the agreement this time were from small countries belonging to Ingrasia's clique. The countries' intents and the Council members' intents were

different, but their contempt for monsters may be the same.

After all, nobles were beings that only thought about themselves. Oh well, though there seems to be a person who changed with the country among them. It would be better for me to have a second thought before associating with such country.

Because I only saw the document and deal with it unseriously, it might be better for me to review it later.

After all of that, the important agenda was approved and accepted by the Council members after I threaten them.

1. Military cooperation with Tempest.

1. Internal Passage Permit for the Tempest army.

1. Official participation in Confederation Council for Tempest.

1. The relocation of the Confederation Council's headquarters to Tempest.

1. The relocation of the Freedom Arbitration Committee's headquarters to Tempest.

Forcibly making them sign it, everything passed without a hitch.

With unanimous consent.

Outfoxing them, and using tricks wasn't something I was suited for.

As a result, I had simply controlled them using physical strength, and all the issues were resolved. The one who throw the hit wasn't me, so I was satisfied since it seemed to prove my open mindedness.

Thus, the assembly ended without an issue, and we left the assembly hall.

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Oh well, this was the whole story.

Prince Elric, the Ossan named Gavan who was a minister of Ingrasia, and the council members as well.

They were dumbfounded, they seemed frightened by the seriousness of the matter, but they reap what they sow.

Naturally, I gave Souei an order the moment the conference had ended. I had ordered him to deliver an account book to each of their countries. With this, the rude and idiotic people would be purged.

Even if they were forgiven, they would be fired, it could be said it was a dead end for them.

And also, the Ingrasia Kingdom.

Because of its facilitated transportation, this country had been the center of peace for many countries.

Even though the technology was remarkable, it didn't mean the productivity was high.

The culture level was high, but it was no more than reproduction by Yuuki so that "Other Worlders" could live comfortably.

Since an important institution like the council and the committee, would be relocating, its role as the center of many countries had already ended.

If they didn't do anything, as it was, they would surely begin to decline.

Even so that was a natural consequence, so there wasn't any need for me to feel bad.

「Oh well, Tempest becoming the center, even I approve of that」

Those were Hinata's words.

If she had said that, it was clear what would happen to Ingrasia Kingdom. Hinata didn't say anything.

On this matter, Hinata's decision was final. She had quickly returned and began to prepare the relocation. Well, Hinata might have been angrier than me.

I thought about it while drinking the pseudo coffee.

「Or rather, I was able to have a good experience this time」

「N?」

「No, I was too angry too, I might not have understood what happened since I was raging too much.

If Shuna had moved even a little slower, all the humans in that room would have burnt into nothingness」

Buu! So I spray out the coffee I drank.

I was admiring Benimaru since he'd become an adult. I had thought he had gone quiet, but he was just about to lose control of himself in the anger.

I felt that I had lost that admiration. Or rather, that was dangerous. I would have become the enemy of mankind if a mass slaughter had happened in that place.

「Oioi, you must absolutely prevent that!?!」

「Hahaha, it's just a joke. I'm not serious!」

Though Benimaru had tried to deceive me with a refreshing smile, I wasn't going to be deceived.

This guy was deadly serious.

For the next conference, I think it would be necessary carefully consider the personnel I brought.

Then,

「Rimuru-sama, I did it!

Kirsch-tenchou decided to come to Tempest!」

Shuna returned, and reported to me with a full smile.

「Since I heard that he was going to close the shop and go into retirement——,

He seemed willing to come when I invited him!」

「Seriously?」

「I'm serious!」

Wonderful.

With this, as long as I prepared sugar, eating cake every day was no longer a dream.

No, as long as there were ingredients, could I not assemble any kind of cake?!

「It's wonderful, as expected from Shuna!」

When I praised her, Shuna nodded with smile.

This time Shuna had played a very active part.

This is in great contrast to a certain disappointing secretary. If it was that disappointing secretary, even when going easy she might kill Reiner.

And then after using skillful deception, it would likely become something terrible. Oh well, that wasn't limited to Shion, but included me as well.

This time, thanks to Shuna, the negotiations were easily completed.

But, her greatest accomplishment was that she was able to persuade that stubborn Oyaji.

I had asked him earnestly before, but he hadn't budged at all.

She did a good job.

Thus the conference ended safely as well, and we returned home to Tempest.

Various things had happened, but the greatest result, It went without saying, was that cake would now be included as the dessert every day.

Chapter 140: Research Results

My diet had become more diverse.

Previously, with every meal, the dessert had been fruit, but now there was also cake.

Ah, it's wonderful to be alive. I had decided to make Sunday and other public holidays special because I had grown tired of eating too much everyday.

It was a satisfying life. When I had just reincarnated into a Slime, I had never thought about leading such a luxurious lifestyle.

If there are no problems with the East Empire, I could immerse myself in my hobby but.....

Thinking about it recently, Veldora, some sympathizers, and I had all thought something like, "Should we attack at the same time as the declaration of war?"

Although there some who didn't agree with the wait and see approach, if you think about it, it's easier to attack than it is to defend.

The spread out defensive forces might not have enough soldiers to protect along the planned invasion route. On the other hand, only deploying the reconnaissance unit to decide the route had a large risk of turning into an attack.

It's expected that they would not invade from the Dwargon Kingdom territory.

The neutral country, the Arms Nation Dwargon, possessed a standing army equipped with highly technological armaments.

The country's entry and exit points were also more suitable for defense, and not for an attempt to seize the city with a large army. Therefore, it could be said that the country itself was a natural fortress.

The sea route was also not an option. The number of the ships might not suffice, and there were also large demonic sea

monsters infesting the high seas.

It was difficult to meet the requirements and gain a foothold for sea combat, so the risk would be too high and the route would not be chosen. More simply, it was unknown whether the ship could sail the sea safely or not.

Similarly, the mountain range inhabited by the dragons was also not an option.

In the end, the only option left was the route that passed through the Great Jura Forest.

When it came to this, the possible routes that could be selected for military mobilization were three.

But, one of those routes was an area adjacent to the Dwarf Kingdom. I think it wouldn't be used for an unauthorized invasion, due to the fear of a pincer attack from Tempest and Dwargon.

In the end, the other two routes are the most probable for invasion. The army, in theory would be divided in two to handle the two routes.

However, was it really going to be that simple?

I couldn't help but to think about it. If the empire really mobilized as expected, was the empire underestimating Tempest? Or it was because they possessed a large army? Which one was true?

Anyway, those were my thoughts as a person that wasn't an expert in military affairs, but I would choose the invasion route between the two routes.

A military expert would not choose easily predicted the route simply because there was no other route.

No, on contrary if there's no other route, I would not move until I gathered enough forces to overwhelm the defenders, so I thought.

If it became a battle against that large army, then splitting the war potentials was a bad plan.

It was no good.

I got irritated while thinking about it.

As expected, we should attack, right?

Or rather, when the empire made their war declaration, was a suicide attack the right answer?

The right answer might not come even if I think about it seriously. I should deal with it by adapting to the circumstances.

'Adapting to the circumstances.'

The phrase sounds wonderful, it gives the image of capable man.

Alright, let's go then.

I made reconnaissance missions to various places, including the Sea route, as a precaution and I set up Transfer Magic Circle in various places.

Using the long distance communication method, the preparations for urgent mobilization were flawless. It was meant for personal use, but it was good enough for delivering reports.

If there was something, then a report would come. Let's think about that later.

With the conclusion reached, I stood up and went to the dining hall.

I needed sweets when I used my head. Though desserts were reserved for special days and public holidays, snacks were different.

I intended to ask Shuna to prepare a cake for me immediately.

Sweets were my soft spot. In case I grew tired of eating sweets, I would think about it when it happened.

My plan was easily overturned, though when I saw that Shion was in the dining hall.

A large smile appeared on her face when she saw me, and she presented to me the plate in her hand.

I wonder what this is, this unpleasant premonition.....

「I have been waiting for you, Rimuru-sama!

Don't be so reticent, Rimuru-sama.

If you ordered it, with a single word, I would have prepared a cake (something similar).....

Ok, here you are! The taste is identical to Shuna's, but it's several times bigger. Please eat it without reservation!」

She smiled while presenting the plate with a big lump of something that seemed to be made of konnyaku on top of it.

Eh? Cake.....!?

I gazed at the object on the plate I had received reflexively, and looked around, searching for help.

But there was no one, did they run away?

Apparently, I had come at the worst moment.

「Oi, is this a cake?」

「Yes! The taste is perfectly reproduced!」

Shion was brimming with confidence.

But, the bad feelings just increased.

The taste is perfect? Then, other than the taste, the rest isn't good?

I decided to eat a single mouthful while mourning my ruined plan.

This was something I had decided, to enjoy a post-meal dessert.

In the first place, this hellish situation was caused because I was a glutton despite the fact that I don't need to eat.

I scooped a bite with a spoon, and put it in my mouth.

I thought I vomited.

It had the consistency of konnyaku, but it tasted like an overly sweet cake.

Looking at it, it was grey and had the texture of konnyaku.

At this moment, I realized once more: For a cake, the appearance is important. No, not just cake, for any meal, the appearance is also important.

Even if the raw ingredients didn't seem to have changed, I didn't think it was delicious.

「How is it? Is it tasty?」

Shion's annoyingly smug look seems to say, it's perfect, right?

This fellow is like that. First of all, what was cooking? She seemed to stumble for such basic a basic point.

「Sit down. For a now, sit down there. It's time for scolding!」

「Eh!? Why?」

Her smug look immediately changed to watery eyes. Shion was flustered, but I don't care.

After that, for approximately 30 minutes, I lectured Shion seriously about what cooking was.

I finished scolding Shion and finally drew a breath.

Leaving her unattended was my mistake. Shion entrusted everything to her Skill and only got the resulting flavor. She might not improve during her lifetime because of this attitude.

Did my scolding work? Shion promised to learn to cook from Shuna.

Or rather, wasn't she already being taught by Shuna? No, no, that might just be my imagination.

I was slightly anxious, but with this I was safe for the time being, I decided to think that.

When I came out of the dining hall after modifying my thought, I unexpectedly met Kurobee.

「Oh, I've been looking for you, Rimuru-sama. You were here after all.」

「Hmm? Looking for me? Was there something you needed?」

「Yes, the previous request for a new type of weapon was completed!」

Kurobee reported joyfully.

Request from before? Because there were a lot, I don't remember which one it was.

Anyway, I went to the workshop with Kurobee.

The workshop was hot as usual. It was good that I wasn't affected by the temperature, although the work inside seemed great.

The number of people inside the workshop—including monsters—had increased since my previous visit.

「The number of apprentices seems to have increased.」

「Yes, thanks to you. However, they still have a long way to go. The number of unusable articles produced is greater than the number of usable articles produced.」

The two of us entered the workshop while talking, and the apprentices noticed our voices and looked up.

And then, noticing my figure, they all stood up and bowed simultaneously. I was surprised by their vigor.

When Kurobee saw that,

「You idiots! Quickly return to work!」

He shouted in very loud voice, and the apprentices' work resumed.

I might understand their feelings. It was similar to when the company president comes to your workspace, making you feel tense.

It was more stressful, for the people in lower positions.

I too didn't have much free time even though I was the King of the country. I might be just as pitiful as them since I couldn't play freely.

Even when general manager visited my workspace in the previous world, I would have prepared with a major cleanup the day before. If it was the company president instead, then overbearing mood where failure could not be tolerated would appear.

Since I understand that my household had increased, I might need to pay all the more attention when playing leisurely.

But.....

「I'm sorry for coming here so suddenly, but, because I think I'll probably be dropping by more frequently, please don't feel so tense.」

I said to them.

It may be a problem if I became over-familiar, but there was no need for everyone to be tense.

I loved to act big but it wasn't very interesting if they were too

tense and there was no reaction.

I preferred foolish responses, like Gobuta's. TPO——attitude corresponding to the Time, Place, and Occasion——as long as they knew this, then it was acceptable.

My words loosened the apprentices' tense shoulders.

I nodded once after I confirming it, and I went to the back room.

——By the way, I didn't know about it, but the reason the apprentices were feeling tense was not only because I was a Demon Lord. I had been chosen as one of the three major idols of Monster's Country Tempest while I was unaware. It was me, Shuna and Shion. The popularity was surprising. Besides, if Ramiris and Milim were added, it would have become something like a scramble for popularity. The rankings were intentionally withheld, but I hear that Milim and I were the very best. Good grief, I was shocked when I heard it, I will do anything to hide——

Well then, the articles from the previous request were shown.

Kurobee confidently retrieved the box storing the equipment and brought it before me.

The thing inside was a Broad Sword that gave off a powerful feeling. It was characterized by a small, empty, round hole on the size of a marble at the base of the sword.

There were three holes. They were all located in that spot.

Of course, the sword had a modest performance, but it wasn't an overwhelming weapon like those that Kurobee forged. Still, compared with the apprentices' work, it was on another level.

The materials were pure Demon Steel, it was valuable but didn't seem to be a special material.

It may seem odd, but it was a very normal, unique class weapon.

It didn't seem to be enchanted with a particular magic either.....

「This is? Compared to Kurobee's other work, it doesn't seem to be particularly outstanding?」

I asked him because I didn't understand.

Kurobee could forge a sword in a day. On average, the finished products would be unique class, and even when he made mistakes the finished product would still be superior rare class.

If I produced one carefully, it would take 2-3 days, but I could only produce would be of unique class quality at the least.

However, producing a legend class item was still a far away dream. I haven't succeeded even though I used suitable materials. It seemed if a finished unique class weapon was used by an expert for several years, it would evolve into legend grade by through the weapon's evolution.....

Therefore, it was unthinkable that Kurobee wanted to show me a mere unique class weapon.

「Fufufu, you haven't realized it? It's the mechanism that Rimuru-sama had described before.

When I inserted this gem into this sword's hole, then——」

While explaining Kurobee inserted a yellow gem-like marble he'd taken from the box into the sword's hole.

Then, the plain Broad Sword became clad in lightning magic power and transformed into a Magic Sword.

Yo-you don't mean this is!

「O, oi, Kurobee! Kurobee-chan! Did you complete it?」

I excitedly asked Kurobee.

A complacent smile appeared on Kurobee's face,

「Mufufufu. I did!」

He answered smugly.

Ah, it was just like Shion's annoyingly smug look, but I wanted to praise him honestly.

Suddenly I remembered the request: if a Pure Demon Steel weapon adapts to magic power, then, if a magic gem charged with an attribute is inserted into the sword, would it turn into a Magic Sword? Kurobee consulted with Kaijin about this.

Kaijin ended up researching with him, and thus it seemed that this was the result of the collaborative research of between Kurobee and Kaijin.

「How is it? Did you remember?

After directly condensing the magic power, we finally succeeded in refining a high purity magic stone.

According to the attribute of the magic power, it can be classified it into one of the four elements, Earth•Water•Fire•Wind.

Let's call the magic gem that grants the attributes Element Core or just Core.

It's possible to change the attribute, by changing combination order. Naturally, you can only combine one attribute per hole.

It's still in the middle of experimentation to perfect it, but there were some dangerous combinations.

Also, no matter how hard we try, the maximum amount of holes is three.

Furthermore it's questionable whether we can even create 1 hole for every 100 strikes.

Using the normal hammering method, it's difficult to create a gap for the gem...

It shames me to say it, but it was nearly impossible for the disciples to hammer a hole in the weapon.

Even my four best disciples barely succeeded in creating a single hole.

Well, if they give up they won't improve, and if they could create 3 holes then they would possess the skills worthy of a legend class.

That's what I believe.」

Kurobee explained proudly.

Wonderful. It's too wonderful!

Even though a magic sword was already valuable, a magic sword that could change its attribute had never existed.

It was an incredible creation.

Though I forgot about it completely, this might be useful against the empire.

Incidentally, since the rarity greatly changes due to number of holes, I think it would be interesting to set it as a boss drop in the labyrinth.

If the apprentices could make the hole on a normal sword, the successful product would be set as the floor boss's drop. I'd make the large boss of every tenth floor drop a core with random attribute.

Well, that's only if the adventurers get past the 30th floor. Should I set it for the 40th floor?

「What do you think? Can you prepare several varieties of

them?」

「Yes, since we will manufacture the batch to be delivered to the Commander class from now on, the failed products will be circulated in the labyrinth.

We don't have the time or resources to produce them for rank and file soldiers, but the high quality mass produced equipment should be enough for them.

There might not be a problem」

I received Kurobee's ready consent and the plan was decided.

Well, the labyrinth after the 30th floor becomes a real pain.

The boss of the 50th floor was Gozurl who lacked the restrain. He was our next target.

I can't play happily if I don't smash the empire quickly. I want to bring back Chloe too and have some peace of mind already.

Still, Yuuki is the strength of the empire.

I want to solve the problem quickly.

「By the way, the Demon Steel which was adapting to Rimuru-sama magic power from before, what's its condition?

Will it soon adapt completely?」

Kurobee asked suddenly.

Eh? That reminded me, though I had forgotten about it, for the sake of creating my exclusive weapon, I had let the Demon Steel mature inside of me.

「Y, yeah. It's alright. You remembered it?」

「Yes.」

「Wait a moment, I'll take it out now.」

I was a bit flustered, but I composed myself so he wouldn't realize that I'd forgotten about it. The Demon Steel shone with a rainbow color.

Though I hadn't mixed it with gold, it emitted radiance brighter than Orichalum's.

Hmm? It gave off the feeling that it had matured splendidly.

「How is it? Does it seem good?」

「Th, this is——!!」

Kurobee was surprised and excited to the extent of speechless.

I looked at it and appraised it a bit.

《Result. Divine Steel: Hiirokane (Ultimate Metal)》

So the result.

It was a superior version of Orichalcum.

It had a performance higher than the Orichalcum I had previously refined; certainly it could be called the perfect metal.

「Hi-hiirokane, is it?.....Amazing. It's the transcendental myth class material.」

Once it gets used to the owner's magic power, every other magic power is repulsed.

It seemed to be an ultimate metal which could be converted into either the strongest weapon or armor.

Unfortunately, because it had to be infused with an especially dense magic power, there was only a small amount. Just enough to make a weapon.

And with this amount, it might only be enough to create a weapon for me.

However, my exclusive katana could, at last, be made with this.

Previously, normal weapons were unable to endure my power and would break. I had to re-make the weapon many times while in the midst of a battle. It was an absurd situation.

If it was broken in a critical moment, then I wouldn't have anything suitable to defend myself.

I handed over the God Metal, glistening with rainbow colors, to Kurobee, and requested he make a katana with it.

Kurobee's eyes viewed it reverently and emitted a strange

gleam of extraordinary tension and excitement.

I had expected this.

I left the rest in Kurobee's hands and left the workshop.

While thinking about the still formless katana.

In one week, a report arrived. Kurobee had finished forging the katana.

At last, a weapon made exclusively for me was completed.

Chapter 141: An Unexpected Guest

I looked at the katana and was fascinated by it.

It wasn't an unusual Tachi. It was neither too small nor too big.

It wasn't big to be called an Ōdachi, it was just an ordinary sword.

It was curvier than an Uchigatana[1], and gave out an elegant feeling.

It was Kurobee's greatest masterpiece.

It could even be called a Divine Katana, an excellent item befitting of the classification of Myth class (Gods).

It was the best katana forged with only transcendental myth class raw materials. Despite being just born——just having been made, its performance was wonderful.

Because its compatibility with me was also fantastically good, it seemed possible for me to wield its full power immediately.

Its transcendental property didn't mean it couldn't evolve. It had the ability to repair itself even if it deteriorated or was damaged.

Even if it was in a pure state, without an attribute, it was a legend class item. The lack of an attribute wasn't a problem either since I could grant it one. Essentially, it could be said that I had obtained a weapon of Myth class (Gods).

「Ah, as expected, the katana is cool——」

I muttered while gazing at its beautiful blade pattern[2].

I had a feeling of wanting to admire its workmanship here forever.

At that moment, I heard knocking at the door.

I had been relaxing and idling around in the office, but it seemed to be a guest.

I returned to my human form,

「Come in」

I called out.

The door opened and Shuna entered.

Bowing at me, she....

「Rimuru-sama, it's a guest. He introduced himself as Dino, is he Rimuru-sama's acquaintance?」

「Dino? Ah, he is one of the Demon Lords. I wonder what he came here for?」

「Demon Lord? Should I call brother and gather the soldiers?」

「No, no need. Just in case the situation turns into a combat, only send in Benimaru and Shion, please.

Well, the concern is unneeded. Probably. I think he just came to play」

I said and left my seat.

I thought there was no need to worry. I felt that Dino had previously mentioned that he wanted to come to play or something.

「Acknowledged. Then, this way」

When Shuna nods, she guided me to the guest room.

It was a problem that there were a lot of rooms. We used them

properly according to the other party.

A luxurious room was for merchants and nobles.

A simple and firm room was for strong monsters and suspicious people.

This was because there would be a great loss in damages if they acted violently in the luxurious room.

When I entered the room after Shuna, I saw Dino's disheveled appearance.

He was relaxing on the sofa.

「Yo, long time no see. How have you been?」

He noticed me and greeted me while lying sprawled.

Shuna was angered by that response and send out a glance, but she bowed without saying anything and left the room.

Most likely she left to prepare the tea.

「Ah, I'm doing great. Well.... I can't be carefree though, since there are some problems.」

I replied while sitting on a chair across from him.

I took in Dino's appearance. He hadn't changed since the last time I met him, he still had that carefree atmosphere.

「What, is there a problem? It seems to be troublesome」

「Well. It didn't go easily. So, for what reason you did come here?」

「Eh? It's just like I said, I just came to play」

Shuna entered the room after she had prepared tea and cake.

In the room wrapped in silence Shuna set up the table as if nothing was wrong. When she was done, she bowed and left the room.

She was a professional.

I sipped the tea once and paid more attention to Dino.

Did he notice it...

「No, actually, I was driven out of Dagrue's place.

So, when I considering what I should do, I remembered about this place (Tempest), where his sons were being taken care of.

Because of that, I want you to take care of me too!」

「No, it's no good」

「——eh?」

「Eh?」

Silence once again descended in the room.

No matter how you put it, we were acquaintance, but I didn't think it was a good idea to support such suspicious looking guy like him.

I'm certain that this guy was the type that would say such things like「I don't want work-degozaru!」[3].

「Ple-please wait a moment. Then what? “Go fall dead on the street![4]” like that?」

「No, go to work」

「Don't say something so unreasonable! I hold the aesthetics of not working.

For the last several 100 years, I have never earned any money by myself, so I also don't have any money for food and drink!」

「Oh really...How amazing. Go home after you eat that」

Ignoring Dino's words, I reached out the cake with my hand.

The snack[5] served with the tea was a Cream Puff[6].

Delicious. Isn't it impossible to get bored of this?

Dino also picked up the Cream Puff and ate it.

「I know. Please make me a citizen of this country as well.

There won't be any regrets if I can eat such delicious things like this every day.

Rimuru, no Rimuru-sama. Please, order, me anything!」

He began to spout such nonsensical things.

I don't have any intention of employing you...

「Really, even if you say we are acquaintances, I only met you once.

What is your true purpose?」

I asked him seriously while finishing the Cream Puff and drinking the tea.

Dino shrugged his shoulders, his frolic atmosphere disappeared, and then he answered.

「Actually, Guy said[7] that it seemed like I could be well cared for in this country.

He didn't tell me the reason, because he's selfish.

If I disobey, it'll become troublesome, and it's true that I was driven out of Dagrue's place.

Because it was also troublesome to think, that's the reason I came here」

「Guy, that Redhead,[8] say so?」

「That's right. That Redhead」

Hmmm.

His atmosphere appeared honest.

It might have seriously been what Guy said.

「Ah, I remember. I have a letter from Guy」

Saying so, Dino took out a letter and handed it to me.

The seal and the aura.

Certainly, I felt the aura of Guy Crimson.

The letter just contained a few words, 『Please take care of Dino』.

「Wh?」

So, I nodded at Dino and pondered a bit.

It was troublesome, but it would be problematic if I

antagonized Guy.

Until I settled the issue with the Empire and Yuuki, my hands were tied.

It didn't seem like a big deal if it was just Dino alone. It would be good for me to receive him.

However, if he was only here to play, it might not be good to invite a person like that.

Then, I suddenly remembered something.

This fellow seemed to be no match against Ramiris.

Ramiris was currently researching and developing something using the facility I had prepared in a room inside her labyrinth.

I would occasionally show my face in the Joint Development

room and conduct various exchanges of opinions. Nowadays, I had become an idol in the development room, and my popularity was high.

Ramiris wanted an assistant. Because every task was handled by Beretta, it seemed she was short on hands.....

Just at the right time. Let's make Dino Ramiris's assistant.

「Okay, I understand, but will you accept the job?」

「What did you say!?!」

「Oh well, although I called it a job. I want you to become Ramiris's assistant.

That fellow does it quite happily, if it's possible I want to participate too.

When I have time, I will help, but because I'm a bit busy right now...

Oh well, let's not think so hard. Anyway, it's good if you do.]

「Mm, mmm. I understand. What are the details?」

「N? Ah, it's quite simple. I think you only need to follow Ramiris's instructions.」

Oh well, I didn't think an amateur could make it as a research and development assistant either.

Carrying things, and assisting in the collection of data. That might be the extent of his duties.

The remodeling plan for Beretta that I had considered about since before was complete, and I had remodeled it together with Ramiris. I had received a request from Ramiris after wards about the application of the facility, and I had prepared large quantities of Culture Capsule[9] and installed them.

What is a Culture Capsule? I used it when I was remodeling Beretta. It was a container of high-density glass which could culture[10] monsters and others inside it.

With the Magic Power Injection port installed to it, it was possible to adjust the concentration of the magic power injected to it. Inside the container was full of Magic Water——water from the vast water reserve I have inside my gluttony's stomach that changed because of the concentration of magic power——The system filled the container with magic power when the concentration was low and kept it at a constant rate.

As usual our relationship was close, so it was pleasant.

By the way, last time I was asked to prepare 1.000 Culture Capsules and install them.

Even though she hadn't answered when I asked why she needed such a large quantity, but she had said...

「Even I want to work you know! Please, because it will be surely useful!」

So, I wasn't able to reject her when she asked me that with her watery eyes.

If I had anything to say, it was that I also wanted to be helpful to Ramiris.

Besides, well, Ramiris was an idiot, but her head was good. She seemed to be flawless in regards to Spirit Engineering, and she had been studying Sorcery Engineering the many times I had visited her.

Since she had lived for a long time she had learned the laws of physics. It was unexpected, but she had the qualification of a researcher.

Though I say that, such a knowledgeable Ramiris was helpful, I believe there is no need to think about it.

Besides, even though I was asked to make various things, it was fun to see how it would turn out.

I hadn't visited her recently because I was busy. This was the perfect time.

I'm going to see her situation while guiding Dino.

When I crossed the door into Veldora's room, I had finally arrived at Ramiris' research facility.

Oh? Veldora can't be seen. Where did he go?

「Hey, why is magic power so thick in here?」

「Ah, it's because this is Veldora-san's room.

He will fly into a rage if you touch things in his room as you please, so please don't touch them without his permission.」

「Haa? Did Veldora lives in here!?

I didn't think that you guys were simply acquaintances, but to live in such place...

That explains why the reaction disappear so suddenly」

「Ah, the reaction has disappeared...I think it's because he learned how to control his magic power.

Previously that guy leaked out a tantrum of aura, and seemed to be discharging magic power as well.

Because that was very bad to have in the country we were planning and where people would live, he practiced to the point that he could control it」

「Haaa? That Veldora? The very Veldora who was wandering selfishly at his own convenience and called the ruler of the Great Jura Forest?

Or rather, I can't even sense his aura because he suppressed it!？」

「Eh? Ah, he's not that selfish though, you can ask him to do almost anything, you know?

About the aura, while it's great, it seems it's because he splendidly does his best to practice.

Even so...If we're talking about selfish people, then it will be Milim you know」

Because Milim wasn't here I might have said what I really thought of her.

That Milim didn't lower her head, even to Frey. She was a difficult being for anyone to deal with.

Anyhow, Dino seemed to have received a shock, and while I was revealing the troubling story we had received from Milim recently, we entered the laboratory.

He seemed to not to have heard half of the story, but I didn't particularly care since it was merely a grumble.

Well, surveying the inside, Veldora was helping Ramiris.

As usual, Ramiris was pushing someone around, huh? What a hardworking dragon.

Even though he complained, he eventually gave her a hand.

Veldora was unexpectedly soft on Ramiris. Was this a bad influence from her calling him Shishou?

Even Bester, who was participating in the joint research after he had entrusted the work related to the recovery medicine effect to his apprentices, was there.

Ramiris and Veldora seemed to be having fun with an evil smile, but Bester didn't seem energetic. He was completely exhausted.

Is he all right? It worries me a bit.

「Chee—see. How you been? Any progress on the research?」

While greeted them lightly, I advanced into the room.

Bester stilled his hand that had been writing on a document, looked in our direction, and then stood up.

「Oh, it's been a long time, Rimuru-sama」

「Ah, as usual. By the way, are you alright? You look like emaciated by something?」

「I'm alright, is what I want to say but...Right here, I have done research that's bad for the heart.....」

Nn? He looked like he was about to say something.

Veldora seemed to have noticed me, unsurprised, he approached me.

「Oh, long time no see. I'm also helping here.

Because Ramiris asked me, it can't be helped after all.」

「That's helpful. Since it seemed difficult enough that she had said she was short on hands.

In response to her request, I brought her an assistant today.

Though he might not have scholarly knowledge, I think he'll be all right with physical labor.」

「Yahoo! Rimuru, I'm waiting!

I have Shishou helping me and he helps me a lot.

And also, the research progressed considerably as well!」

「Ohh? That's good to hear.

Ramiris, you might know him too?

Starting from today, Dino-san will be your assistant.

You can rely on him in various ways」

And then, I introduced Dino to Veldora and Bester.

Dino looked around curiously but he completed his introduction greetings.

「I'm called Dino. More or less, I'm one of the pillars (person) of the Demon Lord.

I don't want to work, but I will be reluctantly helping you. Please take care of me」

How should I put it...you couldn't feel any motivation from his greeting.

But that wasn't a problem. He will be her assistant.

After the common greetings were over, I asked why Bester was here and about the details of research so far.

The reason why Bester was here was because he was abducted by Ramiris.

Locating Bester who was researching what I had requested in the joint research room, Ramiris seemed to have earnestly requested his help and brought him here because she was short on hands.

She wanted a person who would do the menial jobs such as filing in the documents or collecting data. Veldora didn't seem to help her with such tasks at all, so she conferred them to Bester.

「You've had a hard time, Bester」

I called out him, and a smile of defeat floated on his face,

「No, not at all, because this is work too」

He answered.

A while ago, Dino, a known Demon Lord, had worn an astonished expression as well, but his expression had immediately returned to calm.

He seems he had been surprised too much, and he might have mastered the art of an undisturbed heart.

Because he was capable, I thought I might want to mingle in the Joint Research lab, not to research but to play but...it seemed things were different than expected.

As for why he was worn out, it was because of the content of research.

Then he said,

「By all means, please let me keep researching! Ramiris-sama's ideas[11] are fantastically interesting.

We gather data almost every day, it would be too regrettable to waste that time sleeping!」

He started to make a plea without hiding his excitement.

The cause of his worn out appearance was simply lack of sleep.

There was magic like Refresh (Physical Condition Recovery) [12], but it didn't mean without any rest.

It seemed necessary to let him rest even if he had to be forced.

Dino came at the right time, entrusting the trivial tasks to Dino while Bester slept sounded good.

And so, I let Bester explain the details of the job to Dino. It would be good if they got along well.

Even though the other party was a Demon Lord, Bester didn't hesitate and explained things skillfully.

I noticed his appearance a bit, but it seemed he was fine. I decided to entrust it to them in ease.

Well, the research results made me worry though——

I was led to the hall where the Culture Capsule was installed.

And then, I almost shouted when I saw the things that

floating inside.

What the slime is this!![13] Or so, I screamed internally.

In front of me was a Bone Golem, made with Demon Steel, which could be said to be guarding this place somehow.

The bones were made with Demon Steel, so it was a composite structure, in the strictest sense of the word, it was a fake... That kind of bone golem was floating inside every culture capsule.

Instead of a heart in its central part, a “Spirit Sorcery Core” was pulsing. It was as big as a fist, however the core was of superior quality.

I couldn’t help but notice that the golem’s design concept was no different than Ramiris’s toy.

The Spell Mark was applied to the metal bone too, and the embodiment that had begun as a bone was enveloped in magic power. It was a process that could produce a monster, similar to

artificial reproduction...

I see, that was why Bester said that it was regrettable to sleep.

Each joint was embedded with a Spirit Orb, but there seemed to be no spirit dwelling inside of it yet.

So it was an artificial production of the new variety of soldier, a fusion of monsters and spirits? This is interesting.

「This is interesting. Was this Ramiris' idea?」

「Of course! How's it!?!」

Ramiris was boasting and puffing her chest.

Yeah, you can boast. This is amazing.

「Amazing. Is this everything?」

「I guess so. I'm sure it will succeed. But I worry, whether a Will would dwell in it or not.

However, in the worst case, if there's no Will, I can linking them to Beretta and put them all under control!」

Wow, she had thought it through to that extend.

Unlike the usual stupid Ramiris, it was quite skillful.

I gazed at a Bone Golem in the Culture Capsule while anticipating its power, but when it's born, it will probably become monster placed in upper rankings among the High ranked Devils.

There are 1,000 bodies. Were they created to grow simultaneously?

「Just perfect. It seems they will be useful」

「Right, right!」[14]

The idea was born when I saw Beretta's appearance, which you had created earlier.」

Ramiris stated joyfully while flying around me.

This seemed like it would become a great force more than expected.

「However, right now I'm at a stalemate.

Even if you insert the spirit, if the attribute is different, it's repelled...

It doesn't go smoothly. If it's energy without attribute, it can't invoke magic.

Beretta is a Saint and a Demon as well, though he was able to do it with direct energy, there's no attribute...」

Magic power would be gathered in the “Spirit Sorcery Core”.

The energy of the magic power would then be converted into energy to invoke Spirit Magic.

But, if spirits with differing attributes dwelled around the Spirit Orb, the result was that the spirits repulsed each other and it would become non-attribute, making it so that magic couldn't be invoked.

「And then, can you take it out as energy?」

「Yes, but, it only scatters in the air. There's no meaning you know...」

Ramiris seemed to be disappointed.

So she meant, that there was no meaning if even though it possessed magic power, it couldn't invoke magic.

N? Wait...

「Hey, how about you insert this?」

What I took out was the Core (Magic Orb) that Kurobee had handed over to me before.

Because this core was red, it was a Red Core (Fire Magic Orb).

Actually, the inside of this Core was a structure loaded with energy that gathered the surrounding magic power and changed it to an attributed magic power.

It was the reason a lot amount of magic power was gathered and the power increased when it was charged with the owner's magic power.

I thought that if I inserted this in the appropriate slot, it might be possible to use every attribute without any problems.

「It might work!」

Ramiris' face sparkled in response to my explanation.

She received the Core joyfully and said that she would asked Kurobee how to make them

I could also make them but I couldn't explain its principle. Anyway, it could be said that I could only copy them.

It was correct to ask Kurobee about it.

Ramiris merrily restarted her work.

Although Veldora had said he was helping unwillingly, his face showed that he was having fun.

Bester and Dino seemed to have become friendly with each other too, let's leave the next part to them.

However, everyone seemed to be doing various things in places I wasn't aware of, and that made me a bit anxious.

I was also worried about Diablo who was still on his trip, and about the training Shion was doing.

There seemed to be many applicants for the army too; it would be better if I organized it formally soon.

Since after I threatened the council, and all of the defenses had been entrusted to me, the adventurers and the merchants had gradually gathered to this place.

They stayed in the labyrinth city's area and set up their residences there, but there seemed to be some people who wanted to enter the Tempest Army.

I will think about the reorganization of the military in order

to include them as well.

I left the place while thinking about such things.

The things that still had to be done were plenty.

Chapter 142: Military Affairs

I must also name the dolls Ramiris has been mass-producing.

Magical energy has coiled around their demon steel bones, giving birth to something like muscles. Even so, their birth—their completion—is still ways off.

Furthermore, cultivating these monsters in a Cultivation Capsule further increases their strength by 1.5-2 times.

And, of course, the time required for higher monsters is greater than for lesser ones.

If you tried to accelerate the process, you would get an inferior monster, and naught can be done about that.

Of these capsule dolls, we have only finished but a thousand so far.

But time has yet to pass for them to be born.

And we expect them to be high class monsters.

Worst case scenario, they will only be stronger than Gelmudo... so they are a terrifying force.

In other words, we are mass producing A ranked monsters.

In human terms, we are producing monsters equivalent to a Templar Knight.

And that is their force at birth—O! How I long to see how strong they can grow!

Oh, surely you want to know whether a soul could dwell within?

So long as you etch a core into them, it will fill with magic energy.

Thus we are ignoring the point of creating souls for them, and instead giving them a jump-start.

Perhaps they will be mere shells of might but no mind.

Should that happen, we only need to make use of Sarion's possession skills, to have common foot soldiers take control of them.

Ramiris did recommend having Beretta link into them and command this great host, but with his processing power it may prove difficult.

Moreover, Beretta is Ramiris' subordinate.

Can't keep depending on him.

And he also has the responsibility of guarding the Dungeon, which he certainly cannot abandon.

But these points we can fret about when they are complete.

I sigh upon returning to my office.

There are too many things to consider.

The first corps.

Gobuta will be the commander, and Hakurou will advise him.

Affiliated with the first corps are...

———Ogre wolves, 100 members. Evolved from the combination of Wolf Riders and Star Wolves. Their battle power is at A rank [EP: 9,000 ~ 9,900] and they will serve as captains of this corps.

———Green numbers, 12,000 members. They have been split into a host of 4,000 members, comprising three teams. Their

numbers have increased greatly over the past year, so they will be put to good use. The majority of them come as warriors from the many tribes in my domain. Even so, they are B rank [EP: 5,000~6,000] and are a splendid fighting force.

Next, the second corps.

Under direct command of Gerudo, and the primary strength of Tempest.

Affiliated with the second corps are...

———Yellow Numbers, 2,000 members. These are the High Orcs serving under Gerudo. Individually they are strong B+ rank [EP: 7,500~8,000]. They are also able to unite with Gerudo to become a single shield. We reorganized them into teams and assigned captains.

———Orange Number, 35,000 members. Recently “born” high-orcs. They are C ranked. However, only 15,000 will participate in combat with a 20,000 support and engineer corps.

The third corps.

Vice-commander Gabil will lead them, launching air raids upon the enemy.

The affiliated members are

———Hiryuu, 100 members. These are, on average, the strongest unit in Tempest. A rank [EP: 9,500~9,900], but coordinate their attacks extremely well. There are some among them who are surpassing A rank as well. Their trump card being 『Battle Dragon Transformation』

———Blue Numbers, 3,000 members. Comprised solely of new applicants from the lizardmen. They are only C ranked. But that be not their true strength. Nay, their power lies in their ability to mount the Wyverns and take to the skies. In fact, this division has the ability to completely dominate the air space. Even within Tempest, they are a secret division.

***By the way, Wyvern is a lesser dragon species. These B+ beasts we acquired with the help of Milim.

Standing above all of these are three divisions of absolute power.

With the supreme commander Benimaru at the top.

Benimaru has full control over every force, such that not even I could command them.

But it seems that Raphael-sensei linked thoughts with Benimaru, so it's not like my will is not being carried out.

Benimaru's personal cohort is a group of 100 members of Crimson.

Crimson is a group of A rank monsters focusing on strength and truly possess ridiculous abilities. I attended one of their practice sessions, and while raw power wise they may only be at Gelmudo's level—level does not mean everything. Oh, their current “level” would match the Templar Knights.

The problem is that one's level is determined by how much

energy one possesses.

Their strength is basically determined at the moment of birth. And Tempest did attempt to inculcate greater strength.

Of course, in reality, energy does not define your actual strength.

Who can doubt Hakurou's strength despite his little energy?

And the captains of Crimson endured Hakurou's hellish training. They are a very dependable force.

Then there's Souei's information squad.

100 members of Darkness, was it?

To be honest, I only know four of their members. They do specialize in espionage, after all.

Souei said they have zero fighting strength, but I don't believe him. He does carry out assassinations after all.

Souei has sole and exclusive control over them, and few even know of them.

Truth be told, they are kinda frightening, and their name comes up only in rumors.

Oh, and I'll have Souei supervise the Third Corps as well. Information gathering could be done extremely well from the sky you see.

However, Souei can only command if Benimaru issues such an order.

Of course, Souei is not the kind of person to ignore chain of command and issue orders without authorization.

Oh, and you may have noticed: there is not a single group over which I have direct control.

Oh, and I forgot to mention my guard, Shion's Yomigaeri.

These individuals continued training even while suffering mortal wounds, and have reached a rank of B+ [EP: 8,000~8,500].

The most efficient division.

They have developed splendidly since fighting the Templars, and may soon reach A rank.

Though currently the most powerful are the Hiryyu, the Yomigaeri are capable of surpassing them.

As they cannot die, they are perfect for buying time.

And no, I did not choose them as my personal guard; the other members did.

Let me add: I will not issue them orders. They exist to serve them, and will, of course, obey every one of my words.

So did Shion happily report to me.

To be honest, it feels like I'm babysitting a bunch of uncontrollable kids... I can't tell her that, can I?

You know, you have to wear a façade at times like this.

Oh, but Shion will be issuing them orders.

They are her personal squad... her fan-club.

They are not a fighting force we mean to rely on, and their ability is rather unknown, but is this really okay? None of them will seriously die, I hope.

Shion has been raising them in secret, so I don't know how

powerful they are. Well, surely there are no more than a thousand of them, and they won't be on the front lines.

Dagrul's children will be the captains, as they performed admirably during the fight between Leon and Yuuki. I guess I can depend on them... maybe...

By the way, the Dwarf King has sent a formal letter of gratitude for Shion's assistance then.

Seems like she actually diligently carried out her duties then.

Such are the current state of military affairs in Tempest.

Then there's Diablo.

He left to travel with the words "I'll be searching for those worthy of following you!"

He helped resolve the matter with Hinata nicely, and he's getting more and more involved in domestic policies.

Sure, he loves to fight, and maybe that's what I should leave him to do.

But peace will surely return after we defeat the Eastern Empire, and I'd rather he focus on domestic affairs at that point. At the moment, he seems more interested than Rigurdo.

But that doesn't mean I can relax just yet. What if he suddenly goes out and creates an absolute monarchy around me or raises taxes to 90%? Life isn't a game where you can just mess around like that.

In summary, these are current Tempest forces:

Gobuta's corps: approximately 12,000 members.

Gerudo's corps: approximately 37,000 members.

Gabil's corps: approximately 3,000 members.

We number nearly ten legions strong.

But this is our entire standing army.

If you think about, the majority of the second corps are engineers who are not really fit for combat.

That does not mean that I think our army suffers numerically.

But it's not enough to counter the Eastern Empire.

For this reason, we have decided to send out "invitations" to nearby monsters.

At this point, every power under my domain has received an invitation. Their arrival is now but a matter of time.

Since figuring out their placement ahead of time may prove difficult, we may just have to do it once the war starts.

We do plan to resort to them only if we are unable to win with the standing army, but...

Oh, and we forecast the summoned to number roughly 50,000.

This shall become the Forth Corps, the Crimson Numbers.

Under Benimaru's direct control.

He has the 『Generalissimo』 skill he can use to control them effectively, so none are better fit than he.

Then there are the mercenary troops from the Council.

The fact that Tempest's defeat means the invasion and

destruction of every country neighboring the Jura forest forced the countries to give us their full support.

As such, mercenary troops from those countries just keep coming and coming.

Templar Knight Arnaud is overseeing them.

There are currently 30,000 such mercenary troops. If they keep coming I wonder if we'll be able to feed them all.

For the time being, we'll set up a garrison in the south-east border. Ruberius will guard the north-east border.

Northwest region is under no threat of invasion at the moment, so they left primarily border guards there.

Considering that 30,000 mercenaries sounds like too big of a number, I have a feeling that countries actually sent their knights here as well. The threat of complete destruction must have been that effective.

Arnaud concluded that

「I am of the opinion that the 30,000 have come from nearby countries. The rest have been delayed.

I think we could expect a total force of about 60,000 members here」

Knights and mercenaries of every country...

Add up to only that much... is that few or many, I do not know.

Last but not least, there's the adventurer's guarding the Adventurer's city inside our dungeon.

These volunteer soldiers risk their lives protecting the dungeon-city—so they are fools who keep getting killed by our avatars.

They too can be of use, so I decided to have Masayuki command them.

「Why me?」

He asked with a pained expression, but he's the kind of guy who can actually produce good results.

He's pretty reliable at times like this.

Oh, the volunteer troops number 10,000. There's a surprising number of them.

Well, considering that the Dungeon will be on hold—it will go in sleep mode, so people can't be slacking off there—this is for their own good.

We promised to take care of their sustenance, but there's rumors of a reward as well.

I have a feeling that Souei spread these rumors, but it just may be a good idea to pay them.

Thus our country's standing army of 50,000. The monsters in my domain, 50,000.

Mercenaries from other countries, 60,000. Adventurers 10,000.

Together we are a great host of 170,000 warriors.

We're currently only at 50% of the expected mark, but fret not, preparations proceed smoothly.

* * *

At the same time, the Empire was gathering strength.

For as long as Tempest, nay longer even, they have been

preparing.

And now they have finished their preparations.

And this Great Leviathan awoke, and in its rage caused great destruction...

Chapter 143: The Dreadful Corps

After summarizing the military formations to some extent, I headed over to Benimaru's room.

My purpose was to show the organization chart that I had just made.

While Benimaru had the authority to command, I held the supreme commanding authority and the authority to appoint rights.

Although it was complicated, originally, he also held supreme commanding authority, but he was relieved of that.

In terms of commanding the military, my amateurish self really shouldn't have any say in these kind of matters.

So all issues related to commanding the military are left to Benimaru.

As mentioned earlier, Benimaru's orders to the army take precedence over mine.

However, it was a different story for strategic commands.

Those are commands such as appointing generals before the war, and making the final judgment during the war.

Even if the number appointed was less than the number of the posts available for generals, it arbitrarily falls to Benimaru's jurisdiction without any problems, but the appointment of generals for the corps was left to my discretion.

Therefore, I handed the completed organization chart to Benimaru.

「Seriously? Gobuta, a general?」

As expected, that huh.

Certainly, I could agree that giving that idiot the responsibility of many lives was indeed an anxiety-inducing topic.

But I knew that for the sake of protecting this country, Gobuta secluded himself to do intensive training.

And above all, it may not look like it but the trust I had for my comrades was deep.

「It's probably alright. I see the natural qualities in him for this.」

「Oh well, I'll acknowledge it. Shall we give it a try?」

Benimaru nodded, seemingly convinced.

Nothing was said about Gabil.

Sure, Gabil got carried away easily, but even so, he had the right character to be a general.

He was considerate to his subordinates, and he also knew when to draw the line.

While strategic planning was clearly not his strong suit, his tactical judgments were precise.

Even if I gave him a troop there probably wouldn't be any problems.

Needless to say, Gerudo was a reliable general.

I made arrangements for the reinforcement of the lookout points in each location I had prepared against the empire's movement, and then I left Benimaru's room.

I should leave the trifling matters to Benimaru.

Benimaru is also busy.

He's been checking the assembly point for the monster soldiers and makes arrangements with Gerudo about the food distribution and so forth.

It won't be good for me to disturb him for a while.

Eh? How about giving him a hand? I have no idea what you're talking about.

Amateurs shouldn't interfere.

"Those are some convenient words", I immediately think so.

Now then, my destination after I leaving Benimaru's room was Ramiris' workshop.

I was going to check on the growth of the cultured golems

(magic dolls). I wondered if they had generated souls.

Once the golems were complete, if they could take independent action, it could possibly influence the war greatly.

There was no need for them to be ready right now, but it was still unknown if they would be ready for the upcoming war. Even so, just their existence would make a large difference.

Their strength was equivalent to 1000 A-rank.

If they were able to take independent action, their range of usage would expand greatly.

Well, even if they couldn't take independent action, when used collectively they could become the strongest corps surpassing an army.

So treating them like a golem corps of destruction that didn't even fear death was possible.

In that case, I was considering issuing simple commands to them and using them in a suicide attack.

I transferred through the space, and instantly arrived in Veldora's large room.

I opened the large door in the rear, went inside, and passed through it as usual.

Since there was no sign of Veldora in his private quarters, he must have been helping Ramiris again. He was probably conducting another stupid experiment with Ramiris.

And as expected, they were conducting stupid experiments inside.

It seemed like they were trying to integrate the core I had given them.

As always, Bester was recording.

Dino seemed to be working together with him, though there was a paper thin difference between working and playing.

He had been spouting nonsense about not wanting to work, but I guess there were things he had worked on without me knowing.

In the room, aside from the usual four, like Veldora and Ramiris, there was a guest.

It was the Dryad, Trainee-san.

「Well, well, well, Rimuru-sama. It's really been a while since we last met.」

Trainee-san greeted me.

As usual, she was a translucent bishoujo.

「Trainee-san, it's been a while. I want to thank you for your cooperation with the dungeon's management.」

「Now, now, you've given us a place to live in inside the dungeon...

And as a subordinate of Ramiris-sama, this much is a given.」

「No, no, it's still true that you've been a great help. Please take care of me in the future as well.」

I expressed my gratitude.

She had certainly been a great help when I asked her to help with the labyrinth's management.

By the way, what was she doing here?

The answer was,

「As I expected, a soul didn't dwell inside the cultured golem (magic doll).

And so, I was thinking of various ideas.

I could get them all to start activating by linking them to Baretta, but that would be a waste of treasure.

And then, it struck me!

I could place Dryads and Treants that are close to Spiritual life forms in a temporary body like that!

In fact, based off the data of the technological information we got from Sarion, it's like possessing a Homunculus.

That's why we've asked Trainee to conduct the experiment!」

She informed me.

I see.

It was hard to move around without possessing a body. It was possible for the Dryads, but there were severe limitations for the Treants.

Dryads were stronger than actual Devils, since they had a higher position in the upper echelons of A rank monsters.

However, there was the issue of magic leakage due to not having a physical body.

And so, when they were apart from the trees, which were their main bodies, they were unable to exhibit their true prowess.

If they used the cultured golems (magic doll), it would be possible for them to move around freely. This didn't just apply to the Dryads, but for to Treants as well!

In addition, the Treants could show their off strength, which

was equivalent to an A rank; and as for the dryads, they would be able to demonstrate their true power from a distant location.

It was a wonderful idea.

The experiment was a big success.

There was also no problem with compatibility, it seemed that tens of Dryads and hundreds of dozens of Treants would be able to obtain a new body.

It seemed the transfer was completed.

Trainee-san's role was to witness the transfer process during the experiment. After that, if there was a need to fix the appearance, she seemed to be trying her best to model them after her own figure as much as possible.

It seemed that Trainee-san was doing all of this on behalf of her sisters.

The Dryads had many female types, and the Treants had many male types.

Though they shouldn't have any gender, for some reason the differences in their outward appearance was clearly visible.

The Treants didn't seem to pay too much attention to the body's appearance, I'll have to say that the concern mainly originated from the Dryad sisters.

If you were talking about bishoujos, it was my turn.

I offered my cooperation because I could alter their appearance to some extent.

In the first place, it was going to be difficult to change the outward appearance without altering the skeletal structure.

As there seems to be a dozens of sisters, I remodeled and shaped the skeletal structure for each of the sisters while they conveyed their desired figures to me through the thought link.

Afterwards, I adjusted the flow of magic power and finished arranging the quantity of muscles, it was perfect.

As an extra service, I refined the skeleton with gold and made it possible for it to change into Orichalcum.

With this, it would be possible to adjust it to some extent in accordance to the owner's Will later.

In this world, gold was a versatile metal. Thus, it had a very great affinity and adaptability to magical power as well.

Though I couldn't use it en masse because it was a rare metal, it was fine to mix it with magic steel.

「Thank you very much, Rimuru-sama!」

In response to Trainee san's thanks, I replied with shaking and wobbling.

This much was nothing. It was also as thank for her usual aid.

「Then, I'll leave the rest to you guys. Ramiris, please inform me if it seems a soul will dwell in the golems.」

「Roger! I'll immediately come flying and inform you.」

After I asked her to inform me if a soul successfully formed, I returned to my office.

There was still some work left to do.

I wanted to help with the research there forever, but I didn't have the liberty to do so.

While the desire remained in my heart, I returned to my room.

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The Demon was unruly, it was trampling the demonic territory.

In the underworld, or as it was sometimes called, hell, in this spiritual world it defeated strong demons just like the incarnation of violence.

The powerless ones had long fled, and those with strength had banded together to fight it head on.

But for that Demon, the grief of the weak and worthless could not be heard.

That Demon completely destroyed its opponents, and continued to trample them calmly.

Demons were a spiritual life form.

Therefore, even if their bodies were destroyed, they would revive themselves through self-regeneration over time.

Maybe knowing this, that Demon didn't restrain itself and did not give mercy to those who came.

That Demon was the avatar of dreadful violence.

「Kufufufu. There was no chance for my defeat, even if all of you small fries gather like this.

That reminds me, a long time ago, there were several people who rivaled me.

Shall I give them a visit?」

Leaving behind those mysterious words, the red-haired

demon teleported from its position and vanished.

What remained were the remains of demons.

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I returned to my room, and check the construction of the surveillance system.

Intelligence agents were placed in important points of the Great Jura Forest, from the sea coast to atop the mountains, but even to that extend unease still remains concerning about the information gathering.

Or rather, it was expected that it didn't function well when

the actual fight began.

And so, I thought about whether it would be possible to use magic to monitor.

Magic of distance view series with purpose of observing was present in the Hex series.

However, the usability of it was poorer than I thought. It was only to the extent where I can check my target's appearance.

It was inflexible, and it could only monitor from one position.

To view from a different position, the magic must be invoked once more.

It's impossible to view the top guns like us demon lords. Since it would be repelled by the magic barrier we always erected.

And so, using the existing magic didn't go well.

However, I had an idea.

For example, the 〈Physics magic〉 "Megiddo (God's Wrath)"

It was magic that collected sunlight using floating droplets of water to converge it.

I could make the droplets of water float at various locations to transcribe the local situation and copy it.

Alternatively, I could copy the image from a high altitude then magnify the image and project it onto a monitor.

That meant I was creating a surveillance satellite with magic.

According to Raphael's answer, this could be possible with the utilization of 〈Physics Magic〉〈Spirit Magic〉 and 『Spatial

Manipulation』.

Afterwards, I made a detailed request, and made the arrangements for it with Raphael.

Once the surveillance system was completed, collecting information would be simple.

The amount of information I could collect would be enormous, and grasping the movements of the enemy's armies could be done easily.

During the Battle of Tsushima (Sea of Japan Naval Battle), the Russian Baltic Fleet was destroyed by the Imperial Japanese Navy under the command of the Commander in Chief of the Combined Fleet, Heihachirō Tōgō.

The most crucial aspect of this naval battle, was whether you could encounter your enemy or not.

To predict the point where the encounter was going to

happen.

If that had failed, Japan would have lost because the battle would have never occurred.

In other words, I could say it was quite similar to our current situation.

Since I dispersed our forces to various places and calculated the expected inferiority in the number of our forces, defeat was the most probable outcome.

Grasping the empire's movements and focusing our forces accordingly would be the decisive factor for victory.

If the empire dispersed their forces, using timely calculation, it would become possible for us to defeat them individually.

In order to turn the tides of battle in our favor and to ultimately grasp victory, the completion of this magic was crucial.

So, although the magic was already completed, I wanted to improve it.

Demanding Raphael-san to make this spell easy to use in a small place, I made a complaint like that.

Eh? Can't I do it by myself?

Don't be foolish.

Wisdom King Raphael was my ability. In other words, I could say I have been doing my best.

I might have been slightly overworked lately.

After I take a bit of a breather, let's use the finished surveillance magic.

Thinking that, I requested the maid, who was on standby in

the adjacent room, to prepare some tea.

Shuna would usually do it if she didn't have any errands, but when she was unavailable it would be this maid instead.

It was more than satisfactory.

Though the maid was a former goblin who had evolved into Goburina, her appearance was hardly any different from a human's.

Recently, light make-up had become a trend and they seemed to have become increasingly prettier.

She came carrying the prepared tea.

And then, after serving the tea, she bowed,

「Diablo-sama seems to have returned.

He requested an audience, what should I tell him?」

So she asked me.

I asked her to tell him to come here.

The maid bowed to me once, and then left my presence.

Apparently, she was still tense around me, her movement was stiff.

If it was Diablo or the other executives, they should be able to enter without reservation, but the surroundings prevented that.

That was the only problem.

Diablo came in while smiling.

I didn't know what he was going to say, but I could see wickedness in Diablo's smile.

Me aside, I think that for other people, it would be a symbol of misfortune.

He seemed like he was doing something really evil, but this was because he was clad in an evil atmosphere.

「Rimuru-sama, I have just returned.

I have brought people who would like to have an audience with Rimuru-sama today.

By all means, if it is possible for you to meet them, nothing would bring them greater joy.」

As usual, Diablo came to greet me in a reverential manner.

This fellow decided that I was his only master and he served me like I was a god.

In any case, the protégés or something like that, that he had said he was going to gather earlier, might be those people.

「Were there people who satisfied you?」

「Yes, though it was only about ten people.....」

I'm very sorry, I'm really ashamed by my own incompetence since I'm unable to prepare the corps.」

「Ah, no. Don't worry about it. Anyways, let's meet them.」

「Oh, thank you very much! Well then, I have kept them waiting.」

Did he seriously plan on making a corps?

He was a terrifying demon.

I walked behind Diablo while stealthy thinking about such things.

I wondered how far he was going to go, it seemed to be outside of Tempest.

「Kufufufufu.

Though it is possible for them to pass through the barrier, it would be a problem if the barrier accidentally broken.」

So, Diablo apologized, but what the heck are the people you're bringing along?

Using Leon's country as a reference, I had installed a mechanism that created a large barrier.

Thanks to this, the city was continuously covered by a defensive barrier that could differentiate between enemies and allies, and spread around the circumference of the city.

As for a big shot that could break it, that was only possible by a monster of disaster class beyond 'A' rank.

In addition, if it was going to be broken soon, it would immediately be handled by the sentry.

Non-intelligent 'A' rank monsters and the like, are already no longer a match for our country's soldiers who have high skill.

But, even among the devils, only high-ranking ones could destroy the barrier. This was because there was a large difference between passing through and destroying it.

Seriously, what the heck are the fellows he brought along? Were they really devil class?

「I allow you all to show yourselves. Manifest!」

Diablo issued an order when we stopped.

Ten demons appeared.

Hey, aren't three of them Arc Demons!?

Even with high-rank demon summoning, to summon Arc Demon was nearly an impossible task.

Anyway, one of them had the strength of a strategic class.

It was on the degree of whether preparing a big compensation and summoning them in the first time was possible or not.

If humans were to attempt to summon them, they needed a large-scale ritual on a national scale to do it.

And there were three of them.

That reminded me, Diablo was also originally an Arc Demon.

They might have been his acquaintances or something like that at that time.

The other seven were Greater Demons, but they seemed to be special individuals.

They had the dignified presence of great demon.

「These people were once my comrades...

Because they cried and swore that they wanted to be useful to Rimuru-sama by all means, I thought to allow them to accompany me.」

Diablo explained while smiling.

However, the part about them crying might be true, but the

part about them wanting to be useful to me was questionable.

After all, they still had traces of being beat up.

They seemed like wanted to say something, but they didn't utter a word.

It seemed like they had been given strict, detailed instructions by Diablo.

『We are the faithful servants of the Demon Lord Rimuru. We await your instructions!』

The demons bowed their heads simultaneously and swore their allegiance to me.

Diablo nodded, he seemed satisfied as he watched at the spectacle.

Truly, I was glad he was an ally.

What a terrifying fellow.

Well then, we had ten new companions, but because they are demons, spiritual life-forms that is, magic power was needed to manifest their physical bodies.

I see, they were especially made to wait in the outside for this.

Then, suddenly, I recalled the thing that Trainee-san had said a while ago.

Eh? It's should be okay for me to make them dwell inside the cultured golems, right? So I thought.

Let's implement that immediately.

First of all, I prey on the demons with Gluttonous King

Beelzebub. And I stored them in my stomach.

With Diablo, I transferred to Ramiris's Workshop.

I explained the circumstances to Ramiris and we let them dwell inside each golem in the capsules.

The result of their embodiment was a big success.

The demons drifted like they were asleep inside the magic water.

When they awakened, the embodiment would grant them a complete body, they might be useful then.

Oh yeah, it would be inconvenient if I didn't give them names.

Thinking that, I decided to give them names.

Because it was unpleasant when a large amount of magic power was consumed, I needed to be careful.

I looked at the amount and set a limit of once a day.

First of all, it was for Diablo's fight buddies, the three Arc Demons.

Each one of them was going to receive two Greater Demons as their respective aides.

One of them was a unique 'Stray'

It seemed he picked a fight with Diablo and was incidentally crushed by him.

That was the highlight of the people Diablo brought

Anyway, let's give them names.

Testarossa

Ultima

Carrera

Those were the names of the three Arc Demons.

While I was giving them names, their embodiments and evolutions were completed in an instant, and then, Demon Dukes emerged from the culture capsules.

Among the three of them, there was a beautiful female type.

When I first named it Testarossa, I was surprised since its evolution and birth immediately occurred before my very eyes, but as expected I got used to it.

Their ability was tremendously overwhelming and the

dimensions of their strength went beyond common sense.

「Is this for real! Aren't they more powerful than the former demon lords?!」

Moaned Dino, but Veldora and Ramiris were not shaken.

It might because of this, right?

“If it's Rimuru, it's natural, right!”

I ward off such a feeling lightly.

Bester who was in the corner was muttering,

「I don't see anything, hahaha, I don't know. I don't know anything, I'm unrelated.....」

While he repeated such incoherent grief inducing muttering,
he was rubbing his head.

I decided that I never saw that.

Next were the Greater Demons.

Venom

Veyron

Moss

Cien

Zonda

Agera

Esprit

I named them respectively.

These guys also instantly finished their evolutions and emerged from the culture capsules.

As powerful Arc Demons.

I felt I had acquired an unbelievable war force, but this was still just the beginning.

「Rimuru-sama, they couldn't endure the joy of you granting them wonderful names and power.

Please by all means permit me to pledge my loyalty to you later.

There is a request.

Our, the souls of the people who were the subordinates of this one...

If you can allow it, please let us use these dolls——」

I didn't know how many dolls he needed, but I decided to allow him to do it.

It seemed just perfect to let the souls of the Lesser Demons (Low-rank demon), dwell inside the cultured golems.

Though it was likely that they would become Greater Demons with their ability, even so there was no problem.

Because I had consumed a large amount of magic power, to go further and give them names seemed impossible, even so there was no issue.

Dozens of Greater Demons with abilities beyond A rank huh...

If it was a unique individual who was stronger than the average or weaker demons, it might be born as a stronger Arc Demon than the others.

I gave him permission while thinking that...

The Greater Demons seemed to have 100 subordinates each.

There were a total of 700 souls of Lesser Demons dwelling inside the cultured golems.

If these fellows gained physical bodies and emerged, it would only serve to increase their dreadful force.

No, normally, even with only ten demons.....

I may have done it again.

Let's feign ignorance.

It's all Diablo's responsibility.

I was irresponsibly sitting next to Bester and thought of such a thing.

After this, the demons that were born here manifested as Greater Demons.

Terrifying Greater Demons with abilities stronger than a devil's.

My prediction was correct, the Arc Demons that were just born were stronger than the summoned ones.

It had become an unimaginable corps.

Black Numbers (Black Corps): 700 people.

The group called themselves a corps even though their

numbers was the lowest.

They were the strongest unit in Tempest, the Symbol of Terror.

When the other demons emerged from the culture capsule, that time is the moment of the birth of the Black Numbers (Black Corps).

Intermission: Venom's Story

I don't remember my own name.

But what I do remember could be called the memory of my previous life.

It seemed to be the faint memory of when I was a human.

Apparently, I seemed to have been an orphan.

I went to a place called school regularly and was foolish...

Before I noticed, I was reduced to a fool who ruled over other people through violence.

As a result, I was stabbed to death by an opponent in a dispute.

By a common story, I think it was an appropriate end for me.

And so my life ended...I didn't know if it exist or not, but I was going to the afterlife, or I should have——

When I woke up, I was drifting in a place I didn't really know.

It was a world of full darkness, but strangely enough, things could be seen clearly.

I didn't feel hunger, and there was no such thing as pain and suffering.

I was a merely a drifting existence.

When I looked at my surroundings, I sensed similar drifting existences like me.

I wondered if those fellows had similar memories.

I didn't mind anything about my previous life and just drifted for a long time without doing anything.

In order to distract myself from boredom, I focused my consciousness onto the drifting existence that was similar to me.

From the bottom of my body, I could feel a power gushing forth.

I seemed to be exists as a mass of energy.

As in this darkness full of saturated energy, energy that overflowed from my body might not leak out.

How could I explain it so that it's easy to understand?

I couldn't explain it well because I didn't have the knowledge, but it was like crystallized sugar inside sugared water, I think that our existences were like that.

I was able to understand the usage of that energy unconsciously.

I could move in the direction I turned my focus on, without any sound.

I called out to the other consciousnesses.

However, there was no response.

The other party didn't have something that could be call a consciousness. It seemed to be a lump of power that merely existed.

It broke and scattered when I hit it because it was uninteresting.

It was a bit interesting, I remember having thought that.

After that, for a quite while, I spent my daily life searching for the drifting existences similar to me and destroyed them one by one.

The spectacle was clear to see as if it was daytime, despite the fact that light didn't shine inside the darkness.

I got used to such world, besides there was nothing else I could do, and so I kept doing the same thing every day.

Then a change came upon such a life.

I met a strange fellow.

「Yo, brother. Don't be so rough. Rampaging too much is boring too, you know?」

That fellow was different from the fellows without Will, he could speak in words.

I was surprised, and stared at that fellow without saying anything.

Words, well they weren't actually words, it could be understood to be Telepathy (Thought Communication).

However, I didn't even know that there was a person with Will at that time.

It couldn't be helped that I was surprised.

「Hey, hey, what's with that surprised face? Were you worked too hard by an unpleasant guy in the Surface?

If it was a disgusting Summoner, it's okay to beat him to death you know.

Or else, was the opponent too strong? If so, it can't be helped. Just give up.」

Saying such things, the fellow giggled.

A cheerful fellow.

After that, I learned various things from that fellow.

This world was the Underworld.

In other words, this world could also be called Hell.

It was the Spiritual World, the home of demons that didn't possess a physical body.

I was inside such world.

I seemed to be a Lesser Demon.

Demons are an existence like spirits or angels. It seemed to be

an existence that received power receives from the spirit of Darkness, and specialized in the demonic attribute.

Similarly, the Angel specialized in the holy attribute of the spirit of Light, the exception to this seemed to be called a Spirit.

To me, it was an unimportant story.

We didn't have personal names.

There seemed to be few people with names, even amongst the high-rank existences.

However, I wasn't troubled.

Because I could think, I could understand whether my consciousness was suited for it or not.

But because there was no name, there seemed to be little

attachment towards oneself.

There were some exceptions, if we were summoned several times to the surface, we could become an existence that possessed an ego after having contact with the world.

Summoning.

It means to be summoned to the material world from the spiritual world.

By obtaining a temporary body, the pleasures of the surface could be tasted.

That is smell, touch and taste.

I could collect enough information to control the world.

A summoned demon without an ego seems to be affected by

the personality of the Summoning master.

Various kind of information is received from the summoner's side.

According to the contents of the request, it seemed that I could obtain a lump of information called "Soul".*

We could evolve into higher beings if we collected a lot of "Souls".

Summoning is choosing one appropriate amongst many demons.

The place was close by, and a demon with the appropriate rank for the quest seems to be chosen naturally.

It seems we obtain considerable information once we are summoned.

First of all, an ego arises.

And we can get great power by being summoned many times.

That demon come and said to me,

「Hehehe, I've been summoned thrice you know? How many times have you been summoned, brother?」

I didn't know what was funny, but I heard it laugh frivolously.

Somehow, I was very angry.

I hit that fellow.

「Brother, what are you doing!?!」

That fellow hit me back in anger, and after that we fought continuously and exchanged blows for a few days.

Well rather than hitting each other with our fist, we were throwing energy at each other and making the other party accumulate damage.

In my mind, hitting is an appropriate expression.

In the end, there was no conclusion.

However,

「Yo, brother. You are strong. I will call you Aniki from today.」

Because that fellow understood, the fight ended.

Well rather than a fight, it was my one-sided burst of anger.

I wanted to go to the Surface too.

At that time I felt the desire increase intensely.

From that moment, the two of us became like brothers, and every day we kept picking fights with the other people.

A mindless demon is uninteresting.

Our targets were those that had egos and had experienced being summoned to the Surface multiple times.

Every day, we did nothing but——fight——battling.

But, there didn't seem to be someone as unusual as me, there were also some who had come from far away to pick a fight with me.

And before I realized it, my companions had reached 100 and

this area of the world became my turf.

Without becoming aware of it, I had evolved into a Greater Demon.

I noticed this when I instantly killed my opponent in a fight.

I felt that a great power, different from the one I had before, ran throughout my entire body.

I'm invincible.

So, I got too cocky that time.

I, who had evolved, acquired a Unique Skill 『Integrator』.

In conjunction with its progenitor—that I had since my birth—the Unique Skill 『Divider』, it was a skill with great utility

When I hit something, it broke into pieces. This seemed to be the result of the power of division.

I thought that perhaps this ability was produced due to the trauma of being pierced and cut down in my previous life.

Well, it was an insignificant issue.

If the opponent was not my equal, then they could not oppose my power.

Besides, it was easy to increase the number of underlings since it was possible for me to assimilate the opponent and then divide them.

It couldn't be helped that I got cocky, right?

And then, that guy appeared.

Since being in this world, I felt fear for the first time.

The existence of a genuinely strong being was carved into my soul.

A demon with red hair.

He appeared before us, and easily swept us away like we were just insects.

My followers and I were exterminated.

「Fumu. There's no resistance. Boring」

Along with fear, I felt hatred gushing forth from the depths of my heart.

My subordinates, my companions were...!

Amidst the anger, an ability awakened inside me.

《Confirmed. Acquisition of Unique Skill 『Regenerator』 ... Succeeded.》

Further than division and integration.

I experienced my astral body (spirit body) regenerating in an instant.

Die!

I looked down at that red-haired demon and with full with a flood of emotions,

「Oh? Do you still alive?」

“Wave of Division” that I fired was quickly dispersed, and my astral body was crushed into pieces.

Our statuses were too different.

After that, I regenerated once again and I swore revenge.

I continued to chase him many times and challenged that demon for a rematch.

「Kufufufufu. Interesting! There's still a person with backbone, huh?

Good.

My name is Diablo.

By the name granted by a great master, I will show you a little of my seriousness!」

End of World (World's Collapse)

At that time, I had certainly experienced the end of the world.

Originally, the likes like me was an “unneeded thing”, I was able to understand that there was no need to use it.

Ah, the status was too different.

But I’m not regretting it, I felt a feeling of satisfaction that I had not felt until now together with death...

But I never met with it.

When I manifested in the Surface world for the first time, I was summoned by that person, Diablo.

And in front of me was a monster.

If you compared it to the knowledge from my previous life, such a tiny being should be called a Slime.

However, towards that Slime, Diablo-sama, who should be an absolute existence, kneeled.

The reason was simple.

Even the foolish I could understand

That Slime was in a different dimension.

I could agree with why Diablo-sama praised it as “God” every day.

It wasn't an exaggeration, it was the unvarnished truth.

Like me, the people who received baptism from Diablo-sama, kneeled identically.

I understood that there was a person who was overwhelming superior to me, but I didn't mind this treatment.

Before Diablo-sama were people that weren't any different from me.

I could agree that it was natural.

『These people were once my comrades...

Because they cried and swore that they wanted to be useful to Rimuru-sama by all means, I thought to allow them accompany me』

Diablo-sama's voice resounded in the distance.

This person, for sure, will become our true master!

And so simultaneously,

『We, are the faithful servants of the Demon Lord Rimuru. We await your instructions!』

We pledged our loyalty to the “Demon Lord (God)” in front of us.

And, I even gained great power.

「Your name is, “Venom”. Well, please work hard」

Rimuru-sama spoke to me amiably in a carefree one.

And so I obtained it, a new name.

My name is Venom.

The demon who pledged his loyalty to Rimuru-sama.

I had achieved evolution and received a physical body in this world.

A new body and also a new power.

I became an Arc Demon (Superior Demon General), I had evolved into existence with a different class.

However, I realized one fact, even after obtaining this much power, the current me had yet to reach the feet of Diablo-sama.

But, I could still grow stronger!

In the capsule in the rear, my former companions were asleep in their newly obtained bodies.

People who would become my subordinates.

I would lead a unit under Diablo-sama's direct control.

A female type demon with scarlet hair named Testarossa was appointed as Diablo-sama's right hand.

She, who was originally powerful, saw her power increase just like I had.

The present me could not match her.

But, there was no need for me to be impatient.

I could still grow stronger.

And then, someday I'll become Diablo-sama's right hand and offer this world to Rimuru-sama.

My name is Venom.

A man who will someday stand next to Diablo-sama!

After that, Venom greatly increased in power, and was feared as a demon that exhausted and massacred hostile enemies.

Chapter 144: Underground Labyrinth Capture –Enforcer Scout Platoon–

Three people stood in a luxurious room with tense expressions.

Standing upright, they were waiting for the master of the room.

The master of the room was named Kagurazaka Yuuki.

The man who recently came to the Empire, who had, with surprising swiftness, reached the position of Corps Commander.

But to them, they thought it was natural.

After all, Yuuki was...

「Yo, I've kept you guys waiting! Though it was okay for you guys to take a seat while waiting for me...」

Yuuki entered the room while saying that.

Following behind him was Kagali, who was like his secretary.

「No, no, Yuuki-sama. We are your servants. There is no need for you to worry about us.」

One man answered as the representative.

The man's name was Damrada.

One of the Bosses of Cerberus, a secret society.

The three people here were the bosses of Cerberus.

「Hahaha, Damrada is stiff as usual.」

Yuuki urged these three people to sit down while warding off

laughter.

When they sat down in their seats as urged, Yuuki cut to the chase.

「So, Damrada. What is the situation in the Monster's Country Tempest?

How is the transition of the forces and the progress of technological development going?」

「Ha! Their forces are increasing day by day.

That country is already capable of supporting 200.000 people, it's likely that their internal development is complete.

The formation on each corps is also progressing, and there is a relationship with the committee, which is the council, and the new organization.

It could be said that the foundation of the Monster's Country Tempest has been stretched to include the other side of the Jura Great Forest.

The current number of organized forces is not below 50.000.

Their number is not a threat to the Empire, but their individual force is high, and their cooperation is good as well. It's not possible to make light of it.

In addition, the still increasing number of mercenaries and other forces should be factored in.

Their total number seems to reach 120.000~150.000.

Regarding their technological development, that is——

Currently, it seems it's not developed inside Tempest.

As for the barrier that protects the city, its purpose is to protect the citizens, and not to prevent a technology leakage.

But, the thing called “Magic Train” that began operating so suddenly has broken the common sense of transportation capacity.

It is most likely that its development might have been continued somewhere else.

Unfortunately, even me, as a merchant was unable to gather information about further technological development.」

「I see, even you as merchant. Were you able to determine the structure of their forces?」

「Yes. It seems they don't intend to conceal their forces.

It's greatly distributed and seems to have become two corps.

The First Corps is lead by General Gobuta, while the Second Corps is lead by General Gerudo.

Their official main force seems to be the Second Corps. However, this corps seems to be skilled in a certain aspect, and is called the construction corps.

As expected their main force was the First Corps.

It's a high-speed task force that is a gathering of many people with the high firepower flame ability.

While the Second Corps maintains the front, I believe they plan to have the First Corps trample the enemy. 」

「High-speed movement? Do they move by using horses or something else?」

「No, I only observed the military exercise by using a magic tool from a distance...

From the starting position where they were facing each other, the whole force moved at an impossible speed the moment the starting signal was given.

From a distance, their speed seems to be beyond a horse's speed.」

「Hee... You were interrupted by interference magic when you used magic for observation, right?

It seems like it's going to be difficult to grasp the situation in Tempest from now.

The information that you have brought back is valuable.

But, I don't believe that is all there is to their forces...」

「Ah, that reminds me...

Regarding that country's satellite town, the Labyrinth city.

There is a complicated building called a Dungeon, and the city built surrounding it.

There is a rumor circulating that says there is a city inside the Dungeon.]

「A city inside the Dungeon...」

「Yes. There might be a technological development base inside that city.」

「—— Indeed. Possibly, no.....it's certain when I think about it.」

Yuuki thought as much when he heard Damrada's report.

Their number of forces might really be that amount.

However, some doubt still remained in the details. Judging from the thought process of a Demon Lord like Rimuru, he felt that having just two corps was too few.

Besides, in that country, several abnormally strong devils existed.

Benimaru, Diablo, Shion, Gobuta.

These people were called the Shitennou (Four Heavenly Kings).

A corps being left under General Gobuta, who was assumed to be the weakest among the Shitennou, was suspicious.

No, if you said it was suspicious, all the devils of that country were suspicious too...

It was suspicious how people with strength equal to the members of the former Ten Great Demon Lords were under the rule of a single Demon Lord.

(Ah, as expected having failed to kill Rimuru-san is painful)

There was no use even in regretting it.

Yuuki suppressed a sigh and kept thinking.

There was no threat from the knights and volunteer soldiers gathering from the countries around the Jura Great Forest.

The number wasn't significant, and there was no threat even if they gathered.

But, the monsters that assembled from Jura Great Forest were dangerous.

Normally you could ignore such a disorderly crowd, but he thought that they would move more fiercely than expected if they were under the Demon Lord Rimuru.

In addition to that group, if they were strengthened by some kind of technology they developed, it was possible for the empire to receive an unexpected blow.

For Yuuki, it wasn't like he saw harm befalling his own subordinates a problem, but there was no reason that he should be unwilling to try to understand his opponents' forces.

「Vega, what do you think?」

Yuuki was just crossing his arms while listening to the report, and then he questioned one of the bosses of Cerberus.

Vega, the boss that symbolized the “Power” of Cerberus.

Vega nodded solemnly,

「We should just smash it. No need to worry at all! All the problems will fix themselves.」

He answered full of confidence while smiling broadly.

(This guy, his power is great, but his head is bad—or rather it's too bad—you see.)

Yuuki released a sigh in his mind, but he judged that idea to be acceptable as well.

Certainly, if he wanted to conquer the troublesome Dungeon, he should check its current state.

「Miranda, your idea?」

The last boss of Cerberus, the “Woman”, Miranda who governed over beauty.

She looked like a young girl, but also like a mature woman. She was a woman who emitted a bewitching charm.

「Is that so...

If the enemy Demon Lord has a gender, we don't need to worry about such a troublesome thing...

A plan to gather information on the technological development cannot be made since the place where it is being developed is unknown.

There is no one in charge who seems weak to a woman or a technician with loose-lips.

It's very unlikely that it will be useful to you in the war, although it's okay if you leave it to me to investigate...」

「No, I will investigate it sequentially.

That Demon Lord appears to be full of gaps, but he's unexpectedly cautious. He will not neglect to be cautious towards a stranger.

You stand out too much Miranda.」

「Ah, is that so?」

「Yes, then I'm going to rely on you, Miranda, about the Commander of the Armored Corps.」

「Will I do the same as always, infiltrate the Magic Beast Corps and wait for orders?」

「I ask you, Vega. Do not kill the Corps Commander since it's no good, ok?」

「I understood. I will put a great effort not to.

「Yuuki-sama, if allowed, how many people under you control may I borrow?」

「Ah, it's okay. Then, how about you choose at your own

discretion from the 100 people?」

「Yes, I would be my pleasure.」

The talks about capturing the Dungeon was settled, and the three leaders retired from their seats.

The only ones remaining were Yuuki and Kagali

Actually, the preparation for war were already complete, the only thing left to do was to investigate the enemy's movement.

Yuuki had more freedom compared to the other generals, since he had the duty of information gathering.

「Nee, Yuuki-sama. Will they dance well?」

「Who knows, they might.

Though If the incitement goes well, we should be able to spread the ravages of war as planned.」

「But, we came here at last. The war will begin soon.」

「Ah, is that so. We need to reap death wonderfully.」

And then the two laughed wickedly.

Their objective was not the victory of the Empire.

Yuuki's intention and the Empire's interest matched, but their relationship was only that.

It shouldn't be misunderstood, but Yuuki felt that he didn't hold any responsibility towards the Empire's victory.

It was just that he thought that an investigation of the inside the dungeon was necessary.

It was certain that there were traps and devices in there, but running into them in the labyrinth was an insignificant issue when it came to the destruction of the world.

An investigation should be done to find an opening for conquest, though it was only a simple idea...

In the end, because of that idea, the underground labyrinth capture group would bring back an unexpected report, but that wasn't something that Yuki knew.

When Yuuki had decided on the underground labyrinth's capture, similar information was given about the Monster's Country Tempest to the Empire's Intelligence Bureau.

Yuuki's subordinates had begun to move towards Tempest as well.

First Lieutenant Kondou, who received the information, was a

taciturn person.

「Is that so? Good work.」

Those were only words that came from his mouth to one who reported the information to him. He didn't make any further remarks.

He was not a man that expressed his thoughts to others.

With his trimmed short black hair, he emitted a tense atmosphere.

His expressionless eyes gleamed with a sharp light, like they could see through everything, and pierced the other party.

He was a young man. His youthfulness could be seen as he still in his early 20s.

However, there was no gentle light in his eyes, and a cunning intellect could be felt from him.

It was no wonder.

Kondou Tatsuya, also known as First Lieutenant Kondou's, age did not match his appearance.

Kondou Tatsuya was an "Otherworlder".

In this Empire, "Otherworlders" were not unusual. One big reason for this is that the Empire had a policy called the Protection of the "Otherworlder".

Tatsuya was one of the people saved by that policy.

There was magic in this world, therefore it could be said that his life was saved.

Because he had gambled with death and made a suicide attack towards the enemy army when he arrived in this world, he had received innumerable bullets and was the verge of death.

He was lucky.

By chance, he had landed in the Empire's capital, and happened to pass nearby the Empire's Magician Leader.

Tatsuya life was saved by that good fortune. Then he swore to devote the life he had once thrown away to the Emperor.

So around 70 years had passed, but he had not aged.

He had decided not to appear on the front stage, and lurked in the Empire's shadow. Inside the Information Generalization Headquarters, since his figure remained eternally young.

The magician who had saved him was dead.

He took Tatsuya as his disciple, taught him all his magic, and then he departed from this world. Now Tatsuya was managing the people.

Thus, only several of his trusted subordinates and the Emperor knew of his existence.

The Mysterious man obsessed with information.

A Lurker in the Empire's shadow.

A human, subduer of demons.

He knew that he was feared and had received various names, but it had no effect on him since he didn't associate with others.

His rank as First Lieutenant was not actually accurate.

In reality, he was given a high-ranking position by His

Majesty the Emperor.

But, he was the “First Lieutenant”.

Because he doesn’t want to forget the memories of his subordinates that fell together with him in his previous life—or rather, in his former world—so he remained a First Lieutenant.

The existence of First Lieutenant Kondou, who was the director of the Empire’s Intelligence Bureau, couldn’t be disregarded, even by the Corps Commanders.

However, as his true character was unknown, he was a feared person.

Well, there was another reason why there were many “Otherworlders” in the Empire.

That was because there were many people who had been summoned.

The person who defected to the Empire, the former leader of Freedom Association (Guild Master), Kagurazaka Yuuki.

The reason his defection was so easily accepted was because he had sent the “Otherworlders” which he had sheltered before to the Empire.

They numbered 100 people.

There were many who possessed Unique Skills in that group of 100 people, and many of them belonged to the Imperial Guard’s Army.

Yuuki had said that he had found them by chance and had protected them, but according to the investigation, that was a lie.

Though his appearance was that of a young boy, his action were like those of a veteran.

Like First Lieutenant Kondou, you could deem him a

dangerous person by his appearance.

Kondou concluded that the reason why Yuuki was able to prepare so many “Otherworlders” was through Summoning.

To summon people using magic was inefficient, though it depended on the individual’s ability. But, making the summoned pledge their loyalty was possible if the summoner was capable of etch it on the summoned’s soul at the time of summoning.

Summoning was the most suitable way to get loyal subordinates.

In reality, there was no error in First Lieutenant Kondou’s anxiety.

It wasn’t on all of the members, but surely an order had been given to some of them at the time of summoning.

There might also be a person among them that had a different

intent, like the Hero Masayuki, a summoned person that couldn't be controlled completely by the order.

Because he had a strong power, Yuuki didn't even mind that he couldn't control him completely, and just sent him to the Empire as he was.

However, a case likes Masayuki's was unthinkable.

He was not very useful, and it was expected that he would not obey orders, so some measures were given to put him in line.

Although First Lieutenant Kondou didn't know the circumstances, he had guessed that from Yuuki's speech, conduct, and movement in this one year, and he realized the danger of the people that Yuuki had sent.

Such perception was too accurate, it could even be called a fearsome insight.

The investigations on the other Corps Commanders were not

as interesting as Yuuki's.

The system of the Empire is 『Power is everything』.

Therefore, there is no one who criticized Yuuki openly.

There were few people who could complain about Yuuki, who had reached one of the tops of the Empire.

So the First Lieutenant Kondou thought.

(You are dangerous, Kagurazaka Yuuki. You are an existence that should be removed)

It was better if it was in another army, but it was a problem if the people who belonged to the Imperial Guard's Army that ought to protect His Majesty, the Emperor, had already sworn their loyalty to another person.

This matter couldn't be brought to light yet.

But, the moment Yuuki showed an unnatural movement, that was when he would die.

Because First Lieutenant Kondou, a lurker in the Empire's shadow, never forgives a traitor.

「You should become as cocky as you could. Since your life is already in my hands.」

A ruthless light appeared in his eyes as the First Lieutenant Kondou muttered that calmly in the Empire's shadow.

In response to Yuuki's command, three people were selected.

From amongst Yuuki's 100 subordinates, the chosen people

were required to be from the Mixed Corps.

It was said that only coming from another world would get you a high position in the Corps, the Empire was not naïve.

But the 100 people whom Yuuki had chosen only possessed Unique Skills that excelled in combat ability.

Therefore, they hid in each corps, living while concealing their fangs.

They had all received Yuuki's order to revolt together, and to seize each other's corps.

Now that Yuuki had seized the Mixed Corps, everyone thought that the day was near.

Meanwhile, there were three people who couldn't hide their bewilderment for the unexpected dungeon capture order.

Before long, the Empire was going to invade the other side of the Jura Great Forest. It was natural for them to be doubtful about capturing the Dungeon during such a time.

The coup d'état (military revolt) by Yuuki's subordinates was planned to happen when the Empire began the invasion, and after some of the front-line had finished spreading.

As a result, the Empire would instantly fall under Yuuki's control, and he was going to start the world conquest using its might.

They had received such an explanation from Yuuki.

The three people,

Tanimura Shinji

Mark Lauren

Zhen Liu Xing

Flared up at Damrada's unexpected order.

「Hey, hey, Ossan. We were called for the Labyrinth Capture (Athletics)....

Don't joke around! Or rather, you are making fun of us?」

「Well just wait, Mark. Yuuki-san may have some kind of plan?

Please tell us what you know, Damrada-san.」

Calming the raging Mark, Shinji asked Damrada.

The 100 people were battle elites, each possessing a Unique Skill.

Their pride was high, and they were looking down on Cerberus.

However, they acknowledged the superiority of Vega, who was a boss symbolizing “Power”. But, there were few people who respected Damrada whose specialty seemed to be calculating money.

Among those 100 people, Shinji was relatively close to Damrada.

This time too, he had volunteered for the role in order to pacify Mark who was venting his anger on Damrada.

Zhen Liu Xing, this man was taciturn, and what he was thinking was unknown.

But, he could certainly understand what was been said. His braided black hair rested down his back, and he wore Chinese styled clothes similar to Damrada.

Various hidden weapons seemed to be concealed inside his clothes.

Shinji naturally realized that he had gathered this team.

There was unease, but these three were the members of the labyrinth capture group—their Official name was Enforcer Scout Platoon.

That's why Shinji, as the team leader, asked Damrada that.

Damrada explained the situation.

Since the inside of the labyrinth was unknown, this investigation was in preparation for the coming war.

There was a possibility that some secrets were hidden inside the labyrinth.

It might not be a issue, even if it was ignored, but the investigation was for the sake of caution.

(No, Yuuki-sama actually seemed to have another intention.

That's not something that should guess. I better not say something careless.)

Shinji decided that it was unnecessary to daringly ask about everything and Damrada finished his explanation.

However, the explanation of Demon Lord Rimuru's dreadfulness and wariness was intentionally repeated many times.

The labyrinth was created, by that Demon Lord in full confidence.

As far as Damrada was concerned, he hadn't heard any stories of it having been captured yet.

It was only a rumor, but the Hero Masayuki had broken through to the 30th floor.

「Please don't neglect to be cautious.」

「Hey, Ossan! Are you underestimating us?」

「Now, now, Mark. Please wait.

Damrada-san, I understand the conversation. Can I ask for a guide?」

「Ah, guiding and assistance on the other side are left to me. We leave once the preparations are complete.」

「Understood」

The next day.

The group, guided by Damrada, went to the Transfer Magic Formation.

Could these three really capture the labyrinth?

Damrada was more worried about whether the capture was even possible, rather than what was hidden inside the labyrinth.

But, he didn't say it.

He understood that it would only be a complaint even if he said it.

It was better to encounter some bitter experiences, so Damrada thought.

And so, the challenge to the labyrinth from the Empire by the three members of the Enforcer Scout Platoon began.

Chapter 145: Underground Labyrinth Capture –Capture of Irresistible Force–

The report both surprised and shocked us.

It was about the appearance of people who finally captured the Dungeon's 50th floor.

Certainly, this year the adventurers had improved their skills considerably.

Groups that were able to capture the 30th floor had gradually begun to appear. The devised floor capturing strategies used the phenomenon known as barely escaping death, Zombie Attack Plan (Coming back from death Strategy) or Abandoning Scapegoat Plan (For Glory Strategy) and so forth.

There were people that used a frontal attack as well, accompanied by the proficiency of their skill and the improvement of their equipment, they also had their ability improved.

But, after the 30th floor, not only was there a trap that killed everyone at the beginning, the monsters also came groups and fought together.

It becomes difficult to handle that when using the unorthodox capturing methods.

So, the most recent leading capture group was mimicking the capture method that Masayuki and his party used against the guardian of the 40th floor but...

The guardian of 40th floor was Tempest Serpent.

It was the black snake I had met way back in the beginning. It had breath attack that was effective against groups, and many people had watery eyes after their equipment was destroyed by it.

Then, because I was nice, I kindly rent them equipment with the Tempest crest.

They would need to compensate us if they broke.

Well~ the earnings they got till now were completely deprived, we thought that it was a reliable guardian that would bring us a wonderful fortune.

If a person that could defeat it appeared, then...

Besides, the guardian of the 50th floor was Gozurl. He was violence incarnate when his restraint were removed.

After all, Gozurl wasn't weak. Either way, maybe thanks to the restraints placed on him while on the 30th floor, he was able to come up with a creative way of battling for this floor.

The old, foolish Gozurl, that only depending on his own strength, had disappeared.

It was the same with Mezurl. Wracking his brains together with Gozurl, the two devised their fighting style by discussing with each other.

Before we were aware of it, the arguments they would hold whenever they met were now forgotten, and the two had become close friends now.

The two alternated guarding the 50th floor.

I remembered that I set the equipment drop to 100% for the first time win only, as a reward in case someone was able to defeat them.

It was a unique class equipment, the Minos series.

It was equipment that boasted very nonsensical power named after the ruler of labyrinth, Minotaur.

The weapon was either a Minos Bardiche (Cow-Head Devil's Battleaxe) or a Minos Trident (Horse-Head Devil's War Spear).

There was no shield. After that was the pieces for a complete set of armor.

It was the jewel which Kurobee's best disciples had used the best of their ability to create.

Because I believed that there wouldn't be many people capable of reaching this place so easily, I had only prepared 10 sets, and no more.

In the first place, Gozurl and Mezurl had become stronger after I gave them names, so if a person capable of defeating them appeared, I might scout them.

Because of this, I had arranged that an emergency message would be sent if they were defeated.

Either way, if a lot of adventurers attacked them in waves, the two would accumulate fatigue and be defeated.

But no matter the methods the adventurers used to defeat them. I wanted to know about the people that manage to defeat Gozurl and Mezurl.

In case they didn't want to be scouted, there was a possibility that the other party was hostile.

This time as well, were they attacking in waves because of Masayuki's charisma?

When I thought so, my expectations were overturned.

In the report, it was said that Gozurl was defeated by just three people.

Furthermore, they weren't people that had been active recently, they seemed to be newcomers that had arrived recently.

It was necessary to promptly collect information on the newcomers.

That was why I cancelled the long awaited test-run of the improved surveillance magic, and went to the command room that had been prepared inside the labyrinth.

When I entered the room, Ramiris and Veldora were there.

Dino and Bester seemed to have taken a day off today.

Disregarding Dino, Bester had accumulating fatigue since he had come to this place recently, so it was just perfect for him.

Ramiris and Veldora were full of energy. These two people were probably strangers to the concept of tiredness.

It was the so-called “children’s stamina.”

If children were doing things that they were interested in, then they wouldn’t get tired at all.

「Oh, you came, Commander! There's no change in the situation today!」

I didn’t understand what was it that hadn’t changed.

Perhaps, she might have said it because it suited the mood.

I looked at the picture projected onto the big screen.

Projected onto the screen were three youngsters.

It seemed they traversed the floor with like an unstoppable force. The way they fought was really unique as well.

With a clearly abnormal throwing power, there was a person that grabbed air and threw it.

He had a large, sturdy build, and brown hair. With his fine, chiseled features, he had a considerably good appearance.

He wasn't wearing heavy equipment like iron armor, instead he was wearing chain mail made from weaved steel fiber, and a coat over it.

They all looked pretty much the same.

The skinny one had concealed his entire body with a pitch black robe, another one seemed to be wearing a white robe over the chain mail.

He looked Asian, and the white robe was the kind often seen in hospitals.

In every aspect, he was Japanese-like. Without a doubt, he seemed to be an "Otherworlder".

A group of six Death Wolves (Ghost Wolves) came running. With a speed that typical adventurers couldn't perceive, the wolves closed the distance in a dash.

It seemed to have judged the situation instantly from a distance, it would only receive attacks one-sidedly.

As expected of the monsters above the 50th floor. Even a monster that looked like a small fry had considerable

intelligence.

By the way, one Death Wolf is considered B+ rank, so it spelled trouble if six of them gathered.

It was also a Ghost-type monster with the trait of nullifying damage if they weren't attacked with a Holy attribute weapon or a Magic weapon.

Even if its body vanished, it would regenerate immediately. So even just one wolf was dangerous if you didn't possess the countermeasure for it.

You would be devoured instantly if careless...

「Don't underestimate me, you dogs! Uoryaaaa!!」

The one with brown hair who had been grabbing and throwing air until now, took out an ominous battleaxe and swung it powerfully.

With one sweep, three Death Wolves turned into light particles and disappeared.

Ah, that ominous battle axe, I soon remembered that it was Minos Bardiche.

It was a Unique class equipment, and naturally, it belonged to the Magic weapon category.

Even if someone couldn't cast magic, it was still possible to damage a monster with the magic power possessed by the weapon.

Furthermore, this was related to the raw materials used to make the Minos series. Silver that had been mixed with Demon steel and turned into Mithril.

It was a specialized weapon that could easily inflict a great deal of damage to Undead-type and Ghost-type monsters.

「Ah, if it's Minos Bardiche, then Death Wolf will be defeated

in one blow.」

「Yeah. That weapon is the thing that Gozurl dropped.

The combat sense and weapon adaptability of the person that picked up the weapon seems to be great.」

Veldora agreed with my grumble.

After that, I heard the story of their battles until now while observing their combat style.

As for the snack, nowadays, I preferred potatoes.

Based on the story I heard about them, their battles until now were mostly of that brown-haired guy defeating the enemy.

I saw it myself and understood it. The brown haired guy was certainly strong.

But, what happened to the various traps in the labyrinth?

Regarding those, the black robed guy smoothly discovered them, and seemed to have told his friend their position.

As for incomprehensible traps or tricky traps, those were a crucial part from the 50th floor and below.

As if he could see it, the black robed guy precisely indicated the trap's location.

I was certain that it was some kind of ability. You could say that he was an indispensable person for capturing a labyrinth.

The last one was the white robed guy, his turn had only come up once until now. That was during the fight against Gozurl.

I had seen the footage through the Thought Link, but I was certain that this fellow was also someone with a Unique class ability.

He had taken out syringes from his pocket, and given them to his two companions.

Immediately after that, Gozurl's movement had rapidly become dull.

He might have received some kind of abnormal status, but as Gozurl's movements became dull, he became an easy mark for the brown-haired guy.

The one who landed the finishing blow was the white robed guy.

He had taken out a scalpel that shone silver, from his pocket, and in an instant, he had cut the blood vessels on Gozurl's nape.

I noticed that he was from the intelligence faction, which assesses the situation and takes the time to wait for a change in the situation, unlike a muscle head that didn't think about anything.

Their party was very balanced.

《Notification. The result of the analysis is in. The attack that “Individual: Gozurl” received was something similar to a neurotoxin.

The room was filled with poisonous gas, the poison obstructs the movement of those who lack immunity to it. There is no remaining effect now.》

Ah, poisonous gas.

And in addition, he seemed to be able to come up with strategies that worked against the enemy, on the spot.

I considered the results of the analysis, which Raphael had made based off of the data, which remained in the air.

I’d guessed based off of his white robe, but there’s probably no doubting that was a medical-related Unique Skill.

At that time, I heard a knocking sound from the door. Then the door opened, and Shuna entered the room.

She came in holding an entry paper, which had the registered information of the three from the Adventurer's Guild, which had become a branch of the committee.

「This is the registered information of the three that succeeded in capturing the 50th floor.」

Shuna handed over the paper after bowing.

I received it with a nod and confirmed its contents.

Shinji 23 years old, Wizard

Mark 26 years old, Warrior

Zhen 17 years old, Hunter

So, only the minimum information had been filled out.

Their place of origin was a small country near the Empire, the reason for coming here that was written on the paper was that they had heard rumors about the Dungeon from a merchant.

Well, well, that was a lie no matter how you looked at it.

If I recalled correctly, Magicians needed to make a contract with spirits to use magic —— Sorcerers handled chants based on their knowledge of elements—— Wizard was a high-rank job that needed the expertise of both jobs.

It was a lofty, and difficult, occupation that not everyone could attain.

Warriors were similar in that they needed both the expertise from the Fighter job and the Swordsman Job, because a Warrior was a close combat expert capable of using every type of weapon.

Obviously, it wasn't an easy occupation to attain.

We arrived at the last one, a Hunter. This occupation could be called the peak for those who hunt monster. It was an occupation that relied mostly upon, and belonged to, the subjugation guild.

In this world, there were few people with excellent skills in detecting traps or monsters with the Thief job.

That was because, currently, Thief really meant thief in the truest sense.

Meanwhile, calling oneself a Hunter was possible since there was no native hunting tribe here.

Certainly they were a good, balanced party, but if it was true that they had come from the Empire, without a doubt, they were Spies.

However, were they foolishly honest enough to have written

the truth?

They might have done that, but I thought that there were other choices, like they could have decided to say that they came here from the Demon Lord territory under Milim's rule, or from another continent under Leon's rule.

Oh well.

The truth didn't matter, there was one person which I surely needed to pay attention to.

The black-haired, white robed, young man, Shinjy.

Instead of Magic, he was using a mysterious ability.

Or rather, Shinjy... no matter how you looked at it, it was Shinji.

The brown-haired guy was Mark.

He had not only thrown air bullets and monster's corpses, but falling rock as well...

Anyway, it seemed he could throw anything as long as he could grab it.

He grabbed a living monster and threw it, inflicting damage to both enemies, and defeated them together, which almost made me spew out the tea.

But it seemed his being a Warrior was not a lie, since he handling Minos Bardiche skillfully.

The black robed guy was Zhen.

This guy seemed to have eyes capable of seeing through traps perfectly.

In the beginning I had thought that his intuition was sharp but it seemed to be Sense Danger, Sense Monster, and Sense Trap. With all of those, he managed to evade everything beforehand.

He looked at the places with traps, and conferred their location to his friends, and I was certain that it wasn't a coincidence.

Originally, on the 50th floor and beyond, there were increasingly brutal traps that became the main threat instead of the monsters' strength.

Without looking strange, the room could have been filled with Ghost-type monsters, had its air pressure changed, been without oxygen, or had poisonous water.

Like that, I had set traps of a dangerous level to prevent the capture of the dungeon, but everything was seen through by him, so they were all useless.

Moreover, his sense of direction was also excellent. He wasn't

deceived by the floor's rotation and the like, and easily advanced using the shortest route.

Obviously, a maze wasn't effective.

If there was an injury, the white robed youth, Shinjy, could easily treat it.

Although they were just three people, they were people specialized in capturing labyrinths.

However, the three of us joyfully watched their method of capturing the dungeon.

No, there was no way that we would use them as a reference for when we were going to capture the dungeon, or anything like that, don't you think like that!

Hey, you over there, I was only honestly praising the strong person's way of fighting.

Shuna poured the three of us another cup of tea while astounded.

The tea today was Black Tea with the pleasant fragrance of apple.

Starting from the 50th floor was the real thing, but the degree of difficulty didn't change even if there was someone that hadn't activated the trap until the 50th floor.

If that was so, I thought that to truly test their ability, I would use the result of whether they could defeat the 70th floor's guardian or not.

The guardian of the 60th floor was the Ghost King Adalman.

It was a high-ranking Undead King that looked like a polished skeleton.

It was a high-ranking Priest who had gone to purify the dead spirits that had gushed forth from the remains of a battlefield in

Jura Great Forest, but he had become the shadow of his former self after becoming an undead, because of an undead's abnormal status, that is, undeadification.

But, as a result, Priest Adalman had become an Undead with enormous magic power, though it was a case of the tail wagging the dog.

It had become the King of Ghosts with that magic power, and seemed to spend its time quietly in a cave.

When I assumed the position of Demon Lord, I specially went to greet him. At that time, it was almost purified, it wasn't a funny story.

That him, was guarding the 60th floor.

Unfortunately, I believed that those three were at a disadvantage.

Ghost King Adalman had a fighting power beyond A rank

[EP:44,000].

Naturally, he had a higher rank than Gozurl and Mezurl.

His strength was not on par with the devils, but it couldn't be helped since its weak point was too obvious.

He was awfully weak to the Holy attribute and Light Attribute.

He was an extremely troublesome being if you fought it seriously since it could summon Ghost Knights and Ghost Wolves endlessly—If he attack a town, he would be acknowledged as a Disaster—Although it could be said that they also shared the same attribute weakness.

Therefore, for this floor, since they would have gotten used to the traps, I had set an easy to clear boss.

The people who were able to defeat Gozurl and Mezurl using only brute force, may defeat it easily if they only paid attention

to the attribute's weakness.

Moreover,

「It was a mistake, with Minos Bardiche they could defeat an enemy with one blow...

That thing was made from Holy attribute Mithril, it delivered double the damage to Undead-type and Ghost-type enemies.」

「Because of the limited, first-time-only, service, or something like that, they got a bit cocky, right?」

So.

I did something bad to Ghost King Adalman.

Unfortunately, he wouldn't be capable of stopping those three.

Well it might have been my fault, but I hoped he could forgive me.

So, as I thought that, I was looking forward the guardian of the 70th floor.

Chapter 146: Underground Labyrinth Capture –Outcome and Conclusion–

Perceiving that invaders has entered his domain, the Ghost King Adalman curled his meatless lips.

Then, he made noise by grinding his teeth slightly.

It was hard to understand it, but it could be said that the Ghost King Adalman was grinning broadly, and sneering.

「You seems to be in a pretty good mood, Adalman-sama.」

The man, who was a Holy knight, and his trusted confidant, greeted Adalman.

He was a ghost, and didn't have a physical body. However, he stood with a figure unaltered from when he still alive.

Though he had been transformed into a ghost, which was

considered a monster, he hadn't possessed any humans or monsters, but had construct his body, which was the same as when he was alive, from a multitude of corpses.

As for Adalman, he didn't have any attachment to his body when he was alive, though he was rather pleased with his current figure, which had become mere bones.

While Adalman's trusted confidant, who was the former Holy Knight Commander, may have had some attachment and pride towards his appearance during his lifetime.

It was because his appearance had the refreshing ——Though it was strange to say that a Ghost was refreshing —— facial features of a young man.

But from the blue will-o'-wisp that flew around him, and his pale skin, it was clear that he wasn't alive.

「Yeah, I'm in good mood. Guests seem to have come, Albert.」

He informed his confidant, the former Holy Knight Commander Albert, of the presence of invaders.

He respond,

「I see, did they finally come?」

Understanding everything, Albert—who was now a Death Paladin (Ghost Holy Knight) —nodded joyfully.

In the past, they had gone to conduct a purification with good will to prevent the outbreak of a large-scale dead-spirits disaster in the battlefield in The Jura Great Forest.

In doing so, Priest Adalman and four holy knights had gone together, but they had encountered an unexpected situation.

When they had arrived at the battlefield's remains, a Dragon Zombie (Carrion Dragon) an atrocious monster, was living there.

Although they had succeeded in defeating the Dragon Zombie after a desperate fight, they had used up all of their strength there.

There was no one to come rescue them, since they hadn't acted on the orders of the church, but based on their own convictions.

Thus, their fate was sealed, but their hearts, which wished for the peace of the Great Jura Forest caused a miracle.

Well rather than a miracle, it might have been a disaster for them though...

Adalman's group transformed into ghost after receiving the curse of the dead, and a large amount of magic essence .

However, with their strong willpower, Priest Adalman and Holy Knight Commander Albert succeeded in keeping their egos.

Priest Adalman became a Undead King, the king of ghosts.

Holy Knight Commander Albert became a Death Paladin.

And his three subordinates became Death Lords (Ghost Knight Leader).

The Ghost King Adalman who, had acquired the abilities of a Necromancer (Dead Ruler), was dominating the dead spirits in the surroundings, and stayed inside a cave.

That was an old story from more than several hundred years ago.

The rules of time didn't apply them, who had become undead, so the number of years that had passed couldn't be confirmed.

But, he noticed the birth of the new ruler of Jura Great Forest.

It was natural.

After the disappearance of the Storm Dragon Veldora, he had sent his subordinates to gather information, since he had expected the forest to become turbulent.

The result, he chose to subject to the new Demon Lord. As things were, he had become its subordinate.

「Yeah. The time for us to become useful for Demon Lord Rimuru-sama, who gave us peace, has finally come.

If it's in this labyrinth, I can employ the deceased as I like, unlike during the long cave life, this place is overflowing with excitement.

We must make proof of our loyalty for our “God,” that has bestowed us with such a wonderful environment.」

「Yes! This Albert, understands.」

Adalman nodded to Albert's response with a 「Yeah」.

His faith had died once before; Demon Lord Rimuru was chosen as the new target of his faith.

Of course Rimuru didn't know that.

Rather, Rimuru was thinking 『I'm sorry, I don't think you guys can win』 or something like that, but Adalman and his group didn't know that, since they were in high spirits.

Right now, they intended to bring victory to their new master.

Looking at each other's faces, and nodding, Adalman was burning with motivation, Albert was also the same.

And so, they began to think of countermeasures against the coming foolish invaders. -----

The three people, who came from the empire, were smoothly proceeding with the capture.

After parting with Damrada, and entering the Labyrinth City, they had registered in the guild there.

They had collected some information beforehand, but they had felt that the playful contents of the dungeon were mostly a heap of game elements.

However, this place was where Zhen Liu Xing's Sense Trap shone.

As for the monsters' strength that he had heard about from the stories, they didn't seem to be a big deal.

The problem was that the depth of the dungeon was unknown.

To advance, capturing the labyrinth in one go was a no-go, as there was a limit to the amount of food that could be carried.

But, such a worry,

「Ah, it's alright. When you find the stairs, there is a doorway to an inn.

It's possible to stay in that place. So, there's no problem even if we don't bring much food.

In addition, we could sell things that we don't need there, since there's merchant in that place, you know?」

So, it was really satisfactory.

Moreover, there seemed to be an item called “Bracelet of Revival”.....

「It's seems we are able to revive even if we die inside with this....」

Mark and Zhen looked doubtful when Shinji explained what he heard.

How to put it? In this serious world, it was only in here that the world was full of jokes, it was a very hard to describe feeling.

Since they were “Otherworlders” too, in this world possessing an ability would garner you favorable treatment.

However, it wasn't to the degree that you could do as you liked in this country.

Yuuki was considerably doing his best regarding improvements to the food problem, that also dealt with the circulation of goods in the Empire, but this place seemed to have surpassed that.

Takoyaki, Okonomiyaki and Yakisoba. On top of that, recently even Crepes were about to be made.

Stalls were crowded and lined side-by-side.

The toilet problem was also dealt with perfectly, and the comfort of the inn was also wonderful.

「Should I live here? Say, shall we not return to the Empire?」

「Hey!」

「No, sorry.....it's a joke, only a joke. Don't get mad, Shinji」

「I'm not mad, I was wondering whether to consider it seriously.」

「...I also want to live here」

The three looked at each other,

「No no no, it's no use after all.」

「Right? Even if we complain to Yuuki-san, the war is starting....」

「Right.... what a shame...」

They gave up, and let out a sigh.

The town was lively, the food was delicious.

In addition to its comfortableness, it was as if the city was the center of culture and amusement, where new pleasures were born, one after another.

The enjoyment that they were extremely familiar with in their previous world, was a nostalgic one to them, that the Empire didn't know.

It wasn't like the Empire didn't have culture nor amusement, but it wasn't as free as in this city.

Above all else, the war was close to starting.

For the three of them, who knew the Empire's military strength well, it was useless to think that this country would have a chance to win against the Empire.

It couldn't be helped, they cut off such regrets, and challenged the labyrinth.

.....

.....

...

And now.

One week had passed after the labyrinth capture had begun.

The three member's of Shinji's group were relaxing in the inn inside the labyrinth.

「How should I say it... haven't we earned a lot this week?

Though it's said that this inn only offers the minimal facilities, it's still at a moderate level.

Comparatively, the inn fees are cheap, and unneeded equipment can be sold for money, haven't we saved a lot?」

Mark happily asked a question.

Zhen lifted his face like he was ia bit nterested.

Shinji took out a gold coin from the pouch like he was answering the two.

「Well, we saved a lot.

I heard that the highest capture group record here seems to be the 39th floor.

It seemed they had a hard time trying to capture the 40th floor.

The piece-by-piece weapons that begin to appear with empty hole seems to sell for a surprisingly high price.」

「I wonder what it is, that hole.

That kind of weapon didn't even appear until the 40th floor, right?

Two or three of them appeared in the 50th floor, didn't they?」

「Yes, that's right.

Actually, a treasure chest above the 30th floor seems to appear very rarely.

The weapon was surely of good quality, maybe this is the reason? That's what I thought...

There seems to be a secret.

Even when I asked the merchant, they didn't tell me, and just smiled.」

「Hey, that's suspicious.

However, if you talk about good quality, it's this one. Look at this!」

While saying so, Mark took out the Minos Bardiche, and showed it off.

It shone with a beautiful silver color.

A supreme gem made of Mithril.

It was an item obtained from the treasure chest guarded by the guardian of the 50th floor, it was a Unique class weapon.

「It's a Unique class weapon, you know? Even in the Empire, we wouldn't be able to get one so easily.」

「Or rather, in addition to that Bardiche, there's that empty hole right. What might that be?」

「Even so, it's a pretty weapon. Though the shape is weird...」

「This is so surprising. We are seriously trying to capture this labyrinth, we earned income, we're also enjoying this...

Rather, to be able give out a weapon like this freely, isn't this

country more than what we had previously surmised? Isn't this bad?」

Mark and Zhen nodded at Shinji's words.

There were many more things to be considered.

Firstly, the 50th floor boss was strong.

Among the monsters that had appeared around the Empire, not once had a monster with that class been born in these 100 years.

According to the ranking of disaster class that Yuuki had established, it was an "A" rank monster.

As for this monster class classification, the Empire had also adopted it as the common way to refer monsters, because it was easy to understand with it.

There was also the reason that, if the classification was different, then it could cause problems, since this classification system was widely used by merchants.

Aside from it.

In the 40th floor, there was a snake which had begun to attack with a dangerous breath, it was agreeable to say that it was an “A” rank monster.

It would not start attacking if the enemy was outside its breath range, though there was no escape in the narrow room.

It hurled itself with its body's tough muscles, it was a monster that you couldn't be careless with.

And, it was certain that the one they had met in the 50th floor was an Over “A” rank monster.

In the 30th floor, that guys movement were handicapped with chains and weights, but in there his movements were

unrestrained.

He was a dangerous boss, befitting the status as a devil amongst the Demon Lord's subordinates.

But, he wasn't a enemy that the three couldn't defeat, though it was another story if one of them could win against the enemy alone...

「Surely. I'm worried that a monster of such class was guarding the 50th floor.

The class of the floor boss seems to lose against the guardian class boss of every ten floors...

Isn't the strength just increasing in one level from the 40th floor to the 50th floor?」

Mark agreed with Shinji.

After smoothly passing the 50th floor, they were now on the 55th floor.

But, they didn't worry about the next boss in the 60th floor.

Ghost type monsters had appeared since the 51st floor. They are thinking that the boss was surely an undead type.

Fortunately, Mark had obtained the Minos Bardiche, as for Shinji and Zhen, they didn't have any weapons that were effective against undead.

Even so they didn't think that they would lose, though it was common sense that you shouldn't let your guard down.

「Oh well, even in the worst case, it seems we're not going die, so shall we do our best without being careless?」

Mark and Zhen also nodded at Shinji's words.

Their goal was the bottommost floor.

To determine the existence or inexistence of the research facility.

It was unknown how many floor there were until the bottom, so they needed to proceed with the capture without being careless.

They retired that day after they had finished confirming the plan once more.

And then, three days passed.

They finally arrived at the stairs of the 59th floor after they had cleared the poison marsh, and the corrosion zone.

They went down those stairs—reaching the 60th floor—the floor display increased by one number once they went down.

They finally arrived in the front of the boss room.

They had gotten enough rest last night, and their preparations were done.

Actually, they had arrived in front of the stairs yesterday around noon, but as a precaution they had taken a rest.

It was because they had just fought desperately against three Death Lords, so this was an additional reason for why they hesitated to force their way through.

They had the strength of the strongest class amongst ghost type monsters, without a doubt it had strength above “A” rank.

When they came here, they felt that the enemy’s strength had risen considerably.

That was why the three rested, to replenished their energy.

For the boss after this, they thought that they wouldn't have any problems as long as they faced it calmly.

The three nodded to one another, laid their hands on the door carefully, and then push it open without stopping.

An intense fight began.

It was truly an intense battle, or at least, that was my impression.

While slumped, and watching the situation in the middle of a casual game of cards, I watched the boss fight seriously.

The result was a complete victory for the Ghost King Adalman.

It was a brilliant victory to the degree that I was dumbfounded.

The analysis of the skills of the three people had been completed as well.

Shinji ... Estimated A rank [EP: 64,000]

Unique Skill 『Master Medic』

Method of Attack: Virus Manipulation. Air Composition Manipulation, Poison.

Naturally he could heal as well.

Mark..... Estimated A rank [EP: 73,000]

Unique Skill 『Thrower』

He could throw anything. As long as it was graspable, it was possible to throw anything, even a monster.

As there was no attribute, it had penetrating damage. A troublesome ability.

Zhen..... Estimated A rank [EP: 58,000]

Unique Skill 『Observer』

Instinct Evasion. Sense Danger. Sense Trap. Sense Monster. Sense presence.

Anyway, he was nimble. He was the natural enemy of labyrinths.

I felt the outline was like that.

I would deliciously take their abilities into account.

When you only looked at their strength, you would think that they would win against Adalman.

Nevertheless.

That guy, Adalman, seemed to have grown greatly in the span of one year.

Or rather, the egoless Death Lords group that didn't have any big changes in their original fighting strength, were a contrast to Adalman and Albert, who were proud of their current strength, which couldn't be compared to before.

Anyway, even I didn't know it either,

「Hehehe, you were surprised, right!

Actually, though it's a secret...

The youngster named Arnaud, or something similar, trained himself in Adalman's place!」

So, Ramiris told me with a feeling of 「Ramiris's surprise was a success!」 .

N? Arnaud was training? It wasn't the Adalman group, but Arnaud?

As for the source of the incongruity, the Holy Knights had actually passed the 50th floor quickly, and seemed to have arrived at the 60th floor.

But, they were defeated by one knight there.

The Holy Knight, who was rumoured to have been the strongest several hundred years ago.

Albert, Adalman's trusted confidant, who became a Death Paladin.

「Has the quality of Holy Knights these days fallen?」

While saying that, he handled the sword techniques he had had when he was alive with his monster specs, and overwhelmed Arnaud, or so I was told.

“Eeh, wasn't the holy attribute his weakness?” That's what people thought, I thought the same.

The cause of the defeat of those three was tied to Adalman's trump card.

“Holy-Demonic Inversion”

With this skill's ability, holy attribute was reversed into demonic attribute. The target was himself, so there was no worry of there being resistance.

They thought it was a joke, something like holy skeletons, but Adalman and Albert had nullified the holy attribute due to the Holy-Demonic Inversion.

In the first place, on top of having resistance towards physical attacks, they also had resistance against all attribute attacks.

So, against the two that had overcome their holy attribute weakness, it had become a hopeless situation.

With such feelings, those three were defeated quickly, and had become light particles.

By the way, there was also one more trump card, that was summoning a Death Dragon (Ghost Dragon).

I was told, that after having a desperate fight with Adalman's group, the Dragon Zombie became their companion, and seemed to have evolved.

「My master (Rimuru)! Were you able to witness it?

Our victory is for your sake!!」

While looking at Adalman that shouting that loudly,

(This is, the forces that protect the 60th floor are too overpowered right...)

Was my honest thought.

After I calmed down, I started questioning Ramiris.

With that kind of attitude, she should have something else that she was hiding.

「Eh, that kind of thing... I'm not hiding anything though...?」

Ramiris who was clearly behaving suspiciously, became restless.

It was clear that she was hiding something.

Just as I threatened her, that from now on cake would be prohibited, Ramiris began to talk rapidly like a machine gun.

First, Arnaud and his group had reached the 60th floor at an early stage, and seemed to have been defeated by Adalman.

And then for several months, they seemed to have been training in the 60th floor under the coaching of Albert.

Adalman acquired the “Holy-Demonic Inversion” skill from Ruminas who sometimes came to the research institute to play.

Adalman helped with various research, and with getting along with the vampire researchers, and seems to have caught Ruminas’s interest.

He seemed to have improved upon Ruminas's “Day and Night Inversion” and have acquired it.

Of course, as a token of gratitude he taught Ruminas this skill too.

And Arnaud came in when Adalman had acquired this skill.

If you thought about it, he was a man with bad timing, but because he could receive training from the strongest knight of some hundred years ago here, it could also be said that his lucky was good.

With such feelings, the 60th floor was transformed into a dangerous domain.

「Hey, hey... then, Arnaud and his group are where now?」

「Well... maybe because of the training, they easily defeated the boss of 70th floor, and are now in a deadlock on the 79th floor!」

「Umm... from the 61st to the 70th floor is a golem zone right...」

「That's right. They were defeated easily though...」

The guardian of the 70th floor is the perfect reproduction of the spirit protector colossus which I had made to guard the floor

.

Because I had previously broken the one that Ramiris made in the Labyrinth of Spirit, I created it as an apology but...

「I don't need it, because I have Beretta!」

She said, so I deployed it on the 70th floor.

There was no worries of it being defeated, since it was a super heavyweight class with high defense, due to Demon Steel.

It was a guardian of steel that wasn't affected by poisons, virus, and air quality.

My confidence came from my trust for Demon Golem (Demon Lord Protector Colossus), formerly spirit protector colossus, though....

「Veldora, who do you think is stronger, Adalman or Demon Golem?」

「Umm. Without a doubt, it's Adalman.」

As expected...

In the past year, he seems to have greatly increased his strength.

No, I think he was already strong from the start, I may have failed to notice it.

Anyway, as for the Death Paladin Albert, I just noticed him for the first right now.

Therefore, I was surprised by Ramiris.

「Okay, then starting from today, the 51st to the 60th floor will

be switched with the 61st floor to the 70th floor」

「Understood! Just leave it to me!」

And so, the inside of the labyrinth was switched.

Then, there was one more thing that I had in mind.

「By the way, the boss of the 80th floor, was it that strong?」

「Eh? What?」

「Well, wasn't Arnaud as strong as an Arc Demon?

Or rather, isn't it that that fellow, Adalman, has become as strong as an Arc Demon before I noticed!

Eh, huh? The shell of Insect type monsters on the 80th floor

were coated with Demon Steel, right?

After the golems with slow movement, it was arranged for there to be Insect type monsters with high-speed movement, this is...

Hey... What is going on in this place?」

「Well, you see....」

I keep pressing Ramiris, who behaved suspiciously, with questions, and I understood the current situation.

Arnaud didn't seem to be in a deadlock with the 80th floor's guardian.

It was with the one before it, the floor boss of the 79th floor.

His progress seemed to be hindered by the Insect Queen,

Apito.

With her super-speed movement, and her ultimate poison.

Arnaud couldn't touch her with his reflexes in sword techniques which he'd trained.

What the!!

I felt like screaming.

「But, but! It's not just me, Shisou was also coaching, or something similar, the insects were trained by him, you know!」

「Yo, you fool! You, did you betray me!?!」

「Because, it's unfair if only Shisou has that face saying that you're unrelated!」

「Gunununu...」

It seemed Veldora did the same thing.

It might have been my mistake to have entrusted the labyrinth to these two.

having achieved an abnormal evolution, the Insect Queen Apito seemed to be included in the ten strongest individuals in this labyrinth.

Having evolved into humanoid form, her insect-like appearance from before was gone.

Getting a beautiful form. It was a result of the abnormal evolution.

And so, the strongest individuals in this labyrinth...

There was a chance that they had the combat power of Executive class.

I didn't want to know, but various dragons seemed to have evolved to Dragon King class.

It had become that there were four Dragon Kings.

In addition,

Guardian of the 90th floor, Nine Head Beast Kumāra

Guardian of the 80th floor, Insect Kaiser Zegion

Floor Boss of the 79th floor, Insect Queen Apito

Guardian of the 60th floor, Ghost King Adalman

Vanguard of the 60th floor, Death Paladin Albert

Also,

Guardian of the 50th floor, Gozurl and Mezurl.

Frankly, excluding Gozurl and Mezurl, there's still 9 people——rather, should it be 9 being?—— which were equal in strength.

The Dragon Kings are Ramiris's subordinate, but the remaining 7 people seem to be my subordinates.

Though I thought that Gozurl and Mezurl were better off as Ramiris's subordinate.

The two would do anything in gratitude for becoming Ramiris's subordinates, and wished to continue to serve under me.

Hence, they could use the “Bracelet of Revival” many times.

Incidentally, without me knowing, they had become emotionally attached to it.

Anyway, I would give a proper order to these guardians so they don't raise their hands, except against the ones who invade the labyrinth.

Otherwise, it would be impossible for an ordinary person to travel in the labyrinth.

It was somewhat sad, it had become a situation where you couldn't challenge the labyrinth without having several Demon Lords.

Thus, during the observation of the three invaders, I noticed the current, unexpected, condition of the labyrinth.

Oh well, it was good to become strong, but I would be uneasy if it evolved beyond my imagination.

It might be the bad habit of a timid person.

I praised Adalman for his splendid deed, and I told him that the floor was changed as a reward.

He was considerably moved, and said that this was a mark of his wish to be useful to me in the future.

Well, I wished him to do his best.

What I noted next was that, the three intruders seemed to have gone back without invading again.

They may have had some objective, though they might have grown to fear the overwhelming power of the Death Paladin Albert.

Anyway, as for the Death Dragon that waited in the rear, there really was no need to move it.

It seemed they thought that it was useless even if they challenged it many times.

I felt like I wanted to obtain a bit more information, though it might not have been a problem.

After all, it would eventually arrive.

With such feelings, the curtain closed on the current riot.

Chapter 147: The Empire that Start to Move

The door opened with a loud noise.

Three people entered the room.

Yuuki took his eyes off from the document he was reading,

「Yo, welcome back」

He greeted the three.

But,

「Yuuki-san, it was impossible. The bottom zone was extremely hard.」

「Yeah, it went well until the 50th floor.

But, after the 55th floor, Death Knights were roaming together in a platoon.

I think this would be hard for ordinary knight ranks.

Well, the problem started from the 59th floor though.]

「——That was dangerous」

They began to speak vigorously.

Maybe it was because they were excited, they didn't mind how they looked anymore.

If you saw the three's clothes, the ripped chain mail was broken in some parts.

Just by looking at it there was no doubt that it was due to a fierce battle.

The story of the three continued.

「The boss of that floor was a Commander rank Death Knight——Death Lord—— but,

three of them appeared at the same time, you know!

Moreover, they were accompanied by 5 Death Knights each, you see?」

「That was horrible...maybe, we were relaxed until the 50th floor」

「The boss monster with a cow-like face had a strength comparable to an A rank.

Anyway, to have such monsters guarding it, there seems to be something in that labyrinth」

「Hee...then, did you guys give up at the 59th floor?」

「No, we somehow managed to defeated the three sets of Death Knights and their commanders.

But well.....」

「The guardian of the 60th floor seems to be a named boss, it was absurdly strong, you know」

「Because we were almost defeated by the numbers on the 59th floor, we were already prepared for a battle of attrition on the 60th floor though...」

「The result was our defeat by a single humanoid type monster」

「It clearly had abnormal strength, to the point of being the superior version of a Death Knight」

「——That was, impossible. Even if we try it many times, we will lose」

When the three talked to such an extent, Yuuki sat on a chair, and settled down a bit.

He drunk the served tea, and took a breath.

Yuuki, thought that, to some degree, his expectation was correct,

「Then, there seemed to be something over there?」

He questioned the exhausted trio.

Apparently, the three seemed to have just left the town by foot after being defeated at the 60th floor.

They regrouped with Damrada, who waited at the outskirts of

the town, and immediately returned with Transfer Magic.

This was because they feared a pursuit.

They heard that the highest record for the labyrinth was the 39th floor and there seemed to be a stalemate against the waiting boss of the 40th floor before they had challenged it.

Meanwhile, they thought that they certainly stood out by advancing and establishing new records right off the bat.

They said that they realized their mission had failed, and they withdrew when they confirmed existence of strong individual guarding the place without re-challenging the labyrinth.

After some considering they,

「There's no doubt. There should be some kind of facility beyond that place.」

「The size of the labyrinth was quite something.

I think it was expanded through some kind of magic though, but it didn't seem to be an artificial structure.

In the first place, that place didn't seem to have something like underground ruins originally, either.

In that case, it was a mystery how they secured a place that wide.」

「——Only in that floor, the defense was abnormally severe.

No matter how you look at it, they're guarding something.

Not only the knight that defeated us, there was a skeleton magician, and ghost dragon later on.

I think that the forces there were very different than on the

other floors」

「Right.

You could laugh but...

Probably, if all the monsters up to the 59th floor fought against the monster of the 60th floor——

Those guys from the 60th floor would win.」

Shinji and Zhen nodded in agreement with Mark's thought.

They say that it had such an overwhelming presence.

Yuuki had no doubt that the floors until the 50th floor were originally the labyrinth sections for tourist attraction purposes, while the 51st to the 60th floors and further, were a restricted secure area.

After that, they ate a light meal, and he received the report in calm, eased state.

It didn't seem that they were able to enter Tempest, but they seemed to have been able to gather information from the openhearted adventurers in the labyrinth town.

They summarized such information, and reported it.

As well as all sorts of thing they had obtained, their spoils of war.

They got a high quality "Magic Crystal" from a monster.

They were able to get some quality equipment from the treasure chest, which could be located in a room inside the labyrinth, or from the floor boss, and so on.

Each one of them were rare class, while the bardiche that Mark had was unique class.

They could sense, that to gather so many people, they needed to set up an unthinkable amount of money and labor.

Meanwhile, there was some worrying information.

That is,

There was a city on a certain floor inside the dungeon (Underground Labyrinth).

Or so they say.

「As expected, it doesn't seem to be a mistake.」

「Yeah. I think it must be.」

「——It is.」

「The point though, is that we cannot passed the 60th floor.」

At least, because he judged it to be absolutely impossible with only his group, Shinji reported it obediently.

It was on a level that saving face was of no use, since the boss was just too strong.

「Well by the way, to what extent did you feel that boss's strength?

Can you compare it with people that belong to the Imperial Guard Army to be specific?」

Shinji and the two were lost in thought at Yuuki's question.

Though it was called the Imperial Guard Army, in the army there were people like Shinji and his group, who weren't interested in the Rank Deciding Battle.

They were indebted to Yuuki in various ways after they had come to this world, and had helped under his instructions in various ways...

Since they were not interested in being in the top 100, they didn't participate in the Rank Deciding Battle seriously either.

Furthermore, since the Corps Commander had been replaced by Yuuki, they had purposefully transferred from their original Armored Corps to the Mixed Army Corps that Yuuki led as Corps Commander.

In this corps, there was no need to participate in the useless Rank Deciding Battle.

There was a number of people that existed among them that thought like "Otherworlders".

They weren't given a large responsibility, and they didn't show off their power, they were people that lived suitably.

Because the abilities of such people were not clear, it was a mystery whether the Imperial Guard Army was really the strongest group though...

But, on paper, there was no mistake that this group was the strongest group in the Empire.

「Well...At least, around the top 50th rank...?

I think those guys' subordinate aren't worth considering」

「In the end, it was just that one knight, right?

That knight, we weren't able to touch him, even with the three of us, you know?」

「——Right. People in the top 30th rank, might fight evenly against the knight?」

「Which reminds me...Wasn't there an Arc Demon subjugation troop dispatched before the construction?

That time, I participated as the campaign's doctor...」

「Ah, the “Lake Shore Dyed in Scarlet” incident? Is it true, Shinji was a survivor of that incident?」

「—— I was lucky to survive」

The “Lake Shore Dyed in Scarlet” incident was one of abominable incidents that had occurred in the Empire territory.

A vassal state, adjacent to the beautiful lake, revolted against the empire, and shouted for independence. That time, the king of that vassal state took a certain measure, since his state was inferior in war forces to Empire.

That was, the secret art of Demon Summoning, which could be considered Taboo.

The king gave an order to summon the strongest demon that would obey him, and the Imperial Court Magician answered the order.

Even if they opposed the empire, that small country population didn't even reach 10,000 people, so there's should be no chances of victory for them, but——

There was a reason why the king suddenly declared his country's independence.

A noble from the Empire desired for the princess, his only daughter.

In the Empire, which had become powerful, it was impossible for the emperor to grasp the movements of such a small country.

The margrave, who was entrusted to rule the area, borrowed the emperor's authority, and performed atrocities. Such a spectacle was a common occurrence in the Empire.

The Arc Demon appeared from the Demon Summoning; then destroyed that small country.

The demon's desire was that kingdom's princess.

The Imperial Court Magician, whose mind began to break the instant he saw the demon, presented the princess in response to the demon's demand.

The demon sprouted a wicked smile, and possessed the princess' body.

It accomplished embodiment through the princess.

The King went into a rage. However, that anger was immediately replaced by fear as the demon's rampage began.

In the end, a report that the small country was destroyed reached the Empire, and the demon's subjugation was decided.

As if their initial response was late by a step, that place would become the location where the second Guy Crimson was born.

The beautiful lake was dyed with the blood of that small country's populace, and the water change into a red color.

Even in the several hundred years of the Empire's history, this detestable incident could be called the worst that had ever happened.

「Well, about the main issue in hand.

I only saw its appearance during the fight at that time though,

I felt the 60th floor boss was about the same as the Arc Demon」

「What? Such thing as an Arc Demon! It's on a level that we can't defeat, you know?」

「——Is it really, the same?」

The Armored Corps, which had branches throughout the entirety of the Empire's territory, solved the “Lake Shore Dyed in Scarlet” incident.

Or so it was the official story.

However, Shinji who was there, saw that a few knights defeated the Arc Demon, which the troops couldn't fight, from afar.

He didn't intend to mention it, but he thought that they were probably people who belonged to the Imperial Guard Army now.

Therefore, because of it, he had lost his interest in the Rank Deciding Battle.

He really felt that they lived in a different world.

「Ah, they might be like this.

It would be great if a machine to check the enemy's power can be developed, though it would probably have no significance.

That knight seemed to be strong since he was a high level swordsman.

The later magician-like skeleton had an intimidating air that was comparable to an Arc Demon.」

Shinji's words didn't contain doubt, and were full of his true feelings.

「Then, it can't be helped that we lost.

In addition to those powerful two, there was a dragon right?

It's a bit too cruel. The balance is too difficult, that labyrinth.」

「Until the 50th floor the balance was good though...

As expected, if you consider what lies on the other side, there must be a town after that place.」

Receiving the three's report, Yuuki pondered.

It wasn't an accurate conclusion, since he didn't see it with his own eyes, but as there seemed to be a floor that was guarded by an undead transformed dragon, and two beings with an Arc Demon class.

It seemed they couldn't reach the targeted research facilities if they didn't pass that place.

(Oh well, it can't be dealt with with ordinary means, as expected)

Yuuki could go and breakthrough the labyrinth himself, but he would be noticed immediately by Rimuru and his group.

He didn't participate in the labyrinth simply because they were cautious about his movements.

However, Yuuki wanted to achieve the goal of the labyrinth's capture somehow. He may ignore it, but Yuuki had a hunch that some problems were going to occur later.

Yuuki pondered for a while,

「Thank you, you guys should have a good rest.

That's right, if you want to examine the obtained equipment in detail,

you guys should visit the Imperial Court Magician, Gadra-roushi.

Shinji, you should greet your master for the first time in a while as well, right?

Also, you guys may sell the unnecessary things, since the Supplies Section will purchase it.」

He thanked the three people, and called out to them.

The three, who remembered that they were tired with his words, showed delighted expressions, thanked Yuuki, and left the room.

The seeds were scattered.

It might have been too early to spread this matter to the other sections.

Probably, the Empire would move.

Yuuki thought as much, and quietly sprouted a smile.

After the three left Yuuki's room, they went to the Supplies Section to sell "Magic Crystals" and unused equipment.

Their reconnaissance ended in failure, but they were able to get a considerable income in a short amount of time.

Their salaries, provided by the army, were more than the average income of a commoner, but not to the extent where they could live luxuriously. On the other hand, to leave the army and become independent, the conditions in this world were very severe.

Being able to live a steady life, was already attractive.

「Hey, hey, where did you guys obtain this "Magic Crystal"?

This is something hardly seen recently, isn't this a high quality one!」

「The equipment here is great too. It's a weapon made with pure Demon Steel.

Though I'm bothered by this hole thing.」

「Hahaha, where it was obtained is a secret. Please don't ask again.」

After having such an exchange, they had a good rest in their respective rooms that day.

The forced march had ended, their bodies, and minds might have been dead tired. When Shinji woke up, it was the evening of the next day.

Shinji who woke up, contacted the other two.

Zhen was up, but it seemed like Mark was still sleeping.

Actually, his fatigue would be great for sure, since Mark mostly played an active role.

The three met, and decided to have dinner.

In the Empire's capital, the three had a meal at a high class restaurant.

It had been a while since they had last has such a luxury.

Yuuki didn't tell them to hand over the spoils, and was happy to give everything to Shinji and his colleagues.

When permission to plunder is not given, the spoils obtained in the middle of a military campaign belonged to the military.

In this case, they couldn't complain, even in the worst case where everything was taken away.

Well in most cases,

「However, if all things and money obtained were taken away,

we might seriously think about migrating away right?」

The two agreed with Shinji's remark.

One gold coin was equivalent to 100,000 yen.

The market price was similar in the Empire.

The gold coins in the market were issued by the Dwarf Kingdom, the quality was standardized as the common gold coin.

They could use the original Empire gold coin, but there would be an inspection of the money by the moneychanger, and the fee was larger too.

Therefore, the majority of transactions were using the gold coins made by the Dwarf Kingdom.

The gold coins made by the Dwarf Kingdom were inscribed with magic, any counterfeit money would be exposed immediately. If by chance, a counterfeit was exposed, it would result with a death penalty.

Because of that, there were only a few idiots that counterfeited money in the present.

The gold coins that Shinji's group obtained from the labyrinth city, which was the satellite city of the Monster's Country Tempest, were without doubt made by the Dwarf Kingdom.

It could be used inside the Empire without any problems.

The army had an annual salary system. The promotion was also included, calculated and collected the next year.

However, taking in consideration the people who didn't have the money on hand, they had devised a system where they gave out daily allowances from the reserve funds.

For an ordinary soldier, it was ten gold coins——their annual salary was equivalent to 1 million yen.

Because the army took care of the life necessities (food, clothing & shelter), it was a large sum of money for poor people.

The gold coins that they obtained were altogether more than 100 pieces.

Mark and Zhen's rank were First Lieutenant.

Because Shinji had the qualification as an army doctor, his command right was two ranks higher, he was a Major.

Because Otherworlders are given preferential treatment, even at the lowest they will receive treatment as Second Lieutenants.

Of course, the salary provided by the Empire in a year was more than for an ordinary soldier.

But, even so it was around 50~100 pieces of gold coins.

The amount of money they had earned during this short-term mission was greater than their annual salaries.

Not to mention that the unique class equipment and so such, were things that they couldn't get throughout their lifetimes unless they paid hefty sums for it.

Being unable to stomach Damrada's lavish lifestyle was the biggest reason Mark hated him.

In short it was jealousy, there was no other meaning.

Mark didn't like Damrada, whom he didn't know, who was just living a good life, while he, himself, was personally just a dog of the army.

In addition, he was disgusted with himself, who thought about such things, and took out his anger more strongly on Damrada.

Shinji could understand Mark's feelings, but he could satisfy himself with only the salary he received as an army doctor.

If he said something careless word, it would disturb Mark's mood.

They were thinking about something based off the information that they were able to get in this mission.

That,

'Even if they didn't particularly cling to the military, the three of them could live together in the labyrinth city, couldn't they?'

Was something like that.

Sure, the Empire was the leading force in culture and technology. It was an excellent capital.

The food was delicious, and the living conditions were comfortable too.

As long as they had money, they were able to enjoy a fulfilling life comparable to their former world.

But, they were more or less civil employees.

They might be given a dangerous mission, and so they couldn't be careless.

In that regard, that dungeon was very satisfying.

After all, they didn't have to worry about dying.

They were half in doubt, but because they had experienced it themselves, they had no choice but to believe it.

If they didn't have to worry about dying, wasn't it better for

them to live interestingly over there?

It was normal to think so.

Even if there was money, there was no meaning in it if there was no entertainment...

Over there, there was a place called the Colosseum, and it seemed it could be used freely on its day off.

Various sports games, like soccer and baseball, were played over there, and they had already investigated that the adventurer citizens enjoyed it.

About the taste of the food, it was equal to empire.

Though it was equal, it had a nostalgic taste that couldn't be reproduced by the people of this world, and it attracted their hearts as people from Earth.

To be frank, it was because they were indebted to Yuuki that they didn't have feel like to changing sides.

When the war begun, they would be considered deserters, but fortunately right now was a peaceful time.

If it was now, it would be easy to retire from duty, and leave the army.

「The problem is the war...right」

Mark muttered.

It was the reason they couldn't decide.

That was caused by the problem he just stated.

War would certainly begin. Otherwise, they would have left this country long ago, and would have moved to the labyrinth

city.

「Which side do you think will win?」

「Just saying, what will we do if we receive an order to attack that city?」

The three looked at each other.

There was a feeling of unpleasantness in attacking that city they liked, right after they had stayed there for a while. But they, judging from the strength of the boss inside that labyrinth, expected that the strength of the strongest person in Monster's Country Tempest would be unthinkable.

「If you think about it, normally you would think that the guardians that protected the research facilities were strong, right?

But, the people that belong to that country's army are monsters, right?

If so, the guardians in the labyrinth aren't the strongest, right?」

「I think the same. At least, the Demon Lord Rimuru might be an exception.

In the past, a city seemed to have been annihilated by a wicked dragon named Veldora...

Actually, a similar thing seemed to have happened.

I think that an Arc Demon is equal to a tactical nuclear weapon in Earth.」

「That's right. The war is about numbers, even if several of that boss appear it will be useless.」

「——With our class, we can't fight against ten people, I think it's meaningless.」

The three talked till late that day, but in the end the talk wasn't settled.

At least, they had only decided to leave the army before the war began, and parted on that day.

In the office where a splendid desk was placed, a man with one eye was sitting in a high class chair.

His left eye was covered with an eye patch, his appearance was of a skinny man around 40.

His name was Calgurio.

He was the Corps Commander of the Armored Corps that boasted of the greatest power in the Empire.

On the desk in front of him, a few “Magic Crystals” were placed.

They were high quality “Magic Crystals,” which had high purity, and would become sources of magic energy.

In his hand was a sword.

It was made with high quality Demon Steel, and the skill with which it was made could be grasped as a high level.

It was a splendid sword, equal to the ones which the best craftsman of the Dwarf Kingdom forged.

It was said that the Supplies Department purchased it, but it had a clear distinction from the items sold within the Empire.

A subordinate of a high rank noble who was on familiar terms with Calgurio got his hands on the Supplies Department, and reported if there was an outstanding item.

That was the case this time.

Many nobles came over with indecent smiles, and reported it to Calgurio.

Calgurio's origin was as a low rank noble, the high rank nobles would not bore themselves to talk to him if he was a civil employee.

Those nobles were looking down on Calgurio, but they knew how to be courteous towards the head of a corps of the greatest faction.

Thus, their relations were equal.

“It seems to be impossible to harvest “Magic Crystals” of this purity from monsters that generated naturally”, so they say.

‘If we want to aim for a stable supply, we should secure the place that produced this “Magic Crystal”!’ like that.

They demanded of Calgurio in the report.

There was no thing as a high rank noble that moved while disregarding their own profit.

There was no such thing as ‘They reported it with good intent,’ or something like that.

There was another story that he worried about.

It was about the sword that Calgurio held in his hand.

Many times, 『This unusual item seems to have a mysterious effect』 such an exaggerated thing was said when he came to buy it.

If it was examined, it would likely strengthen the Empire’s army.

In the end, it was sold at 100 gold coins due to such a reason, but surely there was something that Calgurio was worried about.

There was a hole in the sword.

Did the hole have any meaning?

Calgurio couldn't decide.

Therefore, he handed the sword over to the Technical Group after he was troubled.

If it was them, there would be some discoveries.

When the result was brought a few days later to Calgurio, he was surprised, but determined.

Because the sword attracted the best craftsman among them,

he noticed it.

Also the origin of the sword was from inside a dungeon that belonged to a certain country, and when he learned of that, Calgurio drafted a strategy inside his mind.

He was thinking while smiling thinly.

When the time came, he must never allow anyone to have a head start.

And, despite having a chance to obtain such important information, he thought that his colleagues were pitiful to not notice this.

After all, this fellow was a foolish upstart.

His head didn't stop thinking while sneering at his colleague.

‘How much could he enjoy the maximum profit if he did it?’

He was thinking about the opportunity to apply the initiation of the military campaign to the Emperor while thinking about it deeply.

* * *

Author’s note:

By Calgurio’s action, the Empire begin to move.

It wasn’t necessary to write it, but it was for the time being.

In case Clayman goes for the labyrinth capture, can he capture the former 60th floor? The probability is low.

He would surely lose if he took on those three (Guro: Magician, Knight & Dragon) at the same time.

Chapter 148: A decision made too late

In a spacious and well lit, comfortable room.

An old man ——Gadra the Imperial Court Mage invited his 3 guests to the room ——he showed them the chair

Whilst feeling obliged, the three sat on the chair as suggested by the strict mage.

Gadra watched the three, and chuckled.

Although he have became a full-fledged soldier, his disciple's nervousness towards him was still amusing.

He knew that his disciple Shinji and his friends will come visiting him from a prior contact.

And, the investigation on the equipments that entrusted to him has also ended.

However, he's still pondering whether he should inform them honestly or not...

The equipment's astounding performance was something that he should be astonished.

Anyway, first of all he decided to return the bardiche and the bracelet which in his hand to Shinji and held it out.

Shinji receive the equipments which Gadra held out, and hand over the bardiche to his friend with large build (Mark).

Then, he tucked away the bracelet into his pocket.

At the same time after it's over,

“So, Shisho.....this bracelet, do you have any ideas what this bracelet is?”

Out of curiosity, he asked the main question.

The effect of its automatic revival after the wearer died is only possible in a specific place. You wouldn't find a magic item like this that possess such ability, no matter how many records were checked.

However, It's not like there's nothing that comes to mind

"Hmm. Impatient as usual I see. Well, I can't criticize others either.

I will say the conclusion, it can't be appraised with magic. I let the Technology Department to examine the other two.

But, I'm afraid that the mystery of this bracelet will not be solved.

Even so, It's not like there's nothing that comes to mind.

So, the question is.....

You lot, where was this bracelet obtained from? What is the place called?”

And so, in order to ascertain that, Gadra ask a question in return.

Gadra didn't hear about the origins of this bracelet. He only received a request saying to examine the effects of the bracelet.

Three bracelets were handed to him and he was asked to check what kind of ability it has.

He only heard a bit detail of it at the time, 『The effect of automatic revival is possible only in a specific limited location』 or some unthinkable thing like that.

When Shinji handed the bracelet, he said that he wanted Gadra to examine it without having any strange prejudice, but Gadra didn't heard the story in detail...

The result, it's impossible to be analyzed by magic.

Due to its indefinite change of the spirit's wave, every interferences by magic were obstructed.

Because the wave of all attributes was intermingled with each other complicatedly, it's in a state which the specific pattern couldn't be calculated. Therefore, Gadra gave up and end up asking the Technology Department to deal with it.

Asking the Technology Department is like admitting he lost and it hurt his pride, but Gadra's personality was to prioritized gain over pride.

While feeling frustrated too, he handed the remaining 2 bracelets over requesting an investigation. The results aren't out yet.

"I've tried appraised it myself with magic, but I failed... I couldn't find any clues.

I thought the failure was due to my lack of ability, but even Shisho too.....

The place is the west side —— of the empire, it's the opposite end, the “other side” of the Jura Great Forest, or referred to as “West Side”—— of the forest,

It's the satellite city of the emerging country governed by the Demon Lord, called Monster's Country Tempest.

In that city, or at the underground dungeon, the bracelet is an item that can be purchased upon entry into the multi-layered underground structure.

Then, as they sold it to us, they've also given us explanation about the labyrinth...

We were skeptical at first, but we personally experienced it with our body.

Without a doubt, it has effect to revive even if we died.

“Hohou.....labyrinth, is it? Then, Can this bracelet be used multiple times?”

“No, once you die it will become light particles and disappears.”

Well in this case, you will be outside the labyrinth, and you need to enter again.

When you paid the fee, it seems you have to buy it again.”

“.....So this dungeon, collects admission fees?

Or rather, anyone can enter?”

“Yeah, that’s right. Apparently, the Demon Lord Rimuru seems to run it as a tourist attraction.”

“What.....Demon Lord, huh.....”

Gadra was rendered speechless by Shinji's explanation.

If you think about it, this is too terrible a conversation.

A Demon Lord is referred as an enemy of humanity.

The Demon lord is an absolute existence, and it's wise to go on basis of mutual non-aggression.

The reason why the Demon Lord rule over an affluent territory is to nullify a Demon Lord's reason and ambition for the territories of other countries

Due to this, Gadra is on the opposition position regarding the empire's ambition to expand towards the west side.

One year ago, the Farmas Kingdom perished for incurring the Demon Lord's wrath.

While the people weren't directly harmed, but the king suffered a gruesome end, and the country perished too.

With this incident as the cue, there seemed to be some kind of movements among the Demon Lords.

As for the newly created Eight Star Demon Lords (Octogram), notification was sent to humanity.

There are 4 Demon Lords whom name is known widely.

Guy, Mirim, Leon, and the one in the topic Rimuru.

Gadra didn't know what are the western nation thought about this, but he believe that it was dangerous move to angered Rimuru as he's a Demon Lord.

His name was known because he takes too many intensive actions.

And the important thing is, even though Clayman who was one of the former 10 Great Demon Lords is gone, the newcomer Rimuru has left quite the impression.

As indicated by that, the west side has an existence that more frightening than Clayman, so is the point.

Besides, it's to the point where there's no survivor amongst the 10 thousand people that partook in Farmas's military campaign.

In the case of an ordinary war, when the casualties were over 30%, it would mean this campaign is a failure.

At that point, they would need to surrender.

They thought that their life will not be taken if they surrendered because of the rumored personality of the Demon Lord, but the result was a massacre.

Were they were annihilated without chance to surrender? Or

was it because of the subordinates' reckless action?

But, the most frightening thing above all might be his ability of impregnable defense that enclosed them and gave them no chance to escape.

The army well over 10000, if there's no one survived.....it's not an event that common sense can be applied to.

It might be possible if a large-scale spell was invoked.

Enclosing the whole army, with a speed that didn't allow them to escape, if it's nuclear strike magic.....

When using that large-scale magic, it would be a miracle if the opponent haven't deploy any defense barriers while the magic power for casting such great magic was being gathered.

If such element cleared all the requirement, it might not be impossible for Gadra either.

Though, this is all very unlikely.

Above all, the effects on the natural environment due to terraforming via nuclear strike magic has not been confirmed.

He wouldn't kill the runaway enemies by some kind of unknown attack nor command a large number of subordinates to lock down the enemy and annihilated them.

It's frightening, that's how he honestly feel.

To especially wage war against such opponent truth to be told, the higher ups of the military wouldn't be able to avoid incompetent criticism.

(I should probably remonstrate to the emperor about this, huh.....)

With such a thought, he let out a depressed sigh.

After a change of mood, he decide to answer his disciple, Shinji's question.

“Well, it's about the Demon Lords. Do you guys know how many Demon Lords there are?”

“Yes, is it 8 people right?”

“Eh? Isn't it 10 people? No, shouldn't it be 11 people now?”

“——Mark..... they made some changes last year.....”

Gadra sighed, and began his explanation.

“Those idiots civilian employee's bad habit, they can't even do an intelligence gathering, I can see them be the first to die.

There are 8 demon lords. They refer to themselves as the Eight Star Demon Lords.

—— It may mean that they have ability that compared to a star.

In fact, it's said that the 'Newbie', Rimuru alone has the strength to match an army.

The higher ups of the military seem to think this remark about Rimuru is just boasting.....but I personally think it's the truth.

But, this time let's put this aside.

Among them, one of the Demon Lords is called 'The Fairy of the Labyrinth'.

What do you think about this?"

These words made the three held their breaths.

Timidly, Shinji state his thought.

“Labyrinth as in dungeons?”

So he said.

Nodding gravely, Gadra took out a copy of a book, and showed it to the trio.

In the Ulgrasia Republic on the west side, there's a dungeon known as “Dwelling of the Spirits”.

It's said that the labyrinth expands in underground or in the air in this world, but the truth is different.

In a sense this is correct, yet also wrong.

According to the books, the “Dwelling of the Spirits” not only houses spirits, but it's also the resident of their queen whose

body changed from a spirit into a fairy.

“This queen, is one of the Demon Lords, the one known as ‘The Fairy of the Labyrinth’.”

Gadra’s words weighted heavily on the trio.

In addition,

“The entrance to the labyrinth seems to be only located in the Ulg National Park, but has now vanished.

Not long after that, the Demon Lord Rimuru has identified himself.

Then, an underground labyrinth (dungeon) was opened to the public after a few months later.”

So he continued

By now, he's convince there's no mistake.

As for Shinji and his friends, they can't utter a denial.

“Shisho.....did you realize that?”

He barely had a reply.

Gadra laughed maliciously,

“Naturally! You idiot.....collecting information is the fundamental of everything you know!

For War, and also Economy. If a person aspire to pursuit magic, it's all the more.

Diligence is not enough!!

And also, one more thing.

You lot were defeated by such opponent, it's as expected."

"Eh?! Shi, Shisho, why it's like that?"

"I've asked Yuuki-dono. About where and what you lot doing.

At that point when the answer come, it's good as naught to decide anything."

"Haha, I'm very sorry..."

Shinji was ashamed, His face dyed red.

As a magician, his master had told him many times how inadequate was his information collecting, he felt ashamed that he wasn't able to realize it till someone pointed it out.

But, it's certainly a bit harsh to compare the crafty Gadra who already lived for many years in this world with Shinji whose lacking in sense of tension due to being raised in Japan.

Anyways, Shinji and co using this opportunity for some serious reflection as well, the information about the 60th floor Guardian was obtained.

There's a story of a noble-minded Priest accompanied by a great Holy Knight from a long time ago.

Such people were turned into devil, it's story that was agreeable even if it's said that their threat can be compared to Arc Demon.

“I don't know whether this the truth or a lie, in this book,

『The blade of the Holy Knight Albert, could cut even an Arc Demon』

So it was written. I'm afraid he was a master of formidable

sword.”

Hearing his master words, Shinji is fed up.

(If that so, I can't possibly win!)

That was his state of mind. Since he was uncertain, it can't be helped, if he couldn't revive he would definitely be dead.

In the future, in order to avoid exposing his comrades to unexpected dangers, he would definitely collect more detailed information, sworn Shinji.

However, this decision was made a bit too late.

That's because, they, have already been caught up in a new crisis.....

The door of Gadra, the Imperial Court Magician's room

opened, and several soldiers entered.

The sudden turn of events shocked Shinji and co.

But, the situation has begun to proceed, and due to Shinji and co's late decision, they have lost the chance to escape from the empire.

Chapter 149: Night Before the War Begin

An Imperial Conference was about to begin in front of the Emperor.

The situation now was different from the time of peace. Tension spread among the civil officers that sat in a row much less the officers that participated.

People that didn't have any relation to the conference didn't come near the big conference room, as if they had felt the atmosphere there.

Everyone felt that this time, the conference was different from a usual one.

When the arrival of emperor was announced, everybody lowered their head at once.

The Union Emperor, Ludra Nam Ul Nasca.

The top of Nasca Namrium Ulmeria Eastern Alliance Union Empire, the strongest country.

To ensure that his true disposition would not be known to others, his figure was hidden behind the blinds, and could not be seen.

To make him the one and only, Supreme Ruler.

There were only a few people who could give their opinion to the Emperor.

In the conference room, there were a little less than 100 people.

The leader of each corps, and their aides.

The elites of the guard army were sitting in a row.

The ministers that conducted the government of the country, and grand noble houses that were the center of the country.

All distinguished faces gathered and lowered their heads.

When the Emperor glanced at the gathered people from the other side of the blinds, he took a seat with an uninterested mood.

The prime minister took it for a sign and signaled to everyone with his eyes.

Everyone understood it and simultaneously, words of salutation resounded, causing the large room to tremble..

The Emperor commanded with one hand,

「Enough with the stiff formalities. We don't desire such things. Just start」

The Emperor ordered the start of the conference.

Thus, the grand conference that would decide the start of the war, that would be carved in history, began.

First, what was the reason to start the war?

It was a silly question.

They thought it was because the Emperor wanted it.

Was that possible?

The opinions was greatly divided.

There was someone who advocated a careful basis, and there was someone who insisted on invading directly from the front.

The civil officers insisted that they should begin with diplomatic negotiations such as threats and other tactics.

Starting the war was the Emperor's intention, there was no place to raise an objection.

If there was someone that said the preparation was lacking and the chance of winning was low, that person would receive criticism of being called an incompetent who could not do any preparations properly.

Anyway, not only had their preparations been completed, there were people who were confident in their absolute military force. There was no one who would make such an assertion be known.

However...

「With all due respect, Your Majesty. I'm against it」

One person reported that he was against the war.

Gadra, the Imperial Court Magician.

He was the person that was called the Empire's great magician.

Gadra spoke out, without fear of the Emperor, and told the Emperor his own thoughts.

「I think that there should be no problem if we only attacked the west side.

However, the wicked dragon Veldora is in the Jura Great Forest.

Also, it's the territory ruled by the Demon Lord Rimuru who made his name widely known recently.

It seems likely that the wicked/evil dragon has joined forces with Demon Lord Rimuru..

To act of mutual non-aggression is the usual course against a Demon Lord.

It's a different story if it is the other party that starts it though,

Was there any kind of meddling from this side....?」

Some of the civil officials nodded in agreement with Gadra's opinion, but,

「You fool! Have you become a coward, Roushi!?

If it's us, the Empire's strongest Magic Beast Corps, we can handle someone like a Demon Lord you know!」

「What insolence!! Does Gadra-dono intend to go against the Emperor's thoughts!?!」

「HaaHaaHaa, Roushi-dono. You have grown old.

Your magic knowledge is the Empire's treasure.

Although you have cooperated in the development of the new type magic weapon of our Armored Corps...

I cannot let that remark go! Are you a coward?」

Gadra was bathed in sneers from both the military authorities and the nobles.

Amongst the ministers, that only thought about the imagined profits they would get, was one person who rolled his eyes and didn't seemed to be amused from Gadra who objected the war.

「You lot... do you understand? That wicked dragon is the strongest species in this world that rules over storms you know?」

「Roushi, I don't understand. The empire army is different from before.

We have learned the knowledge of various places of the many different worlds, the thing called "Science". We have obtained the new technology system which is called magic science.

With this new technology, our military force has increased its power dozens of times from the first generation.

Isn't it because of outdated magicians like you, even now, you still have a bitter experience of having your own corps dissolved!!」

Calgurio, the commander of Armored Corps, argued against Gadra's words.

In fact, the Magic Corps that was once called one of the Empire's three great corps was dissolved, nowadays any capable person will get assigned to Technology Department or other department.

The reason there was no movement from the Empire in these few decades, was because a military reorganization had happened and given birth to the new Three Great Corps.

Armored Corps, the corps where science and technology of the different world fused as magic technology.

The Empire's corps with the largest size, the number of total soldiers that could be mobilized exceeded 2 million.

However, in reality the number of soldiers who could participate immediately in the military deployments is 1 million since some of the forces were on standby in every place in the Empire.

Even so, the scale of the corps could be said as abnormal.

It was arranged to select the best war potential for this time.

As for the breakdown,

Armored Remodeled Legion...

- Legion of soldiers who received magic remodeling by magic and technology of the different world.

- The individual ability increases and has ability considerable to B-A ranks.

- Even at the lowest, the corps consisted of people stronger than C+ rank. Number of soldiers affiliated, 700,000 people.

- It's the star unit that was called the Empire main force.

Magic Tank Division...

- Magic Tank 4.000 unit. Number of soldiers affiliated, 200.000 people.

- The Empire's secret weapon, piloted by 5 people. The main

armament is Magic cannon.

-Optimized by other world's technology, the cannon amplifies magic and fires it.

Aerial Fighter Legion...

-Airship 400 aircraft. Number of soldiers affiliated, 100.000 people.

-One aircraft can be boarded up to 400 people.

-To operate it, needs about 50 staff.

-The other personnel is engaged in bombardment relations. It's useful as transportation means.

-It could be said that there's no concept of air supremacy in this era.

-While the enemy is caught unprepared, it's a threat that can become a transport for a large scale military deployment.

-A lot of Magic Reinforcement Cannons were installed on the airship, many member of former Magic Corps were affiliated with this corps.

The above was the actual force of the Armored Corps.

In the Armored Corps, half of the affiliated member were given a forced magic remodeling.

The degree of the remodeling fluctuated suitably, but everyone's ability increased greatly, although there was some degree of differences.

It's the same with the soldiers standing by in various places in the Empire, everyone had strength above a certain level.

It overwhelms even the union of other countries in both quality and quantity.

It's a corps that showed the might of the Empire.

The magic beast corps captured various magic beasts, bred, strengthened, and trained them.

The culture of the magic beast was by DNA analysis, the technology of the other world.

And, the strong people of the empire riding on their back.

Inborn strong people were said to have the blood of the hero who played an active part in the old times.

If magic remodeling was a technique to change an ability-less person into a hero, they are born heroes.

Born Heroes having an overwhelming ability.

A minor Corps with only 30,000 personnel was said that one

of them had the ability of 10,000 people.

But, the magic beast they rode, all had the strength appropriate to A- Rank.

It's a Corps with only 30,000 people that call themselves the strongest elite corps that the Empire boasts of.

The last entry, Mixed Corps.

This corps, so to speak, was a mish and mash.

The den of dropouts, where black sheep were gathered, or so the people generally thought.

However, while it may be true that they were dropouts, it didn't mean they don't have ability.

It may be said that various experiments and new trials are

carried out by this corps.

The corps own their own technology development department, it also have magic research department, their potential was unknown.

This corps employs the most Otherworlders as combatants.

The total number of soldiers, 200,000 people.

However, a lot of them were intelligence officers and general office work soldiers, the number of soldiers that can actually fight were around 100,000 people.

In disfavor of Magic Remodeling, people who can't ride magic beasts and people of the former magic corps that have no place to go were taken into this corps.

But, it had been already recognized that the forces were more than the former magic corps although it was such a jumble.

Despite its newly created status, it tied against the Armored Remodeled Legion in a mock battle though it's under the same number condition.

A high future was anticipated from this corps.

Its flexibility came due to the condensation of the good points and then reorganized it. It's a Corps that was established with such a purpose.

These are the Empire's New Three Great Corps.

A large force.

1,130,000 soldiers may went to the frontline without any problem even if an order for a military campaign was given right now.

Judging from the prediction about the West side's total military force and armaments that the Intelligence Bureau obtained, the empire's army could be said to be too

overwhelming.

Calgurio could speak openly because he had confidence as he within the strongest and in addition, the Corps with the largest personnels.

There're many people who fear Veldora but Calgurio was not afraid of it.

After all, it's only a dragon right? So he thought.

There are dragons residing in the Qanat Great Mountain Range. It's surely a strong monster.

In case of Lesser Dragon that inhabits the foot of the mountain, when an individual grew up to medium dragon, its strength becomes more than of A Rank.

The force of one squadron from the Armored Remodeling Legion is needed even if it's just an individual.

He handled the dragon subjugation in military drills several times and he familiarized himself with the information about such things.

Even so.

On the contrary, the more he familiarized himself with it, the more he could come up with countermeasures against an individual, even for a dragon.

‘It’s just one dragon, what do we have to fear?’ Calgurio reached such state of mind.

A monster’s strength is decided on the amount of energy.

It doesn’t change no matter how strong an individual is.

The reason why a dragon is strong is because it can act with agile movements compared to its mass.

Also, the extreme hardness of its dragon scale. Its breath attack was dangerous too, but it's true nature was the amount of energy.

If that is the case, there's no need to fight from the front.

There's also weakening with magic, and there's also the new technology called a Magic Canceller (Magic Essence Disturbance Radiation).

It can obstruct a magician's casting, a new technology that enables the weakening of a monster in battle.

The victory will be certain if he just fire the magic cannon of the main armaments of the 4,000 magic tank, but he need to be extremely cautious if there's a countermeasure.

He experimented it with the captured dragon, but he was able to kill it with one shot of the magic cannon even if it was a Young Dragon of A Rank.

As for a monster, energy (magic essence amount) which was the basis of its existence will be disturbed if exposed to the Magic Cancellor and it will be difficult for it to take an action.

In short, it's weakened.

If he fire volley of main armaments of the 4,000 magic tank to the weakened target, the annihilation will be certain even if it's an ancient wicked dragon.

The content of the strategy that Calgurio devised for battle against Veldora is as follows.

- Encirclement by 300 airship.
- Containment of Veldora' action with Magic Cancellor.
- Approximately 200.000 standby remodeled soldiers to confined Veldora.

- Volley of main armament by 4.000 magic tank.

That's all.

Airship is a secret weapon that can be said as the fruits of magic technology.

Its maximum speed can surpasses the speed of sound. It's impossible for creature with flesh body to escape from this speed without depending on magic.

The winning chance of the battle can increase with the accumulation of information after all.

The airship had buried a great number of dragon and accumulation of information is everything.

Calgurio was convinced of the victory and had an absolute confidence.

Gadra, the Imperial Court Magician, an ex-hero that once called that have grew old by now.

He will be at Calgurio' mercy if he threaten him with several soldiers equipped with Magic Cancellor without being able to resist anything.

But, Calgurio think that he must not lack in etiquette as Gadra still a hero...

(Ffu. He was a person of the past after all. Even till now, old people still cause problem...)

War potential reinforcement depend on the passage of times.

He's a pitiful old man that can't follow it.

「Your Majesty, Gadra-roushi seem to fear Veldora very much, but I'm different.

Please give an order for the wicked dragon subjugation to this Calgurio by all means!」

Calgurio who stands up and bows from the other side of the blinds, said that request to the Emperor.

Gadra turned a sharp gaze to Calgurio, but he let out a sigh like he have given up and reseated deeply.

Yuuki watched that exchanges with relish.

It's because the fool (Calgurio) seemed to move as he thought.

Anyway, the biggest wall for the rise of coup d'état is Armored Corps.

He thought that he wanted this corps to weaken quickly.

Calgurio was a man who should be call as officer than a

soldier. He's strong in battle but he's concerned about plan and certain victory, a riskless man.

But, he had the aspect not to mind a loss as he was greedy, and he will move if there's a worthy reason.

The important thing is as long as he given a reason, it's all good.

The Monster's Country Tempest has money. And, there's surely new technology that developed there from a different viewpoint that still unseen by the Empire.

Yuuki had guessed that Calgurio will moved if he showed the thing indirectly.

Money will attracts the nobles supporting Calgurio.

It will be a different story if a new technology is hidden, Calgurio will not move only by being requested by the nobles.

He will turn his fang greed not only to Tempest but also the satellite city and the labyrinth itself.

According to Yuuki' expectation, Calgurio seemed to dance wonderfully.

「Calgurio, are you going to steal the march?

Your Majesty, my Magic Beast Corps can also be deployed anytime.

Please give the wicked dragon subjugation to this me by all means!!」

The Beast King Gladim which kept silence before so roars.

Just by standing up, there was a feeling of overwhelming coercion in the place.

Definitely the personality of a ruler.

A great general that proud of the outstanding fighting power within the Empire which even rule the magic beasts under the power.

He's a person said to be the second strongest man in the Empire.

Calgurio and Gladim let their gaze intersected to restraint each other.

Seeing that situation, Yuuki let out a sigh in his mind.

The Magic Beast Corps was certainly strong but it's obvious that this corps wasn't suitable for this campaign.

So, he didn't think that Gladim will announced himself for it.

Though he doesn't deny that this corps is suitable for attacking, it's not cut out to challenge Veldora.

At any rate, the damage given will be not little and it's doubtful whether in the first place there are chances of victory.

Because Yuuki knew that the Armored Corps had working over for Veldora countermeasures, he can finish reading the strategy but he think that Magic Beast Corps will be hardly effective against Veldora.

From what he heard from Chloe's story, Veldora could be expected to have high combat ability.

It's not so bad when it's Armored Corps, but it will be difficult for Magic Beast Corps to won against Veldora.

And in this case, joint struggle don't have any meaning either.

In the first place, war is decided with number.

Even if there are 30.000 joined in, it will be overshadowed in front of an army that had size of hundred thousand.

No matter how strong that unit was, if their movement are limited, then it will be difficult to dealt an effective blow.

Not to mention, in case the few number separated, the worst case they will get encircled by the enemy army and each will be crushed...

Above all, it's ideal for Armored Corps and Veldora to face each other.

Therefore it's necessary for Veldora to come out to the front though——

About it, Yuuki don't worry that much.

It's still good enough if it crush Rimuru' executives or his subordinates' army even if Veldora doesn't appear.

Comparing Rimuru' army and Armored Corps, Armored Corps might be superior.

There seem to be several strong individuals among the executives but as for it this side also similar.

Calgurio was greedy, but he's not weak at all.

There are protégé special duty officer and strong soldiers also enrolled, so if Veldora doesn't appear then the chance of victory wouldn't waver.

It's wasteful to lose to Magic Beast Corps here.

Yuki thinks that it's necessary to do something.

「Please wait. I think it's better to entrust this to Calgurio-dono」

Calgurio float a thin smile to Yuuki' remark, Gladim have a bitter face.

And for the first time the Emperor, permitted the remark.

「Say it, state your thought」

Yuuki state the strategy with a humble look while hiding his thought in his mind.

First, the Armored Corps will invades from the front of Jura Great Forest area.

Sensing the invasion of large corps, it's certain that vigilance will be concentrated in Jura Great Forest area.

Then, from the north side will come another invasion in order to stun the west side as a simultaneously invasion.

「Do you say north side? Do you mean to pass through the Qanat Great Mountain Range?」

To Gladim' question, Yuuki denied it with a smile.

And, without any taunting feel,

「We can evade the battle against dragon if we go through the sea route」

So he declared.

Surely, judging from the flying range of the dragon, the sea route was out from the dragon's sphere of influence.

However, large sea monster inhabit the sea, and it's difficult to get rid of damage even if they went by a fleet.

It's difficult to keep the superiority with the exhausted force

even if it arrived at the north side's port after it pass through a disadvantageous naval battle.

In addition, the Empire owns several number of sea battleships, it exists to be used for subjugation against sea monster or large sea magic beast.

It's a reason needed to link the transportation fleet to transport the corps, but it will be not in time if prepared now.

The nobles and also the ministers raised a question to Yuuki' remark.

But,

「It's possible right? Calgurio-dono?」

Yuuki bring the subject to Calgurio with a smile.

Calgurio realizes Yuuki' intention at that point.

(Tch! This shitty brat... Did he aware of the existence of the treasured Airship?

Even though I concealed it so much and built it in secrecy...)

But, Calgurio thought about it.

It wasn't a bad strategy.

Calgurio had also considered the strategy to attack from the north side.

But, he stopped it this time because there will be a problem in the number of soldiers and the formation if he greatly distributed his corps.

He concentrate on Veldora and the labyrinth.

That was the decision that Calgurio put out though...

(It's interesting. The airship transports the Magic Beast Corps and afterward it devoted itself on support and supply.

As for snatching only the profit, this might be possible.

In any case, if I arranged a large force to launch a surprise attack from the north side of the west alliance,

It can be a reason to forestall the people to not turn their eyes to the other side.

The military gains are big. Of course, it will become a feat for Aerial Fighter Legion)

Calgurio quickly calculated it in his head.

The scales incline toward profit and lead to a decision.

「Well well, I can't be careless to Yuuki-dono.

I wonder where did you obtained that information from...

It's really astounding」

「No, no, it's because I have connections.

There're many acquaintances from the same town you see」

「I see.. I consent it.

It have been exposed earlier, but sure.

There's a new weapon called "Airship" which developed in my corps.

The Aerial Fighter Legion is making use of this new weapon.

This is the centerpiece, the trump card.

It possible for Aerial Fighter Legion to transport the Magic Beast Corps!」

By Calgurio' remark, the inside of the conference hall grows excited instantly.

It's because there's a way to invade the western countries without going through Jura Great Forest

It was natural that they were excited.

「However, approximately the maximum number of soldiers that can be transported is 100.000 people.

It might be difficult to conquer the west with only this.

Thus, I insist on the simultaneous strategy!」

Calgurio announces the strategy that he made in his mind while revising his own strategy.

100 ships of Aerial Fighter Legion will deal with Veldora, the remaining 300 ships will support the Magic Beast Corps.

The strategy will succeed perfectly if he send the best of the magician to fight Veldora.

While considering it, Gladim groans.

It will be a honor for soldier to fight against the strongest dragon named Veldora.

However, this strategy came with a reason.

Above all, there's seems to exist a group that specialized in individual combat that said to be the strongest group called Holy Knight Order in the west.

It seemed their number were only 200 people, but he thought that he wanted to have a fight with them once.

Besides, there exists a country with faith as the cornerstone in the west called Holy Empire Ruberios.

There seem to be Guard Army under the Pope' direct control that rival the Holy Knight in that country.

He will crush that Guard Army and trampled its holy capital.

Gladim felt that the beast's blood that flows in his body began to boil hot.

「It might be good! Let's go with that strategy!!」

The excitement in the large conference hall has risen further with the words of agreement roared by the Beast King Gladim.

「We'll win, we'll win without a doubt!!」

「Victory for us, people of the Empire!」

「Long live, Your Majesty the Emperor!!」

So in such situation, they were already entranced with imagination of the victory.

The strategy was worked out smoothly and the plan was settled without a hitch.

They finally got the permission from the Emperor and the strategy was approved.

A simultaneous two sides invasion strategy was decided with the sortie of the Empire.

Yuuki sneers in his mind.

Everything was going according to his expectations and he become desperate to endure his laughter.

With this, he can push away the nuisance Magic Beast Corps to distant place, and the weakening of Armored Corps will be certainly done too.

Even if Veldora doesn't come out particularly, the strategy is a success even if it just decreasing Rimuru' handpieces.

It can be say that best result is both side can be exhausted.

And he can consume the weakened empire from the inside and surge into a great war with all forces it has.

While the chaos arises in the world, let's aim at an opportunity to kill Rimuru in that gap.

Guy Crimson and Rimuru.

Two people who Yuuki should be careful with. He cannot be too careful with the other Demon Lords either, but he will manage it somehow if he had time.

Letting Chloe who is the strongest Hero dispose one, and in that gap he would get rid of the rest together with Chloe in one against one fight.

If he do so, the limitation of his own ultimate ability will disappears and it's possible to put Milim under his control.

But...

There was a reason why Yuuki didn't carry it out.

The reason why Guy Crimson didn't move for a long time is unknown.

The reason why that arrogant Demon Lord didn't move.

That's a uneasiness whether it's because of something which he should be cautious of.

He should be careful.

Therefore Yuuki hesitated about using his trump card named Chloe.

(Anyway, if this war become big and the world falls into disorder, something will happen.

Then, I may see the thing hidden if that happen right!)

Yuuki laughed happily and thinking about the event in the future.

Chapter 150: Expectations that Became True

On that day, I had finished the improvement of the surveillance magic, and proceeded to test it.

My current location is at the Tactical Class Military Operated Battle Command Post—— Aka, the Control Room.

Going with the flow of things I decided to give it a cool name, but now it's a little too long and I'm regretting it.

To be frank, only a few people knew its original name since everyone simply calls it “Control Room”.

It's newly established next to Veldora private quarters in the 100th floor of the dungeon, it's made possible to come in and out to this place from Tempest's Strategy Conference Hall.

The Important base was fundamentally established inside the dungeon.

The results were excellent.

Several large screens that were used during the tournament were set in this room, each of them displayed a scene from different places.

The various areas within Jura Great Forest, and the trade route with the Dwarf Kingdom. I'm now able to observe various important points one by one.

Even the state of the sea routes and the Qanat mountain ranges can be displayed without any problem.

The concept is simple.

Utilizing the 〈Physics Magic〉"Meggido (God's Wrath)" which I created, lens-shaped water drops which were handled by the spirit.

It's excellent as I can use it with low cost.

The images enlarged by the large lens are reflected onto a mirror to be relayed to a similar mirror deployed near the [Stratopause](#) and the images will be transferred to this place.

(成層圏界面付近 mean Stratopause, the boundary between Mesosphere and Stratosphere)

At the same time, the transmission of images is directly dealt with via 『Spatial Control』, leaving no moment of gap due to instantaneous transfer of data.

The images projected on the screen had HD quality after being processed by Wisdom King Raphael.

There're two projections, in case one get destroyed or is being deceived.

Now then, there's another merit from the completion of this surveillance system.

I'm able to use "Megiddo (God's Wrath)" while being inside

this Control Room.

I tested it by shooting it at Gobuta's feet who was training at the square, but I didn't think I would actually succeed.

The Gobuta' face who jumped up in surprise was unforgettable.

“You fool! It's because you let your guard down!!”

So I preached him instead, conversely though I thought that Gobuta wasn't so bad.

In addition, the performance of ” Megiddo (God's Wrath)” has improved.

Originally, it was optimized by 『Great Sage』 , but the current Wisdom King Raphael didn't seem to agree to it...

It developed it more meticulously and had developed a system of 24-hour satellites that would float in the sky.

It's usable even at night.

With my magic essence as the fuel, there's now a great spirit class geostationary satellite permanently hovering near the Stratopause.

Once it runs out, I would simply need to supplement it.

In addition, it's position that unrelated to day and night make it could convergence direct sunlight, so it's possible for it to reflect and radiate energy anytime.

It can't be helped that energy loss would occur, but still the power of the light ray was more powerful than before and can be used at night.

It's natural, but there's also a bit of energy loss even during the day.

As the amount of light it converged increases, so too does the amount of heat.

It's now even possible to exert powers on par with a heat ray gun.

I might even be able to completely annihilate the human army without moving a step.

I had such impressions as I've been carrying out the magic modification.

Well then, with the images of various areas displayed onto the large screen, the experiment was a success.

When I came back to the office after I confirmed the result, Shuna arrived and told me there was a guest.

From what I can see, there're quite a lot of them.

Oh well, you could say that most of my work involve interacting with guests.

And the rest are developing magic and coming up with items that looks interesting, oh and assigning the right man for the right job.

Playing is also part of my work.

With this feeling, I've faced my guest seriously.

I was guided by Shuna to the reception room, inside the room were four individuals waiting with nervous looks on their faces.

It was a familiar trio, and an old man I've seen for the first time.

The trio was Shinjii and co who played an active role in the previous capturing of the dungeon before.

First of all, we greet each other, and then I hear their circumstances.

As expected, under secret order from the empire, they seemed to be sent in order to collect information for the campaign.

They formally introduced their name, and started explaining their internal conditions

They've consented that this was an order from Yuuki. I thought it would have been him.

But unfortunately, our dungeon was more difficult than what Yuuki had anticipated.

Or rather, it was also harder than what I anticipated. This really isn't something people can simply laugh off.

If you think normally, you will not think about such a growth—— or rather that evolution—— I think it's an inevitable thing.

Well that's all good. Let's forget about it.

Well, afterwards they seemed to have reported this to Yuuki, but for some reason it has leaked out to the leaders of the other corps.

They were caught and seems to have been subjected to interrogation.

They were doused with drug to make them submit, and in the end a bomb appeared to be planted into their hearts.

At that time, Shinji's teacher, who was also the imperial court magician Gadra-roushi—who seemed to be the old man that came along with them—rescued them, and escaped to this place.

“Wait, are you guys all right with that bomb?”

When I asked,

“Ah, it has already been removed. We bought a new bracelet, and detonated it in the dungeon!”

Shinji replied with a nonchalant face.

It seemed the bomb was set to detonate itself if it was removed via surgery, it's seem to be a cliché bomb so it looks like they didn't think up another good plan.

Anyway, as soon as they were rescued from the jail by Gadra-roushi, they came to this side with Shinji's Transfer Magic.

They went to the labyrinth at once, then blew up the bomb inside the labyrinth before the empire side realized their escape and detonates the bomb.

Well... certainly they would revives even if they died inside the dungeon, but that certainly was a drastic act.

“Didn't you consider that it might affected the traps or monster battles inside the dungeon?”

So after I inquiry him, his face became pale and he was at a loss for words.

Apparently, they were panicked and didn't think to that extent.

“Hey, Shinji..... Oi! Don't tell me, that you didn't think about that!?”

So Mark retort,

“Ha, hahaha. I had thought about that, of course!”

Shinji answered whilst avoiding Mark's gaze.

Oh well, at that time Shinji had insisted that he going to treat it later with his abilities, but this couldn't be retorted as Shinji had tried it first.

After that, Gadra said that it would be better off to not believe Yuuki, and if that was the case they should defect.

I then pay more attention to Gadra-roushi for the first time.

He doesn't look too showy, but he worn a high quality like magic clothes, he is a sharp-eyed old man.

“So, that Gadra-san, why you come here together with them?”

To my question,

“To be honest, I'm a reincarnator.”

Gadra-san suddenly brought up a shocking revelation.

The trio also surprised, as they stared intently at Gadra-roushi.

According to what he said, he seemed to reincarnated many times in order to master the grand magic.

Then, he also participated in the previous Veldora subjugation war, and was splendidly killed...

“Honestly, it was the right choice for me to finished the reincarnation ritual beforehand.

I wanted to witness it with my own eyes. The highest pinnacle of monster brought about by nature”

There were only 4 “Dragon Kind” that borne unto this world.

They were the apex of monsters, the strongest being of this world.

And then, as this was said from his actual fighting experience, he didn’t think the empire would triumph over Veldora, so he said this to me.

And the Demon Lord that become a sworn friend with that Veldora, aka me, had raised his interest...

“I, don’t feel any particular obligation to the empire.

The corps that I had brought up with great care has been taken away, now I have no more attachments to it.

Besides, that Adalman resides in the dungeon of this country, or so I heard from my disciple...”

Wow, it seems that Gadra-roushi was Adalman’s friend from several thousand years ago.

At that time, in the west ——near the our side of the Jura Great Forest——was a small country, secret magic research seemed to be conducted in that country.

In a few brief words, he would read treasured books of each royal palace and build up his knowledge whenever he reincarnated.

It seems he was a born egotist and he asserted that he have no relation to things like loyalty.

He's quite the old man.

I'll keep the fact I actually respect him quite a bit to myself.

Of course, the details about Ramiris and the dungeon, he has heard it all from Shinji's tale! So it seems.

While whistling and pretend that he didn't know anything, he seemed to have played tricks on Shinji and co to make them talk, but there was no point to that anymore.

"The weapon that Shinji brought back, and the "Magic Crystal" was most intriguing.

Those greedy people started to cry loudly for the war to start.

When all is said and done, I think there still more 10 years

I planned to reincarnate before the war starts, but I failed.

However, the cause of that is the youngster named Yuuki.

The one that standing out recently, with enough influence to ascend to the top and become the new Corps leader...

He leaked the information to the other Corps leaders, and obviously had the interest to cause the war.

Well, that has nothing to do with me anymore.

Incidentally, I've decided to help my pupils because I was planning to escape with haste."

So the Gadra-jiisan brazenly declared.

But, if his words are true, then it's according to my expectations.

Yuuki made the fact that high quality "Magic Crystal" and high performance arms can be acquired from the labyrinth to be known.

'Then, what will happen?'

I could expect that people who suggest to start the war early would appear from the empire side.

To be honest, I'm not the patient kind. Over this one year, I've been whole-heartedly waiting, and it's been peeving me off.

Let's just finish this war, defeat Yuuki and save Chloe.

Therefore, I want that side to start attacking us, and I will ignored these three.

Otherwise, there will no reason to overlook them who we known were spies.

“All right, it’s as planned!”

Shinji was surprised with my declaration, but Gadra-jiisan simply nodded with a smug look on his face.

He seems to noticed our ulterior motive.

Of course, Yuuki probably already see through my thought, though he seems to have hopped on the plan and began moving.

According to what Gadra-jiisan said, the empire seems to have started to prepare for the start of the war.

I hear that surrender advice will be done once rather than the declaration of war.

Then I'll simply follow it if they started the battle, there will be no mercy after that.

If that's the case, this side also don't need to cut any corners.

I'll just finished it in a flash, and uproot the root of evil.

The three deserters were accepted at my own discretion.

Gadra-jiisan was given the guest treatment.

But, this Old man ended up as the new guardian of the 60th floor later, and become a hidden boss besides the Demon Golem though.....

That was a story unrelated to the current moment.

The conference of the war in the large conference room had ended, and the Emperor was relaxing in his room.

With a beautiful woman with hair of azure attending by his side.

Emperor Ludra was facing the beautiful girl at his side,

“Well then, the pawns seemed to be all present, Velgurind.

Do you think your younger brother would come out this time?”

So he asked her with an intimate tone.

The Beauty, Velgurind being asked, naturally replied the emperor.

The reason why he asked her that was because she was one of

the “Dragon Kind” the strongest being, the “Scorching Dragon” Velgurindo.

“Yea, Ludra. He would come out. Because that child loves festivals.”

“Is that so, that’s right huh. It would be great if our army could defeat him. Otherwise.....”

“This time for sure, I want to checkmate Guy and my elder sister Velzado.”

“Fufuu. So you’re aiming at Guy. If you fight against Veldora, then there’ll a chance for me.”

“Yes, it’s vexing. Otherwise, I’ll need to deal with that child (Veldora) quickly”

“HaHaHa.

However, this time my ability, the special skill of my Ultimate Skill 『Justice King Michael』 , enabled me to utilize the Armageddon(Army of Angel).

Guy' companions seem to increase in power, though they have united yet.

This time, we have an overwhelming advantage.”

“Oh? Then, should I execute a plan to bring that child over to this side.

Once taken down, he can't be Guy' piece, do you want to capture him after I weaken him?”

“Fumu, let's go with that. However, a human's flesh really is inconvenient.

Every time I reincarnate, inheriting the soul and ego.....

The ability limitation I suffered depends on the timing.

This time, I've waited until I'm at perfect condition

My army is well prepared, and there's no limitation on my ability.

If you can focus Veldora's Consciousness, my "Ruler's Control" should be able to take control of him."

"Oh, then victory is imminent.

But.....

Somehow that child, doesn't seem to be in his usual condition ever since his seal was removed.

His rampaging like violent magic essence storms had vanished completely.

Maybe he isn't back to his usual self yet?"

"Don't mind it.

Guy would simply discard weak people, he wouldn't make them into pawns.

Despite this, he's been raising Demon Lords, but he has yet to control them.

Actually, the newcomer Demon Lord named Rimuru seems to be popular with the other Demon Lords"

"That's true.

It would be against the rules for Guy if he turn human into his control.

And it would be against the rules for us to turn demon lord

into our pawns, but that's just fine.

Before that Demon Lord (Rimuru) grow up, it's best for us to crush him as soon as possible.

Even so, the Demon Lords gathered in that place at a good timing.

[Rimuru and Ramiris](#), we can take down two Demon Lords at the same time.”

(He referred to Rimuru and Ramiris with ㊦, basically treating them as small fries)

“Indeed. Well, let's try to rage as flashy as possible.

Once Veldora's in our grasp, their role ends.

You'll bestow upon them a rain of mercy with your Ultimate

Skill 『Charity King Raguel』 , it might be good if we conquered that town quickly.”

“So, let’s give them some charity after such a long time. Let give them a peaceful death (blessing)!”

The two spoke for a bit.

And then, on the next day.

A large army from the Empire with a size unprecedented in history depart with Monster Country’s Tempest as their destination.

Chapter 151: Great War Outbreak –Start–

Well well, I heard the detailed account from Gadra-jiisan and Shinji's group who came here before, and it was a certainty that the Empire had moved.

It's as expected.

First of all, a command post as the strategic union headquarters was set up inside the control room.

Benimaru and Souei will always be on stand by here.

Souei let out many of his clones to various places, our information gathering didn't rely only on image surveillance.

To be frank, to be able to use something like high altitude image surveillance in this world's war could be said as a out of the box technique.

No matter what I thought, I want to see it.

Previously, I was troubled which route would be attacked, but it's just a funny story now.

After all, to say nothing about dangerous route, even the situation inside the empire can be observed, so everything was completely exposed from their first action.

If this situation is compared to a Shogi match, then my side can see everything across the board, while the enemy only makes a move without knowing the move that my side had made. It's that kind of feeling.

Not only against an outstanding amateur, I will not get defeated by an expert enemy either.

I am not playing a game with a disadvantage handicap, but rather had an advantage (Absolute Superiority) at my side.

Oh well, it's not like war have rules or whatnot.

Righteousness is with the winner.

Anyway, there's no international laws in this world then there's no problem, as there were no rule to be abided either.

In the Council of Nations, more or less there is something resembling an international treaty, normally the course of the event would be the head of the warring countries decided the rule during the war and after the war before starting the war.

But, in the case of one-sided aggressor country, such rules didn't apply...

And so in this case, anything goes in this kind of war.

Frankly, the rule that I had decided was only one.

Involving the civilian is prohibited!

It's only this.

Of course, a follow up attack after I declared the war had ended, is absolutely prohibited.

Oh well, I believe there's no one that will go against my will and didn't abide this order.

Therefore, the Empire's forces which gathered one after another were projected on the several large screens.

The First Corps commanded by Gobuta and the Third Corps lead by Gabil were deployed as the Vanguard Force. Making use of their high speed movement, this allows the corps to deal with the situation in any location immediately.

Their numbers are few, but I judged it's not a problem if they devoted themselves on hit and run tactics.

But.....

「Wa! Hey... why's there a tank here!？」

A mere soldier like Shinji and co wouldn't know a lot about military secrets, so the tank's existence was not known to them.

As far as I observe them from the sky, there were 4.000 tanks.

Moreover, it seem to use magic essence as energy and it didn't seem to be necessary to replenishing its fuel.

This tank had high versatility and it seemed to have performance that exceeded our former world's highest performance tank easily if I only compared by their performance.

I don't know whether it moved only with magic essence, and there seems some kind of refueling, but judging from its speed, it was abnormal.

I assumed bad roads would not be a problem for it even while running with 100 km/h or more.

I rise from the ground slightly just like floating in the air.

‘Honestly, Magic is incredible!’ So I thought but more than that, I tasted the bitterness if only it also gets developed in here.

Obviously it incorporated the knowledge of the “Otherworlders”.

Even I could hit upon that idea but such ideas like a tank wasn’t suited in a world of sword and magic.

If only my head got more brains, then I could freely order for an idea

No, let’s stop.

There’s no use even if I regret it. It’s an issue for later.

When this war is over, let’s try developing things in various ways more freely.

We wasn't only surprised by the tank.

An airship flew.

'Seriously!?'

It was hard to hold back the screaming.

If there is that, transportation will become remarkably easy.
The supplies problem would be settled if it was used for war.

Besides, I am optimistic that I can steal the air supremacy one-sidedly, but this might be a tad self-conceited.

I was thinking of developing it, but it was practically impossible.

(I did various development but it was realistically impossible to be implemented.)??

I should really praise the fruits of the development team of that side, honestly.

Because there will be no invention of such level that can be completed overnight.

Well, nevertheless I want to capture one ship safely; after thinking for a bit, there is no other way.

Well, I was surprised because of the empire's military weapons, but even so my side wins in information warfare.

Raphael roughly counted the total of the empire's soldiers; there seem to be approximately 1 million soldiers.

An outrageous number has come out.

I didn't know how far Yuuki had spread his influence , but it will be difficult for him to keep this number under control, right?

I think this is probably because of the big effect from the bait I spread.

If that's so, the enemy army may aim for the labyrinth.

While I thought about the situation, a corps emerges and begins to detour towards a different direction from the direction that the tank corps is advancing to.

Apparently, that corps seems going to invade the border around the Dwarf Kingdom outskirts.

The tank pretends to be the main force, while the real main force was deployed on other place, huh.

Humph!, honestly only such impression comes out.

「What should we do? Should Gobuta and his corps that went to the frontline return?」

「No, their number is not enough anyway, let's entrust the main force that went to another direction to Gerudo.

I mean one portion of the enemy will enter the labyrinth, it will be easy to crush every one of them」

「I see, how's the labyrinth?」

Benimaru is unusually serious.

His usual frank speech has fallen silent, he now bared his true nature as the supreme general.

He's really reliable.

「Ramiris, could you take in the entire adventurers' town around the labyrinth into the labyrinth?」

「I could you know~! No problem at all!」

I see, then let's do it like that.

Having said that, I explained the circumstances to Masayuki, the Commander of the Volunteer Army.

“Eh, really? Is that thing even possible?”

Then I left the rest to the surprised Masayuki.

Apparently, the story became like, after persuading the Demon Lord, he made me to definitely promise to protect the town.

‘As expected from the Hero-dono!’

‘Really reliable!’

Like that, he receives the praise from the town citizens, Masayuki observed the spectacle with a complicated face.

But, even with this expression,

‘Hero-dono is still not yet satisfied’

‘That’s right, that’s right’

‘Hero-dono will protect this town. We can be at peace if we entrust everything to him!’

Such interpretations are made, there was no one that noticed Masayuki’ suffering.

Thus, the surface town was moved entirely to the 101st floor of the labyrinth.

The 100th floor and the 95th floor changed places, it shifts every single floor and so the defense system was perfectly established.

Or rather, it might be impossible for those troops to go past the 90th floor.

Because even with supplies, several days are their limit. As they can't use the inn inside the labyrinth, such thing as breaking through is impossible.

The remodeled soldiers could go through two weeks without eating and drinking so Shinji and co said, but it's unthinkable for them to capture the labyrinth in two weeks.

Oh well, I can't be careless, I will think about it at the time that side had already come to attack.

There's also the possibility that they keep going inside the labyrinth, but it might be useless to think about that for now.

Well, with such feeling I prepared the preparations. ??

The town around the labyrinth is isolated, and Gerudo's second corps with 17.000 people was deployed as the frontage of

Tempest.

Inside there were 10.000 volunteer soldiers and a corps of 50.000 monsters were waiting.

Because the surrounding countries will also received the news that the Empire had moved, they could succeed in organizing their army quickly, but it might probably will be too late.

I wasn't able to summon them before the war, but the empire's movement exceeds my expectation.

After all, I only asked them to organize and requested to maintain the status quo in a standby state.

The worst case is we got besieged and waiting for reinforcements, but in that case it's already a losing battle.

Oh well, it depends on the situation.

Well then, the preparations of this side were completed as well, so let's start the war formally.

The Jura Great Forest, my territory as a Demon Lord, has already been invaded by the tank force.

As to not make the enemy realize it that our side foresees everything, I left them alone until the preparation was complete.

The situation is already a territory invasion but let's give them warning with a feel like we have just noticed them.

By the way, I dispatched the newcomer to each corps as an intelligence officer.

Gobuta, while looking dubiously,

「A woman who doesn't have business with the battle is unfit for the first corps you know-ssu!」

Said so, but that woman true identity is Testarossa.

‘You...will be killed by me!’ so, she said and Gobuta fell silent.

I mean, that way seems more interesting.

Let’s wait expectantly for him to starts「Ga, gasp!」or something like that later.

In contrast to Gobuta, Gabil has matured.

「There are many circumstances that I don’t understand, so I’m counting on you!」

So he said when I introduced him to Ultima.

Testarossa, Ultima, Carrera.

To be honest, the one with the cruelest personality among this three Demon Dukes might be Ultima.

Gobuta might be in danger if I swapped the one sent to his corps.

On that point, Gabil seemed to have taken a liking to Ultima.

That's great, that's great.

Although I inform them that while obeying the general's order, their true identity must never be exposed, but I feared that they would do something without any hesitation.

While still obeying the order, and yet, perform a retribution at the enemy. Ultima seems to be a person who will do such kind of thing.

Gabil, it seems you have saved your own life after I had warned you to not get cocky.

Therefore, the current amusement is only Gobuta.

Oh well, as for Testarossa which I dispatched as an intelligence officer, they would be obedient in the beginning, while wait and see.

As long as it's in the limits of my order.

So, I get in contact with Gobuta.

First of all, issuing the warning... Well, who should I pick?

Gobuta was lacking in showiness, Gabil was a hidden force for the time being as he was on standby in the air.

If it comes to this....

(Testarossa, I entrusts this to you!)

(Yes, thank you very much! I will meet your expectations surely!)

I order Testarossa.

Oh well, if it's her, I will not have to worry that she's going to die even if the empire doesn't want useless talks and attack her.

It's a farce, but it's necessary to be cliché.

It's alright even if I exterminate them all without saying anything, but a Demon Lord needs to do put up a performance.

Lieutenant General Gastar who was Calgurio's confidant lied on his back at his personal use command vehicle placed behind the latest tank corps, listening to the situation of the Great Forest's surroundings.

His position as Lieutenant General was appropriate as Gastar's ability is high.

He possess ability to control sound and he also posses ability to finely analyze the situation just by hearing various sounds, Unique Skill called 『Musician』 .

Also, he can give specific instructions using a special wave and he can give an order only to his allies even during a scuffle.

In addition, he had the hidden trump card that can cause cytoclasis using sound wave cannon and he was an influential person who held a high ranking position within the Empire.

That Lieutenant General Gastar notices that the surrounding sounds suddenly ceased and so, gave a halt order to the entire army.

A short time later after he issued that order, he saw three people walked from the forest's direction.

They weren't an ordinary traveler, and no one would think that this is just a chance encounter.

A beautiful woman was leading the three, she possess a beauty that can't be thought to be a human's.

Her scarlet hairs flowed lovely and made her good looks stand out.

But, on contrary with that beautiful face, her body was wrapped in a formal military uniform.

The two people who followed on her rear were similar, a middle-aged handsome man who seemed to be strict and a bit fat man of unknown age wore a military uniform with a same design.

Gastar understood and had no doubts that these three people were the Demon Lord's subordinates.

When the woman stopped her walk, she bowed and had a

sweet smile towards their direction.

「Everyone, nice to meet you for the first time.

My name is Testarossa.

I'm a retainer of the great Demon Lord Rimuru, the master of this area.

Then, the business I have today is...

『I will overlook this if you all leave right now. But, I will not pardon it further if you all went in more than this』

to convey these words of my master」

So, that woman——Testarossa seems to be her name——said, at the same time the man behind her lightly wave his hands.

A wall of flame appeared at the moment 1m in front of the most forward invading tank.

The wall of flame vanishes instantly, leaving a burnt mark on the ground that became a straight line.

「You all already understands right?

When you passed this line, your lives will forfeit.

People who don't have the resolution mustn't pass it.

Well then, have a good day」

Testarossa turns back from that spot after she leave behind a graceful bow.

The men behind her like followed her to leave the place.

They said what they want to say one-sidedly, without even considering this side at all.

Their conducts instigated Gastar's anger.

(Do it!)

Gastar briefly give an order to the sniper.

Receiving the order, the soldier who held the sniper rifle take aims on Testarossa.

And then, silently a soundless type magic bullet was shot——

Testarossa who turned around, deepens her smile and laughs evilly.

The magic bullet which should pierce her body was, precisely, stopped by Testarossa's delicate index finger.

The bullet initial velocity reaches three times of speed of sound and it's a lump of undetected magic power.

At the same time of bullet impact that magic power will be released, that bullet which should kill and wounding the target surely was just plucked in the mid flight without any problem and was lightly thrown away.

Just like dealing with a worthless toy.

And then, the three walk away without turning around again and leave without saying anything.

Fear and confusion almost bursting inside Gastar's mind but he suppressed it with his willpower.

The ordinary soldier didn't understand what just happened. Only himself and the sniper that could notice what just happen.

Inside Gastar's mind, fear and humiliation were hanging on the scales, and the one which won was the humiliation.

「Don't be confused! The victory is dedicated to His Majesty the Emperor! All troops, charge!!」

The tank corps started to advancing all at once to the Gatar's loud voice command.

They stepped over the warning line easily and the war had begun.

Chapter 152: Great War Outbreak – Agitation and Resolution–

The war had begun.

It started earlier than I had expected.

The final warning line that Testarossa pointed out was stepped over by the Empire's forces without any hesitation.

At that moment, the Eastern Empire and Monster's Country Tempest fell into a state of war.

As an immediate response, Benimaru's instruction were transmitted to the first and the third corps via Thought Link.

The two forces of the Tempest Military began mobilizing simultaneously.

Since the power of the tank cannon was unknown, it was

suicidal to stay in the same position carelessly.

There was still some distance left to traverse before both armies made contact, but we couldn't be careless as the effective range of the enemy's weapon was still not clear.

The most striking difference between the former world's and this world's tank might be its shorter barrel.

Inside the Jura Great Forest where trees grew densely, there existed some trade routes.

The tank corps came invading from the east, passed through the meadows and crossed the large river, but its turret length wouldn't cause any trouble when rotating the gun turret even inside a forest with its dense trees.

It was questionable whether this had any effect on its accuracy and range, but judging from the performance of the weapons they were carrying such as the rifle from a while ago, I thought that this situation was clearly problematic.

The rifle from a while ago was silent and had no recoil.

I could not confirm its silence as it was only a detailed scene projected onto the large screen that couldn't reproduce the audio.

If there was someone on the actual site, they could use a video crystal to transmit the video on the monitor together with the audio, but I couldn't reproduce the audio using surveillance magic.

Oh well, as the magic processes the image's wavelength via a high altitude light source, lag would surely occur if I tried to transmit the audio.

Only, this was not at the level that Raphael could correct.

Is it easier to understand if I use an analogy of thunder?

Since there was a several second lag from the light, it wouldn't be able to transmit if it was also burdened with sound.

That was why I couldn't determine whether the rifle from before was silent or not from the image of the large screen, but it became clear that the rifle was silent after the Thought Report coming from Testarossa.

In this case, it could be said that this gun was a magic tool.

It substituted gunpowder with a magic formula.

Certainly, the tank would have the same technology with no recoil, high precision to some extent, and a lack of sound.

What needed to be determined was its range and power.

I was not fighting personally, but it was more worrisome than what I had thought just from watching my companion's fight.

But, the only thing I could currently do was assess the situation.

Let's watch this fight attentively.

Before situation progressed, I stated my opinion of using the improved〈Physics Magic〉”Megiddo (God's Wrath)”.

But, Benimaru rejected that idea——probably after he had consulted with Raphael.

There seemed to be a few reasons for this.

First, to begin walking on the road as a country, they couldn't always rely on the Demon Lord that was their king—— me.

If they were aware that this was their country and didn't have any intention of defending their own country, then they didn't have the qualifications to live in this country.

That was the first reason.

The next one was the weakness of "Megiddo (God's Wrath)".

It was a formidable magic that I could activate while sitting inside the control room.

However, there would be some countermeasures made once its materials are exposed.

Because I exterminated everyone last time, there was no information leaked about "Megiddo (God's Wrath)".

But, Benimaru explained that in this kind of war, if I used it carelessly, there was bound to be a survivor, and it was certain that "Megiddo (God's Wrath)" would be dealt with immediately.

Its real identity was of high temperature rays of bundled sunlight, and evasion by sight was almost impossible.

However, some degree of protection could be acquired if one was coated with materials that possessed a heat insulating effect.

I judged that it was not easy to destroy the tank when the tank corps appeared.

I might not be able to penetrate the tank if I didn't raise the power and increased its temperature to 10,000 degrees.

Also, I could predict that there would be no blazing explosion as it was not powered by fuel.

I might penetrate it, but it might not stop the tank's movement.

I could said that its power was tremendous for anti-personnel magic, but it was a different story when facing such modern weapons.

Perhaps, it would be easier to just blow them all away with a normal nuclear strike magic.

In that case, it was necessary to deal with the magician who put up the barrier first, and in the end it would proceed into a

war where we would be dragged into a bog of wars, and this was.....

Not a story that would end out well.

Then, should I only aim at the personnel? So I thought, but I could comprehend that this was impossible, even for me.

I was peerless against Farma Kingdom, it was possible because I had confronted them on the site personally.

If I was going to shoot precisely, I needed to prepare various relay points to utilize the reflection of the light.

That was clearly impossible while looking through a large screen.

Still this was because I couldn't accurately grasp the space with 『Magic Power Perception』 since there was space between me and the battlefield.

So for long ranged attacks, it will always come down from the sky.

I surely understood Benimaru's argument, because it could be expected that they would take measures against it if I used it hurriedly. It seemed I needed to ascertain the situation before I used it.

Then, my job was to watch, since I gave Benimaru the right to command.

With such reasons, I was watching the battlefield.

Gobuta's corps moved to the flank smoothly with perfectly coordinated movements.

Most likely, the Empire forces would try to grasp their position with monster detection magic.

From here on, it was a match of skill and speed.

Gobuta was going as Benimaru's will, striking the flank of the tank corps with the speed of thunder.

They were quicker than the rotation of the tank turret, and their aim was to slip into the tank from the front.

They withdrew after delivering a blow to the infantry unit which was placed to protect the blind spot of the tank turret.

Their refined beautiful movements were projected on the large screen.

I could clearly tell that their mobility was high, even from the image which Souei's intelligence photography corps sends.

Like a huge monster running through the battlefield as it pleased.

At the same time, a battle had also begun in the sky.

The third corps led by Gabil, which were hidden in the sky, attacked the airships.

The enemy seemed considerably surprised by this and was not able to deal with them immediately. As a result, they succeeded in sinking about three of them in an instant.

It was the result of the repeated hit and run tactic used by all the members to attack in waves without being greedy.

Even Gabil had handled the training of his subordinates considerably well, and he seems to have acquired a remarkable air combat force.

There wasn't much power in the fireballs breathed out by the wyverns.

But, maybe thanks to everyone concentrating their attacks on a single spot, the numerous fireballs that they breathed out penetrate the airship's magic barrier.

However, the original strategy was to attack the ground from the sky.

Even though they never assumed that the battle would become an air-to-air battle, what might be called a great strenuous effort had brought about a splendid result.

Gobuta and Gabil.

Those two showed the great results of their training and achieved result in their first actual combat.

However, not everything would go smoothly.

It would be proved immediately.

Lieutenant general Gastar, bitterly glared at the approaching

cavalry.

(These damned people are getting cocky!!)

He clears his mind which was filled with anger as the monsters approach from the front. This reminded him of the terror planted by the demon named Testarossa with scarlet hair not too long ago.

The monsters who can only do hit and run may not be able to damage the tanks no matter how fast they moved.

He quickly orders his subordinates to prepare the tank cannon.

Along with the shell type that packed magic essence and increased the destructive power, the tanks contained another attack that fired a converged magic essence gathered from the air like a beam.

If it's a shell, it's possible to accomplish rapid fire even if the

quantity is limited.

In case it's a beam, energy charge takes time of a little over three minutes but there's no quantity limitation for it.

Because it's possible to alternate between these two types of attacks, the beam type is shot first and the normal shell is shot during the time it takes for the next beam to be charged.

The tank's cannon preparation was completed according to Lieutenant general Gastar's order.

(In the first place, what are those guys in the sky doing. They should have started bombarding them from the sky to sweep the ground!)

Gastar commanded the tank in the outer circumference of the corps to aim and shoot the cannons at the surroundings trees while getting angry at the carelessness of his colleagues.

The tank corps started expanding the battlefield by mowing

down the surrounding trees while alternating between the two types of shells.

In the first place, despite how large the trade route is, it's quite narrow if three tanks form a line.

Because they were at a disadvantage as the enemy was setting up surprise attacks with speed much higher than a wild animal from the gaps of the overcrowded trees.

First of all, they began to create an advantageous situation by transforming the battlefield.

The subordinates who received the order handled the task properly without being flustered. The neighboring trees were mowed down without taking much time and a space wide enough to operate the tanks was created.

As the result, the superiority of the first corps led by Gobuta was lost as the obstacles they used to cover and hide were removed.

A fierce battle also started in the sky.

At first, they were caught off guard and suffered some losses but Major General Faraga who commanded 100 airships of the Aerial Fighter Legion was a capable man.

In the current mission, the cornerstone of the anti-Veldora containment strategy was the airship which could be called an air fortress that had the largest magic canceller device installed.

Piloting it was the elite wizard class member who commands the magicians.

Adjustment of the magic amplification cannon was vital. Also, the magic barrier was laid out to always protect the airship.

Furthermore, Shield (Wall Shield), which is a magic to deal with physical attacks, is amplified to prevent attacks to the airship.

A superficial attack will not surpass it, actually after the first

wave of attacks, the airship didn't suffer any damage from the wyvern's fireball.

Major General Faraga unconsciously sprout a smile and regained his composure. After becoming calm, he felt resentment as three airship had sunk after being surprised by the likes of Wyvern.

The deployment of Shield was not done in time and the attack surpassed the magic barrier, and became the proof of his carelessness.

With such anger he faced the approaching Wyverns,

「Counterattack! To magicians who stand by at the magic amplification cannon station, begin the spell chant!」

So, he issued an order.

The spell of the magician who usually fire it was amplified to 20 times of its power by the magic amplification cannon.

It's a cannon only in name, actually it's just a pedestal with an ability to amplify the used magic.

A huge spell control orb was made with a magic stone of high purity ——Originally, orbs which were attached to staffs were as big as a fist ——due to spell amplification effects, various large-scale magics were able to be casted.

In the battlefield of the sky, lights of dazzling magic spells danced wildly with lighting, blizzard, fire and wind.

Of course, Gabil and his corps which became the targets couldn't be said to be safe from it.

I, who was watching the progress, rose from my seat.

Several of Gobuta's subordinates were blown off after receiving the explosion of the tank cannon.

Attacked by large-scale magic, the Wyverns fell together with the Lizardmen who were riding them.

Casualties began to appear at the same time the initial superiority was lost.

Casualties were expected.

No, I expected it, but I might have been optimistic.

I will win without a big deal.

Since Raphael didn't say anything, I had the naïve thought that there would be no problems.

But, reality was different.

Well, that is so because it's a war after all.

It can't be a natural thing to win without any damage received by this side.

I felt anger and agitation to an extent to I couldn't say anything as I clearly saw my naiveté.

「Please sit down, Rimuru-sama. It's within the predictions. There's no problem」

Benimaru said to me with a calm aura.

To his words, I reacted as if something was exploding inside of me.

「You, can't you see that causalities have appeared! Therefore, I will go out and use “Megiddo (God's Wrath)” ——」

But, my words were interrupted in the middle.

「That's no good. As the supreme commander, I can't allow the king to be exposed to danger.

Above all, the enemy side has the dangerous person named Yuuki.

In addition, I heard that the Emperor's Imperial Guards are strong.

There might be other strong people in the Empire.

Without knowing the enemy's war potential, for the king to go out to the front is out of question.

Please believe in us.」

I feebly sat down on the chair because of his words.

The unpleasant feeling that was neither anger nor agitation

didn't fade away.

There was nothing I could do, because Benimaru's words were correct.

Shion who was standing behind me , Souei who stands by the side too.

There's nothing to say about Diablo, Shuna who was looking at me anxiously, I realized that everyone already prepared for victims to appear.

Also, it wasn't only the people in this room——

Perhaps, everyone that was fighting on the front too.

With their resolution to become the bait to lure out the strong people, they would stand in the battlefield.

It was only me that had no resolution.

And then at that time,

——Therefore, I have to be perfect——

So, I thought that I heard the voice somewhere.

Even you too, are you worrying about me?

But, now it's alright.

Me grieving all the time would be rude to those people.

「Sorry, I was not calm for a moment.....」

When I apologized to Benimaru, he nods,

「Rest assured. Victory will certainly be yours 」

So, he promised me.

His usual carefree face was not there, now it is the serious expression of a great general that held the life of his soldiers in his hand.

To his words, I felt my agitation, troubles and unpleasant feelings disappear.

I had already prepared to kill my enemy even if I had to die with him.

But, for someone to die for my sake, I didn't think about it too deeply.

It was necessary for me to accept it.

That act is done not only for my sake, it's for their family and the country that protects them, for the existence that symbolizes them all. And that is me.

For this reason, as my compensation for their action, defeat was not allowed.

「Of course. Convey my word to everyone. Okay?」

「Yes! By all means」

I obtained Benimaru's approval and displayed the maximum ability of 『Thought Control』 , and gave out the order to all subordinates joined to the genealogy of my soul while putting forward all my emotions,

『Hear this! Defeat the enemy with all your power.

It's not necessary to show mercy and there is no need to go easy.

With all of the power that you have, eliminate the enemy immediately!!』

Benimaru nods to my words and smiles appear on the faces of the executives.

That order meant one thing.

‘Release the restrained power.’

Properly understanding the meaning of my words, the monsters resumed their action.

And then.....

My words would greatly change the state of the war.

Chapter 153: Great War Outbreak –The beginning of the trampling–

Every monster on the battle, heeded the words of their master (Rimuru) through their souls.

Their absolute ruler who has accepted their loyalty and trust.

Their hearts were filled with joy and left to their welling impulse, their magic power was unleashed.

As they lived in the town, their magic essence which were suppressed in consideration of their environment was unleashed. The surrounding concentration of magic essence went up a level.

They no longer fear anything.

With that impulse, they dashed towards the battlefield.

Gobuta signaled his aide with his eyes, beckoned him over.

In this battlefield, moving as a group would instead breed danger of being targeted.

As the result of observation and discussion (arbitrarily with Wisdom King Raphael), it was concluded that the aim of the tank's main armament was done visually.

Thus, if the enemy treated the group as a single monster, their actions would be easily predicted and them aimed at.

「From now, all squad are permitted to attack freely.

Ogre Wolf (Star Wolf Oni-kin) will become the leader and lead the Green Numbers (Green Corps).

Even while everyone are acting freely, our thought are always linked, so don't forget to cooperate」

「It's not the time for me to be playing around-ssu.

Our lord is watching us-ssu.

Because of that I can't do an unsightly behavior, I will get serious now-ssu」

Looking at Gobuta's eyes, the aide realized Gobuta's seriousness.

The seriousness of his superior that rarely seen.

“[May the fortunes of war with you!](#)” so the aide said and immediately issued the command to the army.

the original blessing was 御武運を, which is an encouragement and a blessing for safe returns during the Sengoku era.

And then,

「Don't get caught up! General Gobuta will going to be serious!!」

The aide didn't forget to say so.

The Ogre Wolves who were originally joined alongside him, and as Gobuta's subordinates, they knows pretty well that Gobuta is a genius.

His leadership ability was abnormally high, and under Gobuta's teaching everyone's skill progressed abnormally.

Not to mention, Gobuta's individual combat ability can't be summed up by a single word 'genius'.

Gobuta's command ability was completely no good, but such a thing didn't become a problem due to his excellent intuition.

In addition, it's to the degree one would think he received suggestions from someone hidden, he make a decision when he sees the chance.

If that Gobuta concluded that the whole army moving as one was no good, then to disperse might be the correct answer.

Also, Gobuta with “Transform (Demon Wolf Fusion)” he got from his Unique Skill 『Become my power (Demon Wolf Summon)』, he was strong to the extent that even if the Ogre Wolves come at him together, they were not a match for him.

Because they knew this well, their action was swift.

Gobuta pushed forward to the enemy line alone.

He seen the tank’s barrel faces his direction,

「Well then, it’s time to rampage-ssu! Transform!!」

In an instant, black fog wrapped Gobuta .

(I’ve been waiting, Gobuta. Let’s show our power to Rimuru-

sama!)

To respond Ranga's speech in his mine,

「We'll show it in a good place-ssu. Let's go-ssu!」

The inter magic power was unleashed.

The black fog that swallowed Gobuta disappeared, a single goblin warrior clad in a black wolf manifested from it.

A humanoid black wolf with two ominous horn protruding.

tank shells that come flying hardness bounced off its black fur that changed in hardness.

When Gobuta howled, "Black Lighting" pouring down from the sky onto the tank corps, creating dazzling light as it clashed with the defense barrier applied to the tank.

Observing the situation, Gobuta perceived that it has effect on the electric shock effect caused by the lighting strikes.

However, it didn't seem that the electric shock-proof ability was perfect, as the lighting seems to give serious damage on the precision machine parts.

Gobuta laughed.

(This isn't a big deal-ssu)

Well then, let's get started.

Gobuta ran through the battlefield gleefully.

Reaching speeds beyond sound, the empire's tank corps could no longer follow him with naked eyes.

The tank corps fell into disarray inside the resounding

thunder.

And then,

「Well~, how far you can follow me-ssu? Dance with Wolves (Gale Demon Wolf's Dance)!!」

A black gale dash through the battlefield and the tank corps was assailed by destruction caused by its sonic boom.

Before long, the shock waves became a tornado and it generated “Tornado Storm of Ruin” which exceeded “Storm of Ruin”.

With extremely calculated movement, the enemy force was efficiently annihilated.

That was “Dance with Wolves”, Gobuta's dreadful anti-army annihilation technique.

One of the battlefield ended in this way.

When Gobuta begun being peerless on the ground, changes also occurred in the sky.

For the third corps led by Gabil.

Soon after Gabil heard Rimuru's "voice",

「Hear this! We shall go down the path of asura!!」

He declared so.

The monsters tightening their expressions simultaneously.

Gabil's words continues.

「Blue Numbers (Blue Corps), you guys are inexperienced.

Therefore, support the battle on the ground!」

Don't do the impossible, just proceed like the training.」

「However, the numbers of that flying thingies——Airship——are still.....」

「There's no problem! You guys don't need to worry, display your power freely!」

It's regrettable that they didn't train for air battle, but it's no use even if they think about it now.

That was a topic for after the war.

The Blue Numbers heeded Gabil's order and left the sky battle stage.

Separating from Gabil's command, each one of them

supported the ground corps.

The momentum of the ground corps would accelerated as they receives support from the sky.

When Gabil was sure of that, he glared at the frontward of the Empire army aerial legion.

「Hiryuu, Who is the ruler of the sky?」

『It is us, Tempest's Hiryuu!!』

「That's right. For people that defiles our sky, we must get rid of them.

This is the order of Rimuru-sama.

Everyone, use all of your power.

Don't let your ego be swallowed, all right? All members,
『Dragon Warrior Transformation』!!』

『Ohh!!』

The Hiryuu responded to Gabil's order.

Their trump card called 『Dragon Warrior Transformation』 .

Their fighting power increased tremendously, but so did their ferocity.

Because they couldn't suppress the destructive impulse, this ability had been sealed until now.

However, Rimuru's order was to reveal all of their power, an order like that.

There was no reason to hesitate.

『Dragon Mode (Dragon Body Change)!!』

All member of Hiryou unleashed their original power simultaneously.

That was the moment when the true combat ability of Tempest strongest corps was released.

Dark red muscles swelled instantly and their outer skin was covered completely with jet black dragon scales.

Their stature grew 1.5 times, and their volume and mass increased greatly too.

Their offensive power and defensive power, it goes without saying, but it was incomparable to before the transformation.

If they lost their sense of self now, then they were nothing but a mere incarnation of power but.....

They succeeded in keeping their ego splendidly.

This was the moment when a true dragon warrior was born.

「Each person bring down one ship. Can you guys do it?」

『Of course!!』

「Alright, let's go for it!!」

The dragon warriors move simultaneously to Gabil's order.

The Empire's treasured Aerial Fighter Legion was already no more than pitiful lambs.

Because the special effects of the 『Dragon Warrior Transformation』 magic has no effect on them

Even natural effect like “Megiddo” has no effect against them.

A barrier that nullified all kind of magic attacks as well as natural effects was generated spontaneously and protected their body.

Their energy was strengthen until it can be said to be equal to beyond A rank [EP: 40.000~60.000], that power exceeded a high rank devil.

Besides, as for Gabil who was originally a strong individual.....

He transformed into a fierce warrior boasting an absurd amount of energy.

And that power,

「Here I go! Take this, my special move! Tornado Crash (Water Spear Vortex Strike)!!」

The current of air swirled into a vortex, it converged the moisture in the atmosphere at one point and that big vortex of magic power swallowed one airship whole.

The magic power barrier knitted with magic power of more than 100 magicians was broken without any resistance at all.

Correction, it sunk the ship instantly.

Gabil excitedly,

「Fuhahahaha! Now, let's keep it goes steadily.

For those who couldn't even sink a ship, you guys understand what will happen later right?」

Said those words to member of Hiryou who stiffened.

The surviving airships were already cut down to below 100

ships. It was a situation where several people would not get a prey.

At the same time as they realized it, every member of the Hiryyu rushed on towards the airship each one of them aimed for.

Major general Faraga was in shock of the spectacle in front of his eyes.

Shields were deployed in front of the air fortress in addition to the magic power barrier that always protected it.

One of such airship was sunk by a single strike of that monster.

It was a rare race called a Dragonewt , it seems to possess fighting strength that earned them the nickname humanoid dragon.

When there was only 100 ships left in the sky, he had an

unpleasant premonition.....

Suddenly, he received a report from the observation team that the enemy power increased suddenly.

Soon after he felt anxiety of seeing the wyvern riders withdraw, an abnormality happened.

It was more precise to say that the phenomenon was called transformation.

The remaining dragonewts displayed fighting power that surpassed the wyverns and they came attacking the airship.

The airship fired amplified magic, yet it appeared to be completely ineffective.

It was as if to say that the magic itself was ineffective.

(Kuu, like there could be such a ridiculous thing!)

With magic canceller, it weakens the monster's strength to move.

Using such principle, it suppose to weaken them but as the target's movement was too quick, it was not possible to catch them.

But, to the individual whom was supposedly the enemy commander who delivered the first strike, Faraga felt that the effect of the weakening wasn't so significant.

He understood that the enemy commander's strength was on a completely different dimension.

It would be difficult to stop the movement of that individual if they didn't concentrate the wave of all magic canceller generating devices.

Or perchance.....

(No way, is that individual “Veldora”!?)

Faraga consented to his thought instinctively.

‘I see, he’s weakened after the seal was removed so the rumor said, but to have weakened and transformed to that form.....

No, on top of that, because he still has such strength, I can’t imagine how strong he was before he was sealed.

But, on the contrary it will be easy to kill the current him.’

When Major general Faraga has such a realization and was about to order a concentrated attack,

「Hey? Do you not serve even tea to a guest here?

I was thirsty though?」

A beautiful girl with long bluish purple hair styled as a ponytail, had sat on his aide's seat before anyone can noticed.

She worn a military uniform, making her appearance unbefitting of her age.

(Where did she come from!? No, there's something other than that——)

「Who the hell are you?」

Hearing Faraga inquire for the girl's identity, his subordinates turn around and notice the girl.

They didn't detect any abnormality inside the ship.

And yet, that girl was there like it was natural.

「Who I am, you said? My name is Ultima.

I came today to ask about various things.

You guys are going to die soon right?

Therefore, before it happens I want you guys to teach me about various things!」

The girl said such words with an innocent smile on her face.

But, Faraga was familiar with the very indescribable feelings he felt from the girl.

If he want to compare it, right, it's like when he was facing the high ranking people with absolute strength of the Emperor Imperial Guards....

No, anymore than this was imprudent.

(No way..... Did I feel fear? From such a girl!?)

However, it's a fact that this girl was an abnormal existence as she invaded the ship by herself.

Major general Faraga pull out his military sword and took a stand against the girl.

Faraga had quite the amount of confidence in his swordsmanship. He was confident that he wouldn't lost even against an active A rank Adventurer.

The air around Faraga changed, an invisible thread of tension formed between him and the girl.

「What do you want to ask?」

Faraga asked the girl.

That girl——Ultima——nods joyfully,

「The structure of this ship and how to operate it. The war potential in the Empire.

Are there any strong individuals? Everything excluding the current attacking corps.

Well, amongst other things.

You don't need to worry. Because even if you don't talk I can steal your knowledge on my own.」

While declared so brazenly,

「You are an unfortunate fool. The one in front of you is one of such strong individual!」

Faraga immediately swung down his sword that he raised overhead aiming at the chance when Ultima was talking.

A sword skill he often taught his subordinate, a sword slash at the level of a master.

A sure-kill strike, not even a devil could avoid it and would be bisected.

「Then, I will ask starting with you.」

「Eh?」

He heard a voice from behind.

Far from cutting Ultima who should have sat on the chair, Faraga's sure-kill strike couldn't touch her at all as it cut empty air.

And, the impossible thing was the one who should have sat on the chair in front him has moved to his rear before he realized.

「What!？」

When Faraga turned around in a panic, a round mass of something came flying.

Splat! it hit the wall, leaving behind a stain..

One of the magicians who lost his head had his body collapsed onto the floor , convulsing as if it's still alive.

「It's not such a big deal. Here comes more~」

So she said, Ultima keep repeating the act of plucking off heads and then throw it away after touching it for several seconds.

The bridge was transformed into hell dyed with screams and terror.

「All, all hands, use magic canceller!!

Aim and concentrate it on the demon in front of you!!」

Magicians who fell into panic in terror regained their sanity because Faraga's words.

Everyone who carrying magic canceller radiated it towards Ultima in panic.

「Ohh, is this thing magic canceller?

That new weapon right? That said to have a tremendous effect on all kind of monster.

But, is there any meaning of doing this?」

Ultima muttered a question while tilting her head lovely.

「Haha, you're done now bitch. Don't think you can get away by bluffing!」

Faraga regained his composure and sent a signal to his subordinate.

The soldiers pull out their gun simultaneously and aimed it towards Ultima.

「Against demons, use the annihilation bullet!

She is the worst Arc Demon class. Don't let your guard down!」

The soldiers replaced their bullet as Faraga ordered while the enemy's movement was sealed by magic canceller.

But,

「Umm~, I don't really understand.

This thing used theory of disturbing the magic essence and obstructing its existence isn't it?

The effect become big towards a being whose body is composed of magic essence right?

But you know, towards people like me who has received a physical body, isn't this thing meaningless?

In addition, this thing may work against low rank demon, but it's meaningless against high rank being you know.

Because for us magic occurs naturally when we think about it, just like how it's natural for you guys to breathe.

Like so↓

Simultaneously when she said so, Ultima's figure disappeared and one of the soldiers lost his head.

She moved instantly and shown how she murdered a soldier.

「So? I merely moved and a person's head was sent flying.

In your way of speaking, I moved exceeding the speed of sound right.

But, why were there no shockwaves? Because this movement is magic.

And then」

She lightly shook her wrist and it seemed to be blurred for a moment after.

Immediately following was, bam! Together with the impact sound, a soldier's head exploded.

「This way, according to the physics law, I can even send out

the shock wave like so」

Faraga's mind was finally able to comprehend Ultima's words.

She explained with such mysterious feeling as if she speak foreign words of a country far away.

His instinct refused to understand.

Arc Demon? Is this what they're really like?

Thinking based on his ability, even if he couldn't win against an Arc Demon, he thought he could at least stall for time.

If there were several people with his abilities, then it's not an unbeatable enemy.

But.....

There was no chance of victory even if he struggled so hard against the girl in front of him.

「Hi,hii!! Monster!!」

The soldiers and magicians were falling into a complete panic state.

Because there stood an existence that embodied death itself, it could be said that the reaction was natural.

「Well then. Now, I shall resume the questioning~!」

That was the last words those people who fell into terror heard, the voice of a girl who said it cheerfully.

Several minutes later.

Ultima who had stole all their knowledge left the bridge

satisfied.

She was an intelligence officer, it was her duty to take the information back.

She thought that the results were satisfactory, but it was judged by her, but by her superior.

And then, when she was about to jump out from the ship,

「Oh, right right. We're permitted to use our full strength」

She muttered so as she remembered about it and invoked one magic.

Immediately after Ultima had jumped, the magic was activated and the ship was engulfed in a fireball.

It was a type of nuclear strike magic, Nuclear Flame (Flame of

Destruction) that completely leaving no trace behind.

The fireball swelled up greatly and it caused an explosion.

With a flame of super-high temperature as the first wave of damage and the shock waves of the explosion that followed was the second wave.

The ship exploded and scattered at all direction due to the flames, the ship's body became shrapnel that penetrate nearby ships.

the shrapnel flew at beyond supersonic speed, increasing the damage inflicted.

A large disaster occurred in the air but the damage calculated towards the member of Hiriyuu was zero.

Well, as some people couldn't achieved their assignment, there would be some people who suffered indirect damage later though.....

Such a thing was not something that had nothing to do with Ultima.

Due to this large explosion, the battle was set.

The Empire air force which wasn't able to push forward advantageously since the start of the battle was defeated with the shameful record of having all their ship sunk by the enemy.

Chapter 154: Great War Outbreak –The Smiling Demon–

‘Impossible, how can there be such an impossible thing!’

In a place a bit distant from the battlefield, Lieutenant general Gastar groaned these words as his face turned pale.

An impossible, disastrous scene is spreads in front of his eyes.

The prided tank corps was toyed by the demon wolf type devil that like a demon and there’s no doubt that there were already many tanks that got destroyed.

Their defeat was already decisive, but the progress speed of the war was too fast that they had lost the timing for retreating.

But, prompted by his words of reason that if the situation kept going as it is reorganization will be difficult, Lieutenant General Gastar finally decided to give an order for retreat.

However, that judgment was definitely too late.

「Ah? Certainly you wouldn't utter something like stopping, right?

I already told you so.

There will be no mercy if you went in.

I may look like this, but I'm the type that keeps my promises.

When I intruded to this world before, I would precisely fulfil the wish of the person whom summoned me.

You may feel relieved.

To you guys too, will precisely receive a retribution.」

A full smile was on her beautiful face.

However, it only sprang terror inside Gastar's heart.

「Yo, you bastard!」

「Ah? It seems you forgot about it.

What an impolite gentlemen」

With beauty to the extent of being unforgettable, and her scarlet hair that was let fluttering.

Testarossa had an expression like an affectionate mother who was looking at a child making a problem.

Repressing his fear, Gastar was going to give an attack order to his subordinate.

However,

「I don't really know what you're going to do, but your subordinates are sleeping.

They seems tired, and will not get up anymore」

So Testarossa whispered to his ear.

Her movement speed was too fast.

Even though he was not careless and he never took his eyes off of her.

Also, the most frightful matter was that he didn't even heard a sound at all.

Gastar's Unique Skill 『Musician』 , enables him to sense the enemy's movement from just the sound.

No matter how much of an expert someone is, they couldn't prevent making a faint sound. It's possible for him to even grasp the heartbeat sounds.

But, he didn't heard any sound at all.

And, he noticed another frightening thing at that time.

From his fallen down subordinates too, he heard no sound.

Because they were all dead.

「Yo, you..... were you the one that killed my subordinates!？」

To Gatar's shout,

「Ah? It's because I'm a bit hungry, so I only ate a bit, you know?」

Testarossa answered without being timid.

「You ate, you say? What do you eat?

「Yes, just a bit of the soul」

Gastar was enraged as she told him as lightly as this.

To vent that anger,

「Die, you damn demon! Mind Requiem (Spirit Death Funeral Tune)!!」

He scattered a killing sound to the surrounding space that has the special effect to influence the spirit and cause it to die.

It was Lieutenant general Gastar's trump card that could even kill a spiritual life form.

Despite this fact,

「Ah, a pleasant tune. It's too good to be made by a mere human.

It's unfortunate that I need to kill an amazing musician like you」

Testarossa muttered with a fascinated expression that was clouded with sadness.

There didn't seem to be any effect at all, Gastar who realized that fell into despair.

He was mislead by her beautiful appearance but the beautiful woman in front of his eyes was certainly not human.

She also was an existence of an incredible high rank.

Perhaps, she may be an even higher rank being than the currently rampaging demon wolf devil that was like a incarnation of violence.

This monster will not be the only one, so Gastar foresaw the failure of the current Empire army military operation.

Furthermore, disaster class monsters like Veldora were still not out.

「Please wait, let's make a deal!」

「Ah? What kind of deal is it?」

「I, I have a high ranking position in the empire.

I'm familiar with military operation and I also hold the confidential information.

I promise to be useful. Therefore, I only want you to spare my life!」

Gastar begs for his life by throwing away his shame and reputation.

However, there's still light in his eyes, he looked at Testarossa's appearance with carefulness.

It's because sounds of several people approaching were audible to Gastar's "Ear".

Gastar thought by intuition of the identity of the people approaching him.

Probably, it were people who sneaked in to give situation report and monitor the battlefield, the subordinates of the Empire Intelligence Bureau.

The Intelligence Bureau Staff or, so called Intelligence agent are holders of first-class combat abilities.

Although they has superior combat ability, they didn't participate in the rank deciding battle.

They belonged to the Empire Intelligence Bureau, and they wouldn't be transferred out from there.

Kondou Tatsuya, a cunning "Otherworlder".

They were the diverse people who were active under him.

If it's Kondou Tatsuya, it will be not strange that he can assume a situation like this and he might already have taken several countermeasures for it.

Therefore, Gastar intended to buy some time by doing anything even if it's begging for his life.

However, his hope was smashed.

Because all hope was used up in the moment they met Testarossa.

「Damn you demon, you revived!？」(Unknown agent 1)

Shouting so, people who belonged to the Intelligence Bureau drew near Testarossa by sneaking under the cover of the general soldier and attacked her.

Those people sealed off Testarossa's movement from three sides with the chain made from the weaved monster's fur.

It's the strongest special move formation that can suppressed high rank monster—even an Arc Demon.

The elites of the Intelligence Bureau which hunt monsters in teams of three.

‘I did it!’ Gastar raised a cheers inside his mind, at that time,

「Ah, oh my oh my. This is nostalgic. You guys are the one who defeated me before right?

I'm so happy.

I was not able to eat to my heart's content because I was disturbed at that time.

I haven't forgot the grudge from that time you know.

Even so.... Will you be alright?

To use the same technique once again like that time now?」

Testarossa's voice was heard with malice in it.

「Hmph, you monster! This evil presence, you're the Arc Demon of that time!」(Unknown Agent 1)

「You already revived huh. We will destroy your soul!」
(Unknown Agent 2)

「This is not the right place for you. As long as we are here, we will not let you do as you like!」(Unknown Agent 3)

「Now, Gastar-dono. Leave this to us. Quickly give the retreat order!」(Unknown Agent 1)

Gastar begins to move as he came to his sense after the three people talked to him.

In panic, he was going to notify the entire army with his Unique Skill 『Musician』 but,

「Hey. Do you think I will allow such a thing?」

He felt the sensation of a delicate woman's hand on his neck that made his soul freezing cold.

It's Testarossa, there's no need to see.

The chain strengthened with holy silver and with monster fur woven into it, which had high performance of legend class was ineffective as it was destroyed and broken.

The three shaken people turn their eyes to Testarossa who had moved to Gastar's back.

Irritation and confusion appeared in their expression.

They didn't see it at all how Testarossa destroyed the chain and when she moved.

And then, another hardship attacked them.

They heard a cute voice that was unbecoming to the battlefield from the sky.

「Testarossa, you still haven't killed them yet?

Even though Rimuru-sama commanded us to let out all of our power, you will get scolded you know?」(Unknown Girl)

A girl with bluish purple long hair styled as a ponytail fell from the sky while saying those words.

That girl seems to be the reinforcement for the demon in front of them, and the girl's way of talking suggests that the two were equal in rank and in addition has ability close to Testarossa's level.

In a situation where even only one enemy was already hard, this kind of reinforcement was fatal.

They were the elite of the Intelligence Bureau which was the expert in killing demons.

They took pride in being able to kill an Arc Demon class even if one of the three people was going one on one with it.

Despite this, the suppression barrier, they were proud of, was broken in front of their eyes, and now another monster with horrifying presence, which seemed to be equal with the female demon appeared.

It was necessary to conclude that the situation was disadvantageous.

「Gastar-dono, pull back from this place at once」(Unknown Agent 1)

One of them began chanting Transfer Magic after notifying Gastar.

The remaining two began to move in order to rescue Gastar.

Just after that,

「I hate people that don't know true strength.

Because I met familiar faces after a long time, unconsciously it became a long talk.

Ultima, I request a memory extraction on this person」

「Ooke~. What will Testa do?」(Ultima)

「I'm still not full. So, I will have a little meal.

Because it's familiar faces from a long time ago, you see」

Testarossa had a lovely smile.

But, that smile was like a ill omen itself.

The three people felt an ominous feeling from Testarossa's smile, they gave up on Gastar's rescue and decide to withdraw.

However——Transfer Magic was not invoked.

「Im, impossible! How come!?!」(Unknown Agent)

Testarossa sneered at the trembling spell caster.

「What is strange? This is the right way of using Magic Cancellor right?」

Testarossa answered the three people's question and calmly steps forward.

「What did you say? Magic Cancellor!?!」(Unknown Agent 1)

「No way, even reproduction by magic.....!?!」(Unknown Agent 2)

Via Thought Link, the demons were sharing information.

So, using the skill reproduced from the information they obtained was like a child's play for them.

However, such a thing was a talk of an unfathomable dimension for human's common sense, it's not something that could be understood by the three Intelligence Bureau agents.

The only thing they could understand was,

「You, what the hell are you!? There's no way an Arc Demon has power to that extent!!」(Unknown Agent 1)

One of them shouts painted over by fear.

Testarossa deepened her smile as she happily heard the shout.

「Yes, it's so. I'm a higher existence than a mere Arc Demon.

Or rather, I think that my status is different than an Arc

Demon's though.....

Do you want to see it yourself?

It's sad when you don't understand something without me telling you.」

The answer of their question was affirmative just like she said.

And,

「Well then, though it's regrettable, farewell」

So she announced.

The situation was already too late when the three people understood the meaning of the words.

They would reach death without understanding the true identity of the being they faced.

Or, it might be good luck.

From a profound darkness, black flame was summoned.

Testarossa condensed the black flame to size of a fist and crushed it as it is.

Testarossa (Demon) smiles,

「"Death Streak (Blessing of Death)"」

So, she whispered just like singing.

At the moment the black flame was crushed in her hand, black light diffuses to the surroundings.

That light has a property of penetrating almost all kind of substances. It's not a natural generated light.

It had the characteristic of not causing physical destruction.

When the light penetrates a living creature, it affects the genetic arrangement.

Almost all living creatures were killed forcibly because of the forced genetic rewriting.

It's the extremely evil, magic of death.

However, this light had another aim, or so says the legend that had been handed down from the past.

Only someone who has the ability to storage his soul or spiritual life forms can withstand this magic.

It's also possible for someone who can revive from a complete physical body destruction.

Even the smallest amount of the light was difficult to be defended with magic and there was no way to defend against it physically.

The only countermeasure against it was a Holy Light Barrier.

The probability of death when bathed by this light was 99,9999%.

One in a million people will get his body changed into a monster and he will get a long life.

In other words, this is actually a blessing magic that sort out suitable persons with aptitude for demonic attribute.

However, the success example of the monsterification of this magic was not existent.

Perhaps it was a story that had a moral of “The demon will lies about the hope”.

Therefore this magic was the worst forbidden spell.

It was the ultimate forbidden magic with purpose only for killing living creatures which was kind of a nuclear strike magic but without any physical damage at all.

Within the radius of 500m almost everything was devastated by a great storm of ferocious death.

Testarossa has completed grasped that there was no ally within the range with 『Magic Power Perception』.

For a demon like herself, they wouldn't be exempted from this magic.

Because the magic was created with the purpose of killing——Demon and Human——all living creatures alike.

The regrettable part was that it did kill any living being within the range regardless of friend or foe.

It may be expanded to a radius of 10 km if used without any restraint, but it would involve allies too.

So, it was necessary to specify the range to 500m.

「It looks like you have annihilated everything in this area.

For the information of the toy called tank, we could take home the undamaged actual thing you see!」(Ul)

「Yes, for that reason, I only swept clean the human beings.

If you annihilated them from the beginning with this magic, any surviving enemy would be finished though」(Testa)

「It can't be helped you know! Rimuru-sama said we should

fight.

Even so, it was good that there was a turn for me too.

However, should I not break the toy which floats in the sky too?」(Ul)

「That's right, Ul's magic was too flashy.

The collecting of samples may be difficult because of that you see」(Testa)

「I know..... I thought that I failed too.

That thing is too fragile.

I only intended to destroy only one, but a lot were broken」(Ul)

「It can't be helped. You obtained the information right?

Then, let's think that there's no problem」(Testa)

So they discussed, Testarossa and Ultima ended the conversation.

Meanwhile, the work of collecting the souls was done thoroughly.

At the same they were killed by "Death Streak", their souls were accurately reaped.

In fact, the possibility of them changing into monsters was only present when the soul was left behind.

When the reaping of the soul was done at the same time like now, the survival rate completely becomes zero.

Of course, Lieutenant general Gastar and the three people from the Intelligence Bureau too failed to resist it and were already dead.

Testarossa didn't have any deep emotions even when she sees the final moments of the people who defeated her in the past.

As they were never within Testarossa's thoughts from the start, it can be said as natural.

Thus, the victory of the Monster's Country Tempest was set into stone like this as the strategic headquarters of the Empire forces completely became silent.

However, that didn't mean the end of war, the possibility of of the Empire army surrendering disappeared completely when the strategic headquarters also disappeared.

The battlefield shifted into a war of annihilation.

Chapter 155: First victory and the enemy main forces

Give it all you got!

I remember saying this before.

No worries, I'm not at that age where you begin forgetting things.

It hasn't even been three years yet since I reincarnated.

Such worries are unneeded.

But,

Are these words I spoke really something I spoke?

Yet the event I pondered about has been projected onto the big

screen before me, it was but a small thought at the back of my head.

The large screen before me projected the victory of the tempest army.

That's good.

There's no problem with that, but the contents are too gruesome.

The extent of their error resulted in this battle developing into a one-sided stampede.

Gobuta, displayed an un-Gobuta like coolness, as he darted throughout the battlefield, destroying tanks left and right.

Gabil being Gabil, transformed into a Dragonoid Magin looking figure with a befitting strength, struck down an enemy vessel with a single, unnaturally powerful strike.

It's not just Gabil, everyone in the Hiryu squad transforming was no laughing matter.

The Material "Dragon warriorization" was noted, but to think they could master it without going berserk.

And the decisive move, was the explosion in midair.

I'm not sure which lunatic went insane, created a hot nuclear explosion midair, and wrap the empire's flying squad in a blazing inferno.

At that point the empire's air force fell into an irreversible state.

With that as the kickoff, Tempest's grand offense began.

In modern warfare, helicopters hold overwhelming advantages against tanks

Similarly, the Blue Corps and the Hiryu Squad rained their breath attack from above, dealing massive damage to the empire's ground troops.

However, there is a reason things are proceeding so smoothly.

This is thanks to the active role of our military intelligence officers.

With the ability to visually discern the strong, regardless of soldiers or generals, all she sees gets turned into a blood fest.

Actually, through the analysis of Wisdom King Raphael, there were foes boasting strength above a general mixed amongst the opponents of Veyron, Cien, Moss, and Zonda.

I'm afraid, an "Otherworlder", or someone strong amongst the empire was lurking in their midst.

Quickly seeing through this, they were dealt with before the operation began.

How terrifying, the strong-discerning eye.

In the mean time, something went wrong at the rear of the empire's army.

Displayed onto the large screen, are the smiling faces of Testarossa and Ultima.

There was no way to confirm any other survivors.

There were hundreds of tanks halted in their tracks, the reserve logistics support soldiers all fell to the ground.

Their numbers, in the ten thousands.

I can't tell exactly what happened, but I understand something very dangerous happened

Wisdom King Raphael,

《Answer. Usage of the Large-scale annihilation magic “death’s blessing” confirmed》

Answered such.

A type of nuclear strike magic, magic that utilizes demonic death rays to annihilate life, he explained,

Don’t use such dangerous magic! Even if I did cried out loud there’s no stopping this.

Anyways, victory was decided at that moment

At first I wanted to declare the end of the battle right there... but!

At that point, there was no need for this.

The remaining ten thousands of soldiers remaining of the

battle, all vanished the next moment.

Quartet spell: Monster's Arc Sanctuary was activated.

With Moss as the spearhead, 4 arc demons spread towards the 4 corners of the battlefield.

This allowed them to activate the quartet spell.

Due to the initial preparation of weeding the strong ones, there were no interferences preparing this spell.

Comparing that to the nearby Testarossa who could activate a large scale annihilation magic they're on completely different levels.

However, they are by no means weak, it's just a bad choice of target to compare with.

The Monster's Arc Sanctuary, as the name suggests, has no effects on monsters.

On the contrary, Humans who are not used to Magic Essence, would experience death-inducing effects.

Once the barrier was in place, even the mages with their magic barrier collapse, the enhanced humans simply strengthened for combat needless to say, couldn't resist the effects.

Then something terrifying happened, the flesh of those who couldn't resist began to decompose, and turned into magic essence.

In a few minutes, even the remaining survivors, turned into magic essence.

Just like that, the first battle with the Empire's army ended.

Or rather, the first encounter with the empire resulted in the

complete destruction of their army.

They were, in every meaning of the word, completely wiped out. There's no military term to describe this.

This was completely irrational.

All I told them was to give it their all, and this was the result.

And then towards me,

“What to say, ah. Isn't my battle plan completely pointless now!

What's with that, those girls! And that military intelligence officer!

But I must say even if they're the direct subordinate of Rimuru-sama, shouldn't they explain themselves?”

Benimaru turns towards me with a smile.

Well, that's right.....right?

But there wasn't any battle plans though?

But you know, Benimaru.

You're not the only one who wants an explanation.

Or rather, I want someone to explain to me what's this all about!

I couldn't even think of any excess excuses to make.....

“Those are the new comrades Diablo picked up.

I thought it would have been bad news if the enemy also had

demon lord class individuals, so I also assigned them.

It looks like they gave a little too much of their best.

Well, Diablo's going to be lecturing them from now on."

I'll push this onto Diablo, and dealt with it safely.

I mean, I didn't think the demons would cause such a huge turmoil.

Those guys, are too "cool".

They annihilated the enemy army, with no hesitation.

However,

"Kufufufu. They have overdone a little, they were a little too

excited.

I'll make sure to re-educate them (completely)”

Restraint yourself! I didn't forget to tell the smiling Diablo that.

After finishing the explanations, I've begun to confirm the causalities of the first battle.

In less than 2 hours since the battle began, it has ended just as quickly.

Although it seems there were a large number of injured, they have all since recovered.

Since everyone was given 10 Tempest-made mid potions to hold onto, most damages were immediately healed.

In addition, those whom I thought were originally dead, thanks to the troop leaders applying their Full potions, had made a complete recovery and held onto their lives.

Under Benimaru's command, the bait played their role perfectly.

That's why Benimaru was unshaken.

The results, even though recovery potions were used en masse, the total death count was 0.

This was an unthinkable big victory.

However, it's not like we escaped damages scot-free.

There's Gabil, and his subordinates the Hiryu squad.

Due to the unique skill 『Dragon-warriorization』 they have

received major physical recoil onto their body.

This skill forcefully creates a body that would rival a dragonoid. However, they could only maintain it for 30 minutes, and it cannot be used more than once every 2 days.

Due to this reason, there would be side effects after use, causing their body to be in a harsh state of being unable to move for 48 hours.

Well, it's great we attained victory after they gave it their all, but if they misjudged the situation this would have been a self-destructing skill.

Well, due to Gabil getting carried away, not only he, but also everyone else in the Hiryu squad had suffered the side-effect penalty.

It was fortunate it was only to this extent, it's what they can only think now.

Then, the damages from the empire's side.....

There were no prisoners, for they have all died.

The number, 240,000.

I have obtained their souls, and thus I know the exact numbers.

This feeling, it's like my subordinates are collecting souls for me.

There was a short period right when the battle started, it felt like I was collecting souls at a torrential rate.

If collecting 10,000 souls would allow a demon lord to evolve into an awaken demon lord, what would happen if you collect 240,000 souls?

The answer, Nothing! That's it.

When I awakened as a true demon lord, one could say I have reached the peak of my evolution.

Well of course.

IF it was otherwise Guy would have long driven humans to extinction, reaping all their souls.

I think he probably intuitively realized he couldn't evolve anymore, thus he restraint himself from slaughtering.

However, this could be used for things other than one's own evolution.

《Notice. The predetermined amount of souls has been obtained.

Currently, it can be used on two members connected via soul link.

Possible targets, are monsters named below.

Ranga, Benimaru, Shion, Gabil, Gerudo,

Diablo, Testarossa, Ultima, Carrera

Kumara, Zegion, Adalman.

Those with the qualifications to awaken as the demon lord, are those above.

Set amount [souls:100,000] will be consumed. Would you like to evolve your subordinates? YES/NO »

Wisdom King Raphael just said some pretty absurd things.

One way or another, it seems I have obtained enough souls to grant someone the qualifications to awaken as the demon lord.

However, their cost is 10 times above me.

This is something no one knows about until now.

If someone knew, this would have been an economical way to simply allow one's comrade to become a demon lord.

Perhaps guy might know.

That's why, he probably hosts the Walpurgis as a superior and gather everyone, choosing the worthy among them as comrades.

There might also be other reasons beside that.

Perhaps I've overestimated him, or maybe there are some

other unknown reasons.

Even though I simply say 100,000 souls, it's a number that can only be attained from massacring a major city.

That's not something you do on a whim.

I noticed afterwards, but "connected via soul link" was mentioned.

Most likely, this meant being soul linked via being "named".

Evolving after being named. I've recklessly used this, but I've realized recently that doing so also comes with risks.

Consuming a large amount of magic essence as the cost, then link via the weakened body.

Then, the remaining magic essence is stored up, only

expending when needed.

This could only be done, since there's a convenient skill, my Gluttony king Beelzebub's pouch.

If they didn't have my skill, they wouldn't be able to easily access the stored magic essence, those who had "Named" would have understood this easily.

That's why it's better if there were fewer soul-linked subordinates.

I can't deny this is a privilege granted only to me.

This incident, lets just end it with a NO.

I felt that this was quite the close shave, and then there's the bother of choosing who.

And the selections of the qualified are also questionable.

If we're only going by the amount of Magic essence, then Souei should also be qualified.

Because I'm not sure about the details, lets leave it aside for now.

However, more than 200,000 people have died.

It's a massacre.

Even so, my heart feels no pain.

I've already become a demon lord, and killed 10,000 people with my own hands, there's no excuse for that.

The slain also have families, but if I think like this it's just going to go on and on.

Then, are the ones who sent their families to their doom sinless? If I think like this the responsibilities are endless.

If there is war, then there will be death.

If the people opt for war, then one should be responsible for not opposing to it.

Be it a constitutional state or an imperial government, this will not change.

Ignorance is sin.

Saying I don't know is not a valid excuse. Those with a lack of imagination have also sinned.

Their relatives entered battle without the conviction to die, it's pointless to complain afterwards.

To aim cannon fires at civilians is wrong as a nation and as a person, but even if we decimated the invading forces they have no right to complain.

That's because we too, entered the battlefield with the conviction of being wiped out.

Even though there's zero persuasion coming from me who falters when his subordinates were wounded.

Emotions and reasons are different, lets wrap up with that.

Besides, the war isn't over yet.

It seems the empire's main forces, consists of 700,000 ground troops, entering from the west borders of the Dwarven Kingdom and the Great Jura Forest, invading towards Tempest.

This isn't the time to be sentimental.

It's been a week since the battle has started, and the empire's main forces has finally entered our territory.

The tanks were retrieved thanks to Gobuta, and the wreckages of the airship were also ordered to be retrieved.

Gabil who has returned was ordered to work alongside Gobuta.

There's no need to be in a hurry to return, Benimaru had already issued thus.

Sure, this was a great victory.

However I musn't be careless, we too have a second force, and Diablo seems rather active.

As the military intelligence officer, Carrera is now following Gerudo.

And, within the control rooms Testarossa and co have also returned.

However, if the empire's army also have strong individuals, then they must be allowed to attack.

The other executives also seem pretty pumped up.

Shion too wants to head out to battle,

“Those Demons, they're too flashy!

If I was there, I would have show them what true strength is all about!”

She said, regretting the fact she didn't leave for the

battlefields,

“Weren’t you suppose to be my guard?”

After I asked her, she frantically regained her composure.

And now she’s completely obedient, when something happens it would be fine to order her to attack.

Since we’re at the deepest part of the dungeon, it’s going to take the enemy some time to reach here.

Thinking about our remaining forces, it’s small compared to the enemy’s 700,000

However, the quality of our soldiers are completely different, putting aside the executives, even the soldiers at the far end are getting motivated.

It would seem my orders are effective, for it has raised their Morales.

What to do next, is the problem.

We could ignore them or give them a flashy warning, but the battle has already been declared.

Even if we launched a surprised attack, you can't exactly call it cowardly.

However, a small number of surprise attacks will have a limited effect, should we use nuclear strike magic?

No, should I give them a proper warning?

But everyone's so eager to present more souls to me, I would just be dampening their eagerness.

What would do I do with the souls collected anyways, I don't even know why I'm thinking about this.

Demons, seem to have a liking for the residue emotions engraved onto the soul.

No way in hell would I want that stuff.

Still, 700,000 people.

Enough to awaken 7 of my subordinates, it's kind of scary when you think about it.

To begin with, we should plan how to attain victory without any sacrifices on our side.

Our best bet, is to lure them into the dungeon.

If it's within the dungeon, the casualties of our army can be

reduced to 0.

Or rather, since we can also treat the monsters within the dungeon as part of the attack force, the strength of our forces would drastically increase.

If that's so, even if we disregard quality our numbers could be on par with 700,000.

Benimaru's battle plan, is to position the second corps in front of Tempest, thoroughly solidifying our defenses.

After that, we've sorted out the enemy's intelligence, and confirmed some strong individuals in the mix.

In reality, even though modern warfare is determined by numbers, in this world it's the strong who turn the tides of battle. This has already been proven in the first battle.

This is the theory behind prioritizing weeding out the threatening ones first.

umu.

Certainly, magic barriers probably can't defend against an average nuclear strike magic.

However, it definitely cannot defend against "Death's blessing"

Should I form a demons special attack force composed of only military intelligence officers to annihilate the enemy?

I thought about it for an instant. No, if we did that, it would also wreck massive havoc onto the forest.

Above all, if this were during a defensive situation, we would lose our greatest attack forces.

The enemy large army's defense is basically rather well prepared, there will be those who could deploy a holy barrier.

When Moss and co first went to pluck out the strong individuals, there were some that could erect a said barrier.

There would be no point in using a large scale annihilation if the enemy have the means to defend against it.

In terms of battle tactics I'm just an amateur, Benimaru's more skilled in this matter. I'll leave it all to him, while I simply play the role of the figurehead.

In end, the warnings were left unneeded.

The forces moving south from the direction of the old Pharmas kingdom, naturally is also aiming for Tempest.

Just in case, if they started attacking the old Pharmas kingdom, we would initiate an attack from their rear, but this is just a baseless fear.

Currently, A new kingdom is being raise in Pharmas, by Youmu.

Secretively giving us support from behind the scenes, they no longer have any strength to go to battle. Amidst that, they've given us surveillance support.

I really didn't want them to get in harm's way, so I was relieved by this.

On a side note, the Dwarf King offered us his support, but we replied and said we can handle it.

Leaving this, we asked for permission to go through their territory.

After gathering up everyone's opinions, we're the only ones who are needed for the final decision.

The Dwarf King has also helped us with surveillance, and information subsequently started flowing in.

However, we didn't really need it, but we accepted it out of goodwill.

Using Surveillance magic allows us to monitor scenes one by one, it's really convenient for times like this.

Tentatively, we let Souei's subordinates do the monitoring, not needing to worry about any illusions displayed on the monitors.

With this feeling, we proceeded to prepare for the second battle.

Since the holy knights invaded using the same route, we prepared an entrance to the dungeon along the way.

In case, if the empire ignores the dungeon and heads straight for tempest, the volunteers in the dungeon can come out and attack from the back.

Although the pincer attack can compensate for the lack in numbers, we're going to have to be prepared to make major sacrifices.

We'll respond based on the action they take.

Preferably, we hope at least half of them will enter the dungeon.

I don't know whether my wish would come through, but I hope it would progress as I hoped it would.

The Troops passing by the dungeon and headed towards Tempest number 200,000.

The enemy encamped in the dungeon's vicinity number 500,000.

Probably whilst confirming the status of Tempest's invasion, and also plotting how to capture the dungeon.

It seems they were surprised about the sudden disappearance of the cities around the dungeon, and without hesitation changed to dungeon capturing.

What greedy people.

Having them focus completely on either one would be bad news for us.

To be precise, it would be fine if they bit the dungeon bait, but if the whole army heads for the capital then a harsh battle is unavoidable.

Despite calling it a skirmish, it's actually a decoy for the main army, but once this intelligence was leaked, then it loses its purpose.

Unless it's absolutely necessary, dividing one's forces is a fundamentally foolish move.

Although it's the thoughts of an amateur, but I was thinking about taking them down one by one.

“victory”

In reply to my murmurs,

“Ah.....our victory”

Benimaru replied happily.

In sooth, tactics wise it's our victory.

Afterwards, as long as they don't defeat us with brute strength, it's our victory.

“It's great the idiots entered the labyrinth”

“That's true. However, this is thanks to Rimuru sama scattering the bait beforehand.

Above all it's great they've bit it.”

“That’s true.

Although I’m not sure what’s Yuuki’s objective, however the sown bait causing them to split apart is the best possible outcome

Besides, we’re simply aiming for the empire to stir within.

Well, all we have to do is simulate their desires, they couldn’t possibly ignore the dungeon.

Worse case scenario, the capital would be burn to cinders, and our decisive battle would take place in the dungeon.”

“If it’s nothing serious, the capital would probably be safe and sound.

Depending on the situation, I would head out myself.”

When Beimaru said so,

“There’s no need for that.

Rimuru sama, before Benimaru heads out, can you allow me to go first?”

Shion appealed.

Well, being my personal guard is an important role, but the control room’s the safest place.

They can simply teleport back immediately, and there’s also Testa and Ul who’s reflecting by my side due to excessive violence.

Besides, Veldora’s also watching the battle right next to me, so it’s not dangerous as to the point we would need guards.

It wouldn't be a problem.

“It would be hard if it's only Gerudo's forces, your corps also need some experience.

I'll permit you to go. But, don't go overboard!”

“Wa wa, Thank you very much!”

Shion smiled from ear to ear, gave Benimaru a “How's that!” smug look, and left the control room.

Diablo also bowed to me, and left with a likewise ear-to-ear smile.

It's going to be difficult to stop Diablo.

After all, he's the most motivated one of them all.

Benimaru shrugged his shoulders, and gave up the notion of entering the fray.

And so, he stayed with me and was mixed into the spectating group.

It's a joke for the supreme commander to be in the front lines, however if you ask me if this is natural I would say of course it is.

And so, the decisive battle against the empire's 700,000 troops has begun.

Chapter 156: Meeting in the Labyrinth

Armoured Corps chief Calgurio advanced his troops with the utmost confidence.

After consulting with his advisors, a magic tank squad was to advance as vanguard and bait.

Even if Storm Dragon Veldora appeared, the Aerial Fighter Legion's 100 airship fleet would counter it flawlessly.

That force was thought to be more than enough to conquer all of the west side.

After all, the 100 airships assured complete dominance by each carrying elite mages to the maximum capacity.

In addition, even though the 300 airships carrying the Beast Corps did not have many offensive mages, they specialized in logistic support so it was not a problem.

With both teams simultaneously attacking, Calgurio's Armored Corps would achieve great success and honor.

Thus, Calgurio laughed heartily at the prospect of his power further increasing in the Empire.

As the enemy fell for the bait, the main force was to boldly make its appearance and commence the attack.

Even though they were at the border of the military nation of Dwargon, their movements would not be detected.

It was also not guaranteed that this nation would contact its allied nation, the Monster Country Tempest.

In any case, it was already too late.

Even if they were to send troops now, they were too far, and timewise, would not be able to make it.

Even if they were too busy with their experiments and regretted it, it would be too late.

Plus, even if they were guarding all routes, they would be spread far too thin to actually be a hindrance.

Everything was going according to plan, victory was in Calgurio's hands.

At that point, on the off chance that the military nation Dwargon tried to help the Monster's Country Tempest, their neutrality is nulled.

If that happened, he would then overwhelm and destroy both nations.

-

Then, a well awaited report came.

The vanguard squad sent as bait reported that, the monsters of Tempest had come out.

They number not much more than ten thousand.

The report verified that it was one the enemy's main forces.

I won!

Gloated Calgurio.

The enemy easily fell for the trap.

They seem to be much less intelligent than he thought, and, failing to guess his invasion route, split up their forces.

Reconnaissance had determined that Monster Country Tempest, had prepared 120,000 – 150,000 troops.

Among them, those that could be considered military units should not even be 50,000.

Therefore, as the enemy here number around 10,000, their plan was likely to have all the routes covered and stall for time.

With such a pathetic force, forget stalling for time, even the vanguard can finish them off.

As expected of savages, monsters that do not comprehend the importance of information gathering, this was their utmost level of planning.

If Veldora doesn't appear, they are fated for defeat.

Before the frontal forces arrive to trample all over them, Calgurio would quickly fell the enemy base.

Calgurio ordered to halt covert operations and advanced his army towards the capital of Monster Country Tempest.

Although there is the matter of the dwarves possibly taking military action, that was determined to no longer be a problem.

In fact, Calgurio was immersed in imagining the faces of the of the panicked enemy as they finally noticed his army.

In the end, with no sign of reinforcement from Dwargon, they would head for the Labyrinth in the Monster Country Tempest's satellite city.

They beasts most likely gave up upon seeing the Empire's might, thought Calgurio.

That was obvious, after all, the Empire boasts a great army of 700,000.

In addition, despite being fully armed, they marched are an unprecedented speed.

This modern army was at a strength beyond the imagination of the dwarves with their backdated technology and arms.

Magic and science.

With their fusion, based on a new cutting edge combat system, the strongest corps was born.

That was the Armoured Corps led by Calgurio.

-

In Monster Country Tempest, at the location of the Labyrinth city was nothing save for a single structure.

That, in fact, was the entrance to the Labyrinth, and other than a staircase to its depths, there was nothing more in the vicinity.

This scene was different from what was initially reported, and apparently, the merchants and adventurers on the west side all ran away with the Empire approaching.

If that was the case, rather than let the enemy use them, it was likely that the beasts erased everything.

They probably feared the possibility of looting.

This in reality was a clearly a strategy to hurt the enemy by preventing the enemy from procuring food.

(Clever!)

Calgurio spits out.

For soldiers who received enhancement surgery from 'Otherworld' science and magic, it is possible to perform optimally without food or water for a week.

Food packs made with energy balance in mind were created to provide each unit with energy for a single day.

Each unit, carrying a small storage pack, was provided 10 such food packs.

Considering such measures taken prior to arriving, there was no loss in performance in the Armoured Corps even if they could not manage to collect food from this town.

Food intake was optimized by making sufficiently small and easy to use food packs.

The problem of potable water was easily solved by drawing water through magic.

To hope that the supply chain was a weakness of this great army was simply too naïve.

(Ha! Demon lord or not, in the end, to think they're only capable of such shallow thought!)

Ridiculing the plans of his foe, Calgurio was certain of victory on this battle.

First he would put a foothold in the satellite city of Monster Country Tempest.

Building a base there, he would subjugate the west side with a smooth flow.

If he didn't hurry, the Beast Corps advancing from the north would diminish the scale of his achievement.

If Veldora were to come out, there would be the need to stop it, but the Storm Dragon had made no sign of showing up.

Speaking of which.....

While Calgurio was resting in a tent of the provisional headquarters, he was surprised to not receive any reports from the vanguard.

After the first time, there was no more communication.

According to the communications mage, the magic concentration in the Great Forest of Jura was apparently interfering with the magic communication waves.

As this is a demon lord's domain, that much was to be expected.

The remaining enemy troops may have even come back and fighting had already broke out.

(Even so, judging from the first troops we encountered, reinforcements should also be fodder.)

There was no need to worry about the vanguard, so Calgurio would stopped thinking about it.

Just in case, he ordered an Reconnaissance to look into the matter and dropped the thought.

-

The issue now: Whether to advance to the capital or the labyrinth.

Normally, felling the capital would be given priority.

It was close by, so first was defeat the demon lord and then, beat the labyrinth.

Even if Veldora showed up, it's a simple matter of calling the Airship fleet.

Though communication was impossible for now, they could easily signal them using magic bullets.

Unlike on land, airspeed was so high that the waiting time would be negligible, so there was no need to fear the purportedly weakened Storm Dragon.

The mage reported that, the Monster Country Tempest's capital had a defence barrier set up around it.

Even using the Magic Cancellor Device to break the barrier, it would soon regenerate, so there was no point.

It seemed to be pretty strong. Rather than breaking in, it would seem to be easier to destroy it from the inside.

Even though the Magic Cancellor Device was excellent against offensive magic, its rather weak at beating barriers.

That being the case, now would be the time that the remodelled Armoured Corps takes center stage.

Reconnaissance reported that the monster troops were stationed right in front of the capital.

They were the main force of 20,000 high orcs.

No problem at all.

Calgurio and his advisors all never doubted their certain victory.

After all, they had a great army of 700,000.

Victory usually being assured with 3 times the force, with more that 30 times more troops, they had no doubt at all.

“Can’t we just attack both places at the same time?”

The advisors who were nobles of the Empire expressed the opinion.

There were no objections.

There was no need to pointlessly disagree and create anxiety, as there was no rush.

Rather, Calgurio was equally interested in the treasures that

lay within the labyrinth.

In the end, sending off 200,000 troops to capture the capital, he, with 350,000 were to head into the Labyrinth.

Anyway, it was a simple strategy of overwhelming the labyrinth with immense numbers.

There being no objections, there's really no doubt that what they were most interested in was the short-term profit, rather than capturing the capital but.....

Being assured of victory, Calgurio and co. put their plan to action without realizing their greed.

Thus, in Monster Country Tempest, 200,000 troops would advance towards the capital, and 350,000 would focus on capturing the Labyrinth.

And then.....

These foolish souls would descent the stairs they could never again climb back up.

With the absolute conviction of filling their pockets to the brim with the treasures of the Labyrinth, they advanced.

The Labyrinth grants passage to all.

But, with Safe Mode now turned off, there would be a never before seen hell befallen on its visitors.

One of the innermost rooms of the Labyrinth.

A place where a secret meeting room could be found, that even Rimuru didn't know of.

For the first time, because of the Master of the Labyrinth,

Ramiris' emergency remodelling, the most powerful denizens of the Labyrinth were gathered.

The reason: a meeting concerning the annihilation of the fools who dared to invade the labyrinth.

But in reality, the purpose of the meeting was of a very different nature.

-

The gathered, they were those who were called the 10 Lords of the Labyrinth.

Ramiris' aide, Labyrinth janitor, dungeon master Beretta.

4 groups of the Lords.

Floor 90 guardian, Nine-head-kumara.

Floor 80 guardian, Insect Emperor Kaiser Zegion.

Floor 79 floor boss, Insect Queen Apito.

Floor 70 guardian, Ghost King, Immortal King Adalman.

Floor 70 vanguard, Ghost Knight, Death Paladin Albert.

And finally,

Floor 50 alternating guardians, Gozurl and Mezurl.

Both of them were also participating for some reason.

Realizing the strength of their fellow Lords, it felt as if they were shrinking.

They, who had thought they could win against anyone, now

faced a reality as they recognized the clear difference in level.

As for Beretta, though he was only assigned to chores said – Later, Rune Master Gadra would become one of the 10 Lords – but.....

Anyway, those sitting down currently were the 10 Lords of the Labyrinth.

Knowing that irresponsible Ramiris, that name would not stick.

Normally, all of them wouldn't gather here, but since it was an emergency-like situation, Ramiris invoked her authority, and as a result, for the first time, the whole team had gathered.

Well, Veldora was sitting leisurely on the middle seat but, the other Lords were gathered for a sole reason.

That who amongst them, other than Beretta and the Storm Dragon, was the strongest.

This rivalry burned stronger when Demon Lord Rimuru personally praised Alderman and granted him a higher rank.

Every one of them wanted to prove to be the most useful.

With the lower floors not receiving much action, those Lords were most affected.

So there was a backlash.

Particularly the 2 females, Apito and Kumara, had an dangerous relationship.

Zegion was calm, and Alderman was burning with ambition.

However, they did not truly hate each other despite their poisonous auras.

In the end, even though they were all aiming to prove

themselves, they wouldn't go around sabotaging each other's efforts.

These people gathered for the first time, but it was surprisingly quiet.

Facing the Empire's invasion of the Labyrinth, their hostility towards the enemy took precedence over their rivalry.

"Lords, you've done well to gather!

Today, this Labyrinth faces its greatest crisis since it's grand opening!

With that, let me hear your thoughts!"

The words my Ramiris signaled the start of the meeting.

"Ara? Isn't that obvious-"

“- a Massacre of course.”

Cutting off Kumara, Apito continues.

“This time, can you not send the action to my floor?

These days, Apito has been happy fooling around with the Holy Knight right?”

“Say what! That weakling, any more and I’ll die of boredom!”

As they glare at each other, a different kind of tension fills the room.

“Kuhahahahaha! Lets stop the bickering. And be at ease.

This time, everyone shall get a chance to fight!

First, I figured anyone who can pass the 60th floor

would be a worthy enemy but.....

It was annoying so I stopped.”

“Yea that’s right! Just like Shishou said, waiting for them to cross all the 50 floors is seriously a pain -ne?

Normally it’d be ok, but with their numbers, it looks like it’s gonna take a while.

So tell you what, well send in 10,000 of ‘em to each floor from the beginning.

If you’re lucky, someone strong might come along in y’know?”

With those words from Veldora and Ramiris, the others’

shown a glint in their eyes.

“So you mean..... everyone gets the chance?”

Asks Alderman, to which,

“Exactly!”

Ramiris made an exaggerated nod, and continued with the explanation.

Each of the Lords would receive 10,000 troops at a time.

Floors 61 – 70, 71 – 80 and 81-90 would get filled 100,000 each.

And the remaining would be sent to floors 51 – 60.

There were around 350,000 troops heading into the

Labyrinth, so they would be distributed in this fashion.

“And then, Gozurl and Mezurl are on standby on floor 30 to eat up the ones that can run back up that far ‘kay?

And even if you up and die, you can always revive so, work hard -ne!”

Ramiris concluded.

With that, the Lords got super motivated.

“So, does Rimuru-sama know about this?”

Zegion broke his silence and spoke.

And Apito was surprised.

Insect Emperor Kaiser Zegion was a silent man, he never really had much to talk about.

he seemed to be receiving combat training from Veldora for a while, and recently it looked like they were close to being evenly matched.

Veldora was admittedly very strong, and other than his loyalty to Demon Lord Rimuru, He was a man who only cared for strength.

“Ehehe, we’re keeping it a secret! So, lets surprise everyone - ne!”

Ramiris said with an innocent smile.

But in reality, together with Veldora the two were hatching a devious plot – mainly to surprise Rimuru --

It was always like that, and the one’s who were involved suffered.

“Oi oi, Rimuru-sama won’t get angry later right?”

Albert asked, worried.

“No problemo!”

Veldora and Ramiris assured him.

Seeing Beretta was averting his gaze, Albert gave up.

Well, it probably wasn’t too big a deal, he thought.

I just need to beat the enemy.

In theory, a battered enemy is easier to beat, but we can revive.

There was no need for wait for them to tire out battling

monsters on weaker floors.

“Very well, I concur that we simply need to win.”

Zegion said with a nod, and the matter was settled.

Ramiris and Veldora looked at each other with an evil smile, and the others pretended not to notice.

After all, it was the first real battle with the full force.

Whatever the case, in truth, none of them were going to let go of this chance.

To unleash the true horror of the Labyrinth unto its invaders, the ten Lords returned to their respective floors.

And so, these denizens of hell wait patiently for their soon to arrive guests.

Chapter 157: Battle of the Dungeon

Gradually, the soldiers and the generals of the empire's army began entering the dungeon.

Each one had a rope in hand, connecting them at 3 meter intervals. There was a combat team stationed elsewhere, and they must be able to detach the rope swiftly.

Since they have already made various preparations beforehand for conquering the dungeon, their actions were quick and swift.

Through interrogating Shinji and co, Calgurio had a fair grasp of the dungeon's structure, and prepared measures to combat getting lost in the dungeon.

While spirit mages confirmed the course ahead, a special team would disable any traps.

The combat team would work on subjugating monsters, and the analysis team would collect dismantled monsters and

“monster cores”

Money and Goods collected from the treasure boxes of various rooms would transferred to the back, and be prepared to be transported to the Command headquarters.

With the soldiers connected, they could act accordingly to the situation.

Calgurio’s plan initially went well.

However, things started happening within.

Contacts with soldiers who entered first were cut off, causing minor disturbances.

There were also reports of rather than a labyrinth, it was a wide space internally

.

Previously connected to staircases, an order to continue the search was issued under the assumption that it was a distorted structure.

The spirit mages reported that due to the spirits being in disarray the path would sometimes be uncertain.

Thanks to Shinji's report, he knew that the dungeon would change its internal structure on a weekly basis.

This had caused Calgurio's decisions to go awry

(How unlucky. We've just clashed with the maze's remodeling period.....)

Thinking about this, he gave his subordinates their orders.

Even so, to panic so much over a changing maze, Calgurio was very dissatisfied with the empire army's disgraceful display.

Among the items continuously delivered from the dungeon, each and everyone of them were first rate equipment made with demon steel.

The "Monster cores" collected were also of high quality, with high energy-conversion rate.

Before all the reaped profits, the confusion was a minor problem no matter the scale.

After a whole day, the majority of the 350,000 troops had successfully entered the dungeon.

The ground troops were on standby at the dungeon's entrance, communicating with the internal group via ropes and making preparations.

In addition, they're work on pitching up a tent in order to

place the transported riches and goods.

That's when the actual abnormality began.

Losing contact with the soldiers within, the rope was suddenly cut.

This happened exactly when all 350,000 soldiers entered the dungeon.

They tried getting in contact, via telepathy and clairvoyance communication, but there was no reply.

Things were going well up until then, the transportation of goods from within was also interrupted then.

The means of confirming the internal conditions of the dungeon were all lost.

The entrance of the dungeon remained opened as it first was.

And yet, near the entrance within, the presence of soldiers were all gone.

With an indescribable foreboding silence, the empire's troops felt an ominous premonition

Calgurio was no exception, as it hindered his decision-making.

However the situation is changing too rapidly, he had no time to spare worrying about those who went conquering the dungeon.....

Calgurio was left with little time.

——Dungeon Stratum 61~70——

Charging through a hoard of undead type monsters, the

soldiers of the Empire army•cybernetic troops invaded deeper into the dungeon.

Having a delayed head start, the combat group vigilantly guarded each other as they took cautious action.

To begin with, the soldiers were all individually fairly strong.

In adventurer terms, they were all at the very least above B rank.

Their bear first class prowess.

If it's them, they would need not panic as they dealt with monsters or so it should have been.

After the first day in the dungeon, things took a drastic sharp turn.

Losing all contact with the surface troops, they were completely isolated.

No, this isn't right.

They've descended 9 layers.

And then, there was a large space, with absolutely nothing there.

They've continued to descend, but once 10,000 had passed, the stairway had disappeared.

In its place, a giant door.

Without hesitation, they've opened the door.

And.....

“Welcome, to mine kingdom of death, Dystopia.

Now, let us immerse in fun-filled times.

We’re holding back those behind thee, so lets begin!”

Skeleton, one word describes it all.

With Polished, pure white bones, it spoke to the empire’s troops in fluent human tongue.

Right after, a demoniac roar bellowed as if the very space itself was crushed under its pressure.

And with it a Spectral dragon (death dragon).

The strongest of the undead types and the vilest of dragons, it assaulted the empire’s soldiers.

The large door was swung completely open, and a continuous stream of death knight cavalry led by a death knight charged.

The Spectral dragon (death dragon) released corrosive zombie breath from above, while the death knights began their assault from the ground.

The empire army's numbers diminished in an flash, and the first 10,000 were wiped out in less than an hour.

After all, even if the death knights only number about a thousand, they would rise up no matter how many times they were felled.

This situation broke the minds of the empire's soldiers, driving them to the edge of despair.

Their enemy knew neither fatigue nor death. Then, there's the overwhelming threat from the skies known as the Spectral dragon (death dragon).

The second wave followed, and the first wave also met a similar fate.

More and more empire soldiers descended below, unbeknownst to them as they ceaselessly entered the jaws of death.

——Dungeon Stratum 71~80——

The empire's forces traversing this level were forced in a battle against an endless swarm of insects.

An endless onslaught, the bugs attacked fiercely.

With no fear of death, they fought in their swarms without rest.

However, the amount of “Monster cores” collected were high in both quantity and quality, bringing a smile to the soldier's faces.

They were simply endless, their individual fighting powers were nothing much.

If this were a normal adventurer party, they would be unable to rest from the endless onslaught, fatigue hampering their performance and ultimately be brought down.

However, even if there were a large quantity of bugs, the empire's numbers are nothing to scoff at.

Switching out those who are tired, the empire can still advance as one.

Even though the contents of the dungeon didn't match the reports, this isn't content a single should care about, and shouldn't mind the reports of their superiors.

There wasn't much time to rest, and the situation is still manageable, but it's the amount of luxurious goods they've obtained that brightened their mood.

For example, an earlier room had a treasure chest, and a soldier discovered a dagger within.

Glided with gold and silver, it was an expensive looking dagger. It had superior capabilities, and was made of demon steel.

A demon steel core alone would make something very expensive, yet the whole dagger was made of pure demon steel.

The soldier spoke of it with a grin.

Naturally there would be a body search afterwards, however a dagger of this degree could easily be sneaked through.

The surrounding soldiers were envious, and hoped themselves that it would be them next.

If there weren't perks like these, it would be unbearable to fight insects in such a place.

The number of “demon cores” collected had also piled up considerably.

High purity “demon cores” were difficult to come by, yet they could be easily procured here by defeating monsters.

This alone warranted quite the bonus.

There was a feeling of loathing when the first group screamed something about specters, but they felt like they hit the jackpot with this insect-filled stratum

And so everyone’s delusion of getting lucky continuously bloated.

While some started acting carelessly, there were also those who still remained alert.

Soon, those individuals gathered secretly and formed a group, consisting of the intelligence bureau and the reconnaissance bureau.

They had originally been allocated to separate groups, but soon they gathered.

The reason is simple.

They felt danger.

“This dungeon is dangerous, the conquering plan may have already failed”

One spoke without opening their mouth.

By holding hands and communicating via telepathy, this was a unique method of communicating within the intelligence bureau.

“Ah, you noticed?”

The powerful individual earlier, I think they’re known as the

floor boss.....”

“Ah, the one in front of the stairs right?

It’s strength is in a different league, it even took down a several high ranking soldiers.”

“Ah, it’s that guy. But, the report that followed was unbelievable.

It revived, in 3 hours.”

“W.....TF.....?”

And so, they’ve exchanged information.

The more they listened, the more chaotic this dungeon seems.

The current situation, was evidently different from prior reports.

When the situation doesn't match prior intelligence, forceful actions would be evaded while a re-investigation is commenced.

And yet, the higher ups forced the search to continue.

It's evident this was the result of prioritizing their desires, and so the intelligence bureau members wondered should they comply with the mission and fail with it.

As they were discuss should they retreat from the dungeon first

The head of the soldiers next to them had fell to the ground.

They're too late.

They weren't able to decide, as the time for talk was over.

"Fufufufu. The bait has arrived.

Good work all of you. You may now die."

They've heard a voice.

Resounding from the floor, a beautiful voice.

That, was the beautiful voice of this level's guardian floor boss, the Insect Queen Apito.

Transforming into Mental waves, it undulated throughout the entire floor.

And there it began, a one-sided slaughter.

Any amount of confident in their fighting strength was now all meaningless.

Even if they were A ranks, if they were below a certain threshold they were no different from amateurs.

Those who couldn't react aren't even given the chance to fightback.

The army wasps led by Apito.

They real identities, slaughters with 3D-maneuvers capabilities at hypersonic speed reaching sizes of only 30cm.

Small invisible wings emit terrifying high-frequency blades. Approaching you at speeds surpassing sound, they were silent killers.

These slaughters numbering over a thousand could seek out humans (game) with their heightened senses.

Excellent dynamic vision is meaningless, if one doesn't possess the unique skills "accelerated thinking" and "hyper reaction speed" they couldn't even possibly react to them.

An opponent beyond the perceivable range of humans, even if it's only one, would be classified as an A rank disaster class——On a side note when such a monster is discovered in the western countries an emergency alarm would be triggered. A subjugation team consisting of elite holy knights would be formed, and a large scale holy barrier would be erected to weaken the monster followed by a large area sweep. Still they must enter with the conviction to make sacrifices, for such was the danger of an A rank disaster class —— it was such a monster.

And thus begins the slaughter fest.

And the time it took to slaughter the empire soldiers was a measly less than 10 minutes.

——Dungeon Stratum 81~90——

They could say it now.

The first 2 floors were bonus stages.

Michael and Raymond are waging a desperate 2 man battle.

Their comrades aren't here anymore.

They, were all slaughtered.

The demon before them, with beautiful white hair, was an ape with wisdom.

However, they weren't the only ones suffering.

What they didn't know, was that beyond the 81st stratum, those who reached the lower floors are all engaged in a miserable battle.

The 81st stratum was simply a taster level. Where powerful beasts roam, it's the paradise of demonic beasts.

However, even though there are would be some head and shoulders above their group, they're basically wisdom-lacking monsters.

For veteran soldiers with a load of experience in their belts, they were opponents that could be taken down with ease.

Monsters beyond what they expected——on average, B+ monsters appearing in groups of 3 to 5——were a tough matchup, but they managed to clear the first floor with no casualties.

At this rate it would probably take some times, but given a few days conquering the dungeon could still be possible

...

Until that guy appeared.

With the capability of speaking human speech, it was an ape with wisdom.

Making use of Youjutsu, it had annihilated the army.

A pure white Youkai ape, a Byakuen.

Using a unique Taijutsu utilizing the staff, it was a phantasmagorical way of killing from the air.

Manipulating wind and sound, beckoning forth storms.

Then, slashing vacuum blades at all directions, it was an extremely dangerous demonic beast

Their encounter with this demonic beast has lasted over an hour, and their friends fell one by one.

Michael and Raymond, as “otherworlders” and as soldiers,

were reasonably relied on.

With their pride as strong individuals, they desperately fought against the demonic beast.

The sniping squad's attacks were blocked by the storms, the mage squad's debuffs, status effects, and even magic itself, were all interfered via Youjutsu.

A barrier of wind threw a monkey wrench into the plans of all direct magic attacks for their strength was insufficient.

Even the elites amongst the enhanced cybernetic troops of the empire are toyed like children with the Byakuen as their foe.

It was an unbelievable sight at first.

But in reality, it soon developed into a despair-filled battle, and only Raymond and Michel were left in the end.

Similar beasts also lurk in the other stratum.

The soldiers who lead the invasion began to painfully collapse.

When they were asked, there were also black spots on their skin, and high fever.

Small black mice scurried around their feet. Their existence was so insignificant the soldiers simply ignored them.

However, it was those very mice that were the perpetrators of the current situation.

Black Rats Coccus.

They, are the floor boss of this level.

Spreading Black Death everywhere, the rulers of plagues.

If someone with abilities like Shinji's were here, they would probably be able to neutralize this floor, unfortunately there isn't.

Magic treatment had little effect on the disease, and holy magic that could completely cure this was scarce.

Treatment of injuries and treatments of disease are based off completely different fundamentals.

In this fashion, death had spread throughout this floor.

Similarly in other floors,

The lightning clad trigger——The thunder Tiger Raiko, blocking all who attempt to pass the stratum.

—— the rabbit manipulating gravity—— Lunar Rabbit Getto——scattering tyranny here and there.

The snake with wings——Winged serpent Yoda——lowering the oxygen concentration in the air to 0 by manipulating air contents.

The sheep that reaps the conscious of soldiers——drowsy sheep mink ——lulling all to sleep with hallucinogenic hypnosis.

The bird with a cowl of flames——Fire bird Enchou——killing all soldiers with high temperature.

The dog that uses the mirror that reflects all——Mirror hound Igami——sending any and every technique back to sender.

At each stratum, was a vicious demonic beast rampaging about.

What's worse is the fact that even after being defeated they would revive.

This truth easily crippled the hearts of soldiers.

They could do naught but fight endlessly.

Mouse•Tiger•Rabbit•Snake•Sheep•Ape•Bird•Hound are all beast type demonic beasts.

They, are the Nine-Head Kumara's squad (pet) of eight.

Their forms are those of Kumara's and they each manifested an aspect of her abilities.

Kumara has the bewitching form and beauty of a courtesan, however in reality she is the illusive empress of the demonic beasts whom beckons death.

Before Kumara, the fools have finally arrived.

Yet, they are only food for Kumara.....

It would seem death is being mass-produced within the

labyrinth

And so.....

When the dungeon conquering of the empire's 350,000 soldiers had ended, a day has passed.

The number of survivors, is 0.

Chapter 158: The Absolute Strongest of the Labyrinth

A jet-black exoskeleton with golden joints peeking out.

A deep multi-colored blade-like horn at the center, with antennae (jet-black, like the exoskeleton) extending from both sides.

The exoskeleton, in accordance with the tastes of its creator Rimuru, had been reinforced with Demon Steel.

This special steel, having been cultured in large quantities inside Rimuru's stomach, was extraordinarily compatible with the exoskeleton.

Now, this living Demon Steel (properly called Adamantine) surpassed the strength of diamonds and achieved the flexibility of beings of flesh.

Forged from the most supreme material, it had become living armour.

But his strength was definitely not to be determined by his extraordinary exoskeleton.

His true strength... was derived solely from his instincts that desired battle.

And now, a new prey had appeared before him.

All according to his plan.

He was the absolute strongest of the Labyrinth.

The strongest guardian, Insect Emperor, Kaiser Zegion.

.....

.....

...

Michelle and Raymond, exhausted and breathing hoarsely, were sitting in the middle of the stairway.

By pure luck, they had somehow beat that disaster of a monster, the White Monkey.

But they from reports from other floors that these monsters always revived after being defeated.

So they ran with all their might before it had revived and made it to the stairs.

It wasn't confirmed, but there had been no reports of monsters coming up the stairs.

Maybe it was only their naïve hopes, but believing it to be the only safe space, they took refuge on the stairway.

“Oi..... what do we do now? Go deeper?”

“Don’t be stupid. We only went down 1 floor y’know?”

And that Demon Monkey Byakuen came out.

There might be a whole lot more down there, and we’ll be roast meat y’know?”

“Yea. But you got any clues how to get outta here?”

I myself don’t wanna head down even more, but now we can’t go back either, can we?

Ain’t this Labyrinth fukin’ impossible to capture?!”

There was the problem:

When going up the same stairway they came, they arrived at a completely different floor.

The way back to the surface was impossible.

In the beginning, there was no problem going back and forth, but suddenly, they were being sent to another floor.

Michelle and Raymond weren't aware but they had directly descended to the 81st floor.

And going down from there, ended up on floor 87.

There was no guarantee of getting back to floor 81 if they had gone back up, but even if they did, they would still have to go another 80 floors to get back.

Ramiris had distorted the space in the Labyrinth, and those who now entered would not be able to get out following the common sense of floor order.

Normally, it was impossible to go back to a Boss Floor like floor 79 after having cleared it, but even that rule was now broken.

Which meant that to get back to the surface, it would be necessary to go back up all the previous floors..... which was, evidently, insanely difficult.

So, if I'm getting this right... going up, you get to the previous floor, but going down, you end up in a random room?)

But, these survivors who hadn't known were unable to choose whether to go, or not to go, or to go.

Furthermore, even though water was somehow managed, food would only last another 8 days.

With that in mind, they would need to devour the flesh and blood of monsters, or else they wouldn't survive any more than 3 weeks.

Only a day had passed since the invasion. And already, the situation was that of complete despair and utter chaos.

“Hey, the Dev Committee, you think we can trust ‘em?”

Michelle asked Raymond pointing towards the bracelet on her wrist.

The Development Committee had manufactured an experimental product that supposedly made it possible to resurrect someone.

It was a replica of the item that Shinji and co., the Secret Reconnaissance team had brought back.

The people from the Development Committee had handed it over with confidence in their ability, but Michelle didn’t trust them.

If the effects had been confirmed, it would have been fine but.....

There was no time to make enough for all the troops, so only the elites received them, and no reports of revival had been received yet.

There was the tasteless joke, of which one of them would die first to prove the hypothesis.

Now, the joke was over.

“What idiot would believe this? Of course we can’t go around thinking we’ll just revive if we die.”

Raymond answers her rationally.

Michelle shared his opinion and shrugged in response.

But she kept the bracelet on anyway for peace of mind.....

According to Shinji and co., the ‘Revival Charm’ had

resurrected them in the Labyrinth City near the entrance of the Dungeon.

But it was a charm that based its power on the will of the Faerie of the Labyrinth, Ramiris.

This counterfeit bracelet had the sole effect of proving the idiocy of its wearer.

Michelle then removed the bracelet, and stomped on it.

With a dull sound, the item broke.

Watching her with a wry smile, Raymond followed suit.

Now, they depended on nothing but their own strength

They now stood back up with a bitter smile.

“You ready?”

“Yeah. Now that it's come to this, let's see just how far we can make it eh?

I finally got fired up again, and there's no way but down from here right?”

“You’re right, you’re absolutely correct!”

Determined to fight the good fight, they pressed forward.

With bright faces, they began descending the stairway with an unwavering heart.

With no idea what awaited ahead.

.....

.....

...

Recognizing their fiery souls, something slowly closed its eyes.

Closing its crimson dyed compound eyes, it analyzed its surroundings and thought.

That they who were approaching, had the determination to engage in battle.

Seeing that, it welcomed them.

To its desolate abode.

The ones who reached this floor were called to rejoice.

With the dignity of a human being, they would engage proudly with something much stronger, and receive death.

—— Labyrinth Floor 80, the Desolation Chamber, Prep Room——

The end of the stairs led into a dimly lit room.

The room had items practical for daily life and a number of chairs.

A single door further ahead.

From behind it, spewed out an unspeakably pure and concentrated Demonic Aura.

Michelle and co. descended the stairs on floor 87, and had arrived in that room.

80th Floor, in the preparation room before the Boss Room called the Desolation Chamber.

Those that had arrived had sat down, and were talking.

They were matching their findings.

As Michelle and co.

approached, one of them raised their hand and looked at them.

“What kinda place did you guys come from?”

From their words, Michelle had deduced that they had all come from different floors.

They probably knew that much already.

“We ended up with a stupid amount of monsters.

After this ridiculously struggle with a White Monkey, we got to here while deciding whether to go up or down.

” “I see, we beat this Giant Golem, and went down the stairs”

“And us, the Ghost King, Immortal King.

It was a formidable Demon King that ruled over the evil Undead.

But the real scary things were the Ghost Knights that were protecting the king.....”

“Other than the three of us, it was a bloody massacre on that floor.

A Ghost Dragon, Ghost Knights, and to top it all off, an

Immortal Ghost King.

It's a miracle even we survived.

Those Recon guys also challenged some really strong ones banding together”

These kind of stories were told.

Seven had gathered.

They didn't realize that they were the last of the Imperial army invaders.

But they had the feeling they were.

Tea and snacks, and even a napping area had been prepared in the room they were sitting in.

The stair going up had already disappeared.

There was a clock with a countdown.

Remaining time: around 3 hours.

As if it was their Last Supper.

“I guess..... we really can’t beat the next guy huh.”

“But is he just waiting for people to gather rather than kill us off one by one.....?”

Was spoken curiously, but this place would certainly let one rest even a bit.

There was probably no risk of poison, but the seven didn’t dare touch the provided food.

Everyone took out their Food Packs and restored their energy for what may be their last moments.

Betting on their lives.

“Alright. I got it.

To increase our chances, let's figure something out.

” Spoke the man who appeared to be the leader of the trio.

No one had objections.

This Labyrinth was never a place that the Empire could capture. That much was obvious from everything till now.

If they could go back to the surface now, they would vow never to step foot inside.

But such a vow would not be made. So, they would push forward.

“I’m Michelle, an ‘Otherworlder’

I’ve got the Unique Skill ‘Fusion’.

I hit really hard, but co-op is a bit weak.

” “Name’s Raymond, also an ‘Otherworlder’.

Unique Skill ‘Martial Artist’, I’ve got ‘Herculean Strength EX’”

Following Michelle and co., the rest of them began introducing themselves.

The men who beat the golem, Colonel Kansas and Major General Minutes.

Colonel Kansas — the hero who lead the Demon Village annihilation operation.

And, Major General Minutes.

The Commanding Officer of this very Labyrinth Capture Operation.

Michelle and Raymond began to readdress their behavior wondering what these big wigs were doing here.

Kansas ushered them to be at ease.

In the Empire, just being an “Otherworlder” could raise one’s rank.

These two are a great asset of the army, and it's hardly necessary to worry about rant in emergency situations like this.

After all, what they needed right now was not hierarchy, but purely strength.

And now for the trio.

They had belonged to the emperor's personal Imperial Guards.

Michelle and Raymond showed surprise at those words.

Even Kansas and Minutes couldn't hide their bewilderment.

"Here is proof. Identify!"

The trio took out their pendants and chanted briefly.

With that, dazzling light enveloped their bodies.

The became clad in Legendary Full Plate Mail, the best class of gear that, let alone obtain, one would be lucky to even gaze upon.

The armours shone brilliant gold as they were forged with the god tier material, Orichalcum.

Without a doubt this was the treasure bestowed by the Emperor himself upon his 100 absolute strongest guards.

Their aura proved them to be the genuine article.

3 of the Emperor's Personal Guards.

They had among them, 3 members who belonged to the Empire's strongest force.

And they themselves.

Boasting Elite tier skill, they belonged to the Remodelled Armoured Corps.

Emperor's Personal Guard No. 17: Khrishna.

Emperor's Personal Guard No. 35: Bazan.

Emperor's Personal Guard No. 94: Reiha.

Led by Khrishna, they had been working together.

Michelle and co.

rejoiced at the aspect of this new hope.

They numbered seven.

Most likely, no more were left to join them.

But, with these numbers.....

From the army that invaded the Labyrinth, these 7 elites had gathered.

The countdown had hit 0.

Followed by the door in front of them being opened.

They were ready.

Killing any hesitation, the 7 who had bet their lives on this fight, advanced.

—— Labyrinth Floor 80, the Desolation Chamber, Interior
——

The inside was pitch black. Reiha casted wide range Light Magic, 'Floor Light'.

What they saw almost froze their heart.

On this floor, a mountain was built with the corpses of Imperial Troops.

And at the peak, a single being.

It seemed to be in deep Zen Meditation.

It was slightly floating, which was likely the result of some powerful magic.

Michelle was sure of one thing.

This was the very monster that had led them here, the Demon Lord Rimuru himself.

So she,

“Are you..... The Demon Lord Rimuru?”

Had asked just to make sure.

But those words had infuriated Zegion.

“To mistake one as insignificant as I..... as the Great Demon Lord Rimuru.....

Your utter foolishness has set the path to survival to be but one.

To fight and defeat me, Zegion.

Struggle with all your might, and burn away the embers of your lives!”

The battle had begun.

(Rimuru POV)

Benimaru and I stared speechless at the scene depicted on the Large Screen.

The video of the Labyrinth interior, that was displayed now, showed silence as the Imperial troops were relieved of their lives.

The battle had ended.

But the scene we saw now had left us at a loss for words.

“Hey..... isn’t he like, stronger than you?”

After a while, I spoke my honest opinion.

Benimaru who refused to admit it said after another pause, “I’d be wrong to..... not consider the possibility.”

Said, frustrated.

The Inter-Labyrinth battle was going as predicted.

I was surprised when the giant Demon Golem and Alderman and co. were, respectively and successfully, brought down by 2 of the Empire’s elites, and a 3-man team donning dazzling Orichalcum armour and extraordinary strength.

It seems, some big shots had been mixed in with the rest.

A knight defeated Albert in single combat, and Alderman was done in by a Female Knight possessing great magical prowess.

Even the no-weakness Alderman, with his “Holy-Demonic Inversion”, was defeated by 2 Knights and a Female Knight, which made them a clear threat.

I was beginning to get a bit worried..... but really, there was no need.

The 2 elites, and the 3 in Orichalcum descended to the 80th floor at around the same time.

The culprit: Floor 80 Guardian, Zegion.

Zegion had forcefully called in the people who he personally admitted to be strong.

“If you’re lucky, someone strong might come along in y’know?” is what Ramiris had apparently said — I had sourced the information of their secret meeting from Beretta — but Rimuru ignored that.

Using brute force, Zegion made them come to him.

But, what was really scary was his Senses.

Sorting through every single soldier who invaded the Labyrinth, he had picked out the ones he wanted.

While meditating, he was probably aware of the tiniest of movements.

What an outrageous guy, this Zegion.

Along with the 2 others who may have been Otherworlders, the battle began.

In a word: Overwhelming.

The Knight who defeated Albert, thrust his Max Speed Sword Attack.

With his left hand, Zegion gently, calmly, perfectly following the enemy's movements, parried the sword.

Simultaneously, having now closed the distance, he pushed his right leg, infused with power, into the armour of the previous enemy.

The fierce power of his leg that hit the Knight wearing God-tier Golden Orichalcum armour had killed him in that single hit.

Hardly 3 seconds had passed.

Even before she had noticed the death of her comrade, the Female Knight was cut down.

She had been blessed.

She was able to die without fear or pain.

“U, U~Ooooo! You’ve done it now! Die, monster! Dimension Cutter!!”

The last armoured Knight, unleashed his technique in a fit of rage

“Pitiful”

The distortion of space around Zegion was completely nullified.

“The skill I received from Demon Lord Rimuru’s Raphael-sama makes any attack fall short!”

That was..... Covenant King Uriel’s Absolute Defence —— Spatial Distortion Field —— ain’t it!

Zegion’s Spatial Dominance had surpassed the power of a Unique Skill.

It was on par with the Absolute Defence of Chloe, who had fought Veldora once upon a time.

No wonder he can match Veldora in single combat.

Doesn't that mean Zegion is at the level of those Ancient Heroes?

What fearsome growth potential.

And that form also looked familiar.

His exoskeleton that seemed to grant the battle potential of a Combat-Specialized monster.....

(Oi, Raphael, Isn't that.....)

“Solution.

You may have forgotten, but Master has been sharing part of his body.

As a result, providing Individual: Zegion with the super optimization, Full-Tuneup, He has gained a body similar to Master's"

I remember.

When I saved Zegion who was on the verge of death, I used part of my body to seal the wound.

It was a time when Zegion was a simpler Insect type monster.

He was a hybrid of Rhinoceros and Stag Beetles, which was seriously super cool.

At only 50cm height, he was apparently a pretty rare Insect Type Demon Beast, so I left him in the care of Ramiris.

Well, similar to him, who was placed in the Labyrinth, followed by having part of my body being embedded inside and strengthening him.....

there was a certain bee.

They became the ones we know and love as Zegion and Apito, but I hadn't expected this to happen.

Apito had a Demon Steel coating only in 'name'..... but that Zegion had gone thru some super Accelerated Evolution.

If I had to describe it, he had developed my ideal type of combat form, becoming a battle hungry demon.

In addition, the full body remodelling received from good ol' Wisdom Lord Raphael had put the finishing touches on his current form.

This Zegion had further received special training from Veldora, his current opponents were but small-fry.

My prediction was correct.

“Dimension Ray!”

Spreading open his fingers, Zegion swung down his right hand.

Just like that, the space-time continuity distorted and the very dimension had been cut.

The armoured Knight was ripped apart without resistance, another of them got caught up in collateral damage.

In 10 seconds, a total of 4 people had died.

Oh boy. This guy's bad news.

He had surpassed the limits of man.

No mistake, he left those limits in the dust.

In my opinion, Apito is around Hinata levels in strength.

But even she, wouldn't last 3 minutes with this Zegion.

When Zegion actually got serious.

Why the hell is someone like that in the Labyrinth? A damn waste, that's what it is right? Is what I'd have you think I thought, but this guy's gonna be the secret weapon.

Yeah that's what I'll do. Or rather, every time I leave my pal, Wisdom Lord Raphael, in charge, things have a tendency to go out of hand.

I don't need him for anything as of right now, but we're gonna need to have a talk soon.

It was only a matter of time till the remaining 3 die.

A compressed explosion meant to cause high intensity heat wave damage to Zegion, shows no effect against Absolute Barrier.

And Herculean Strength does nothing to him either.

The guy(ossan) with super speed attacks thanks to his remodelled body, didn't seem to move at all in Zegion's eyes.

Less than a minute had passed and all 7 were defeated.

To be perfectly honest, say I fought Zegion in the same form as him, say I didn't use my other powers, I'd probably lose.

That's how I had come to ask Benimaru such a question.

It's a dog eat dog- err- slime eat slime world, and I mean to always be vigilant.....

But with someone like this literally under our noses the whole time, my preconceptions got flipped upside down.

The world truly works in mysterious ways.

So there you have it, the Labyrinth invasion had ended, and I had acquired another 350,000 souls.

And on the surface, the final battle was about to begin.

Chapter 159: Capital Defensive Battle

With no contact from the Labyrinth Invasion Force, Armoured Corps chief, General Calgurio, had become increasingly nervous.

Rather than the treasures, the high quality “Demon Crystals” were likely going to be needed much more from now on.

Since there was never enough, he had been leasurely watching them being brought up.

With around 350,000 troops already inside, there wasn’t a need to send in any more. Even with all the possible dangers, suddenly losing contact with all of them was not predicted.

If something like —— say Veldora —— suddenly appeared, the fight would start at the front but all the soldiers would be notified by use of Thought Linkage (thx @Alpha). But then, this happened.

The Labyrinth entrance didn’t show any abnormalities, but

there was no sign of anyone inside.

“What’s this all now?”

Calgurio muttered, but his advisors are just as lost as him.

To that,

“A Labyrinth is a place to explore.

It’s certainly not one that an army invades is it?”

Responded a bewitching beauty.

Wearing the Imperial Armoured Corps uniform, spoke one of the 3 bosses of Cerebrus, Miranda.

With orders from Yuuki, she was keeping an eye on Calgurio

while also reporting back on the progress of the Tempest Invasion Operation.

But as a member of the Amoured Corps HQ Advisory Committee, she certainly had the brains.

So obviously, she was well received as one of Calgurio's advisors.

“Are those the words of that brat Yuuki?”

“Yes.

He says that to capture the Labyrinth, we must send in only the elites”

“What nerve! I did send in the elites!!”

Replied an annoyed Calgurio to her response.

More precisely, these elites were the 350,000 troops belonging to the Remodelled Corps who took pride in being the strongest corps in the whole Imperial Army. It was simply avaricious to ask for more.

“But as you can see, the thing has eaten up all of them, and it still stands.

We can't confirm the situation inside, and sending in even more seems like a bad idea.

Right now, the only thing we can do is wait till someone comes out alive, no?”

“Be at ease woman. The elites have been supplied with a charm that can revive them.

We have reports confirming that they should revive back here at the entrance upon death.

And judging from the fact that none have shown up, we can

assume that there are no problems.”

“You know..... we can’t have you ignore the fact that we have not confirmed if that charm actually works, now can we?

Yuuki-sama has already said that, it’s impossible for a cheap replica to replace a charm made with a Skill.”

Calgurio didn’t respond.

A General doesn’t rely solely of brute strength. He isn’t so incompetent so as to not understand the state of the battlefield, even if he was lacking in strength.

Miranda was certainly on point. They did not know whether revival was actually possible.

But it wasn’t possible to throw in 350,000 troops and not expect simple maze to be completely conquered.

This was a force capable of burning several capital cities down to ashes.

Worst case scenario, they could only escape the Labyrinth after completely destroying it.

200,000 troops were headed for the capital of Tempest, with another 150,000 on standby.

Rather than another 150,000, it's better to say only 150,000 are left.

Now that it had come to this, Calgurio considered the possibility of underestimating Tempest.

They should gather up the whole army, and go attack the capital with full force.

Calgurio considered various plans, and then,

“Leave one Communications Platoon here, and prepare to capture Tempest’s capital!

And for the Labyrinth Invasion Force, prepare a search team, and——”

He was not allowed to finish.

Without warning, Calgurio and his men were swallowed up by circumstances that had suddenly become insane.

Their divide and conquer plan, was now all up in smoke.

Though the Labyrinth Capture force was quickly prepared, the capital was yet to be captured.

At only a few kilometers from their current location, it was

like a stones throw away.

The Imperial forces thus decided to set up base, and only Reconnaissance had been sent to Tempest.

Gerudo laughed.

No matter how much recon they did, there aren't any traps, so it was a waste of time.

The capital was too close for traps, so it was decided that they would be fighting head on.

On top of that, their difference in number was like heaven and earth.

However, Gerudo's role was to keep them busy, a minimum force to defend the the capital's forefront.

It was a favorite strategy of the Dwarf King, from inside the troops acting as a wall, a fearsome magic attack gets launched.

It was a plan well suited for Gerudo and his men.

The magical might: courtesy of Crimson.

These personal guards of Benimaru were the cornerstones of this plan. We also got reinforcements in the form of 5000 or so elite Black Mages from all over the the Great Jura Forest.

There were more waiting to join them, but only the ones with high attack power had gathered this time.

The ones on the waiting list were on standby, and on the slight chance that Gerudo had lost, they were to fight as the last stand.

At that time, along with the volunteer human soldiers, they were in the process of organizing.

The 5000 Black Mages who came were led by the self-acclaimed wife of Benimaru, Momiji the Tengu.

“For my husband, VICTORY!!”

It was a very sugary kind of battle shout.

They had already constructed a moat around the area.

Perhaps she was better at strategy building than Benimaru, but the latter probably didn't mind, thought Gerudo.

If he actually hated it, he would have said something by now.

Well, Benimaru's 'Generallisimo' wasn't just for show is what it meant.

The Attack Team and the Support Team were both ready.

Now it was only a matter of whether they of the Imperials had better Magic Barriers, as the initial shoot off may get to decide the outcome of the battle.

Well..... if they got to do that in the first place that is.

Shion had come over and, since then, they were pretty much taking it easy.

Taking is easy would normally be bad with the sheer numbers that they faced.

But if a completely ridiculous person like Shion worked as a counter-balance, the scale would tip a lot more on their side.

Benimaru had said,

“Let her do what she wants. She’s not gonna listen anyway.

But the enemy will get confused from her actions, so take that chance to strike!”

Gerudo’s job was now solely that of a wall to stop enemies passing in.

And while Shion confused the enemy, they would break them apart.

A simply simple plan.

Gerudo believed in Benimaru, and believing in him, he would do what he was assigned to do.

And after a day of just watching each other, the battle started.

Gerudo’s wall was rightly impregnable.

The Imperial Army could not break through the 17,000 High

Orcs that made up the Yellow and Orange Numbers.

Their portable magic cannon proved useless against Gerudo's Unique Skill 'Guardian', which provided his whole army with an iron-clad defense.

Furthermore, Gerudo's 'Gourmet' Unique Skill made his stomach storage shared with all his troops.

Minor injuries were immediately treated with magic from the Support Team, and recovery potions were prepared for serious ones.

In anticipation for the battle, a large number of recovery potions were stored in Gerudo's 'stomach'.

The 'stomach' incubated everything in a sterile environment, so there was no problem with directly using the items inside.

From the outset, being able to heal like this without moving, effectively made these High Orcs into a true wall.

Observing Gerudo's battle from the sky was, a certain demon.

It was Carrera.

This Demon Lord had been assigned to Information Committee duties that day, with 2 others following her.

Gerudo happily accepted the girls and had them do as they pleased.

That was because he really had no other duty to assign to Carrera and co.

Carrera had received instructions from Rimuru to protect Gerudo.

As was probably true for Testarossa and Ultima, if there was someone stronger than the Executives assigned for the battles, Carrera and co. had the role of buying time until reinforcements arrived.

But, now it was different.

Because of the “Go all out!” wish from their master Rimuru.

As such, something similar to the time with Testa and Ul would happen again.

Overkill, but that was what going all out meant.

That being the case, Carrera was about to shoot out some Nuclear Strike Magic.

“He~~~y wait! Carrera-sama, what in the world were you about to do just now?!”

Arch-Demon Agera stopped her in a hurry.

Being around the Carrera who was like this for many years, she was able to read her behaviour patterns and take action this

time.

“Oya? Is something wrong, Agera dear?

I was just going to fry up those things on the ground with some nuclear goodness, you know?

How’s that? Genius right?

They won’t even get to see us, a perfect ‘going all out’ if I do say so myself!”

“Amazing and Perfect! As expected of Carrera-sama!!”

“You there, you shut your mouth!

.....Please listen to me carefully Carrera-sama. That one isn’t what we call a ‘going all out’ ok?”

“w.....what?”

First shutting up her fellow demon Esprit, with Carrera, who was a bit off in the head, Agera explained slowly like one would a child.

Her superior, Carrera, was like a runaway car with the brakes taken off.

Stopping her was a high difficulty task.

With a ridiculous power, she came with no responsibility.

Her colleague Esprit, who was supposed to share in her pain, was instead only encouraging Carrera.

To that end, Agera suffered plentiful mental stress.

Testarossa would be evil but rational, and Ultima kept it

under control too.

But, this Carrera who went 100% from the very start, was hopeless.

After going all out, and laughing about going too far , was something she had been doing with them till now, albeit hesitantly.

Until now, it was sort of okay.

They were elites among the most elite demons.

They worked under no one thanks to their raw power.

But now, to gain Demon Lord Rimumu's favor, they needed to gain the ability to use their brains too.

Agera was already doing that.

But she wanted her superior to use some grey matter too, it was her sincere wish.

This ever enduring Agera desperately tried — as they displayed symptoms of ADHD, she talked slowly and carefully. It was really hard — to talk some sense into these people.

Suddenly, something strange happened to the Imperial troops closing in.

Purple haired leader the Immortal Corps Yomigaeri, Shion's, personal guards charged.

They numbered 10,000.

Yomigaeri had since taken in a lot of Shion's fans who had gotten personal training from the woman herself.

Agera could clearly see that from the sky that, despite their numbers, their strength was not to be trifled with.

Every one of them had inherited Shion's 'Fear Haki'.

These 10,000 troops, these Terror Knights, were thrown towards the Imperial army.

The enemy began to surrender from the horror they unleashed.

Their actual strength sealed off through fear tactics, the enemy faced a hopeless situation, as Shion's team one-sidedly went wild.

They dominated the battlefield, donned in purple armour made by the eldest of the dwarf brothers, Garm.

3 of them in particular rampaged while releasing crazy amounts of Demonic Aura.

These were the 3 sons of Demon Lord Dagrul.

Those three had become the very incarnation of violence, spewing out plentiful amounts of 'Fear Haki'.

It was as if there were 3 vortexes in the middle of the battlefield, swallowing up and dismantling the Empire's forces.

Other than the 3 giants, every one of Shion's corps displayed an overwhelming of force incomparable to when they were newly formed.

She didn't know what kind of training they went through, but, though she was a Demon, Agera couldn't help but feel a chill.

"Look at that Agera, while you were blabbering on, Shion-san got a leg ahead. Care to take responsibility?"

Agera now became very nervous.

Carrera is usually like a car without brakes, but when she gets angry, its more like an 18 wheeler filled with TNT (without

brakes).

And If Agera herself was the target of her rage, she would be dead a week ago.

“Carrera-sama! Look, there’s some live game back there!

We can settle for them them right?”

Dammit Esprit! You have my utmost gratitude, you lovable idiot you! So and the two of them turned to where she was pointing.

Around half of the 200,000 who had come here, were busy setting up camp.

Carrera nodded with a smile,

“O you’re right, they are! Very well, prepare the tea so I can

start snacking!”

She nodded with a satisfied look.

It was now completely out of Agera’s hands.

They were definately going to get scolded if Carrera was allowed to go out of control, but that was something later.

The important thing was that Carrera wasn’t directing her anger at herself anymore.

The hardships of the ever enduring Agera, had yet to end.

In the end, The troops who were stationed farther away as the 2nd wave of the Capital Capture Force, were finished off with a single aerial attack.

The barrier generated from their special weapon Magic

Canceller, was easily broken and they were decimated with Large-Scale Annihilation Magic.

Agera and Esprit disabled different types barriers according to the types they specialized in.

And with precise timing, made it possible to leave them completely defenseless.

Nuclear Magic 'Gravity Collapse'.

Suddenly not being able to handle the pressure from their own weight, an intense gravity crushed the Imperial troops where they stood.

The area they had cleared to make a base, standing out in the demon's eyes made it impossible for them to run away or fight back.

With its full power, the ultra-gravity increase could cause a huge explosion but that didn't happen this time.

Carrera had kept Agera's words in mind apparently.

And without the explosion, as the last of weakling troops were crushed to death, the gravity magic ended.

This wasn't an action taken by someone who moved in an organized army like fashion.

But Carrera, now satisfied with that one attack, went back to join the rest.

And returned to being Gerudo's support.

The scene she left behind was like an Imperial army after a catastrophic natural disaster.

Their only relief, being granted death so suddenly, was having no time to feel regret or fear.

If inversely, some had survived, their soul buried in fear, their hatred for the empire and the realization of their own foolishness, such thoughts would certainly have eaten up at their lives.

In this way, the preliminary attack force of the Empire got one-sidedly overwhelmed by Shion's overpowered army, and their reinforcements were permanently put at ease by Carrera.

And Gerudo's wall, forget being broken, had not even budged a single step.

Tempest's Capital Defensive Battle was a complete offensive victory.

And with this siege battle over with, the war had moved to the clean up operations of the last portion of the enemy.

Chapter 160: Cleaning up the mess

Calgurio was surrounded by bad news.

It was no longer up for debate, the invasion plan had failed miserably.

No, now was not a time to idle.

It was a situation where he was starting to doubt if they could even leave this forest alive.

(How did this happen? Wait, from when did it even start.....?)

Agitated and failing to calm himself down, Calgurio tries to set his mind to figuring out a plan for the soon to come battle.

Their prospects being utterly hopeless, he must nevertheless perform his duty as a General, as a man responsible for the lives of his troops.

At least, he could not allow himself to lose his cool.

The very first report confirmed that the battle had commenced.

The heated battle had reached a stalemate.

The enemy had built a defence line comparable to an impregnable wall that, even with all their numbers, they couldn't break through with brute force.

The Anti-Magic Cannons and Wide Area Magic blasts from their Mages were nullified by the enemy's perimeter wide Force Field, effectively sealing off that form of attack.

A splendid show of defence, he must admit.

The Labyrinth Invasion Force being effectively AWOL, capturing the capital was also proving much more troublesome than imagined.

Putting the pieces together, Calgurio had finally begun to realize his utter and complete loss.

By that time, it was long past too late.

Tensions rose further for the Imperial troops.

A new enemy battalion had arrived. And they strangled the battlefield with fear.

In the blink of an eye, many comrades had fallen.

The enemy's numbers being only a fraction of their own, it was nevertheless a one-sided slaughter from the minority's side.

The Threat Estimation team reported that, it was a battalion consisting of many high level monsters.

But most of them were of similar level to the Empire's forces.

There were not many who could be considered A rank or above.

However, as the results clearly showed, the Imperial troops were being cornered.

And that wasn't all.

From behind the enemy's impregnable wall formation, unbelievably strong wide area Magic was being shot out.

The enemy's Magic had achieved its task of leaving the Imperials greatly damaged.

The aim of the battalion in purple, spreading fear and confusion over the Imperial troops, was to decrease the load on their forcefield.

A splendid show of teamwork.

But if that was the only problem, there would still have been room for striking back.

The capital capture force had been divided into 2 teams of 100,000, a first contact and a rear guard group.

If the first contact group got weakened from battle, the rear guard would immediately go in as support, and switch in ready and able troops.

This plan to overwhelm the enemy was only possible due to their vast superiority in numbers.

(Lasting even a single hour would show that this Demon Lord was competent.)

Not knowing just how defeated they actually were, Calgurio was relaxed with his thoughts.

His ease was taken away by the events that followed.

Calgurio's and his advisors were observing the situation from a few kilometers away using Telescopic Magic.

Everyone of them had lost the power to speak.

It was at that very moment, that their confidence broke.

The Threat Estimation team began screaming like mad men.

“R-retreat! Sir, please order retreat right now!!”

It was all over, and.....

The scene that unfolded in front of their eye let them know exactly what those words meant.

It was the utter tragedy that was the fate that befell on the rear guard group, who were getting ready to support their comrades on the frontlines.

The cause: a devastating nuclear magic known as 'Gravity Collapse'.

Releasing an insane amount of force, the cruel magic crushed them all.

With gravity like that of a star, a localized gravity field had been generated.

Anyone who may have been inside that super compressed area, had been crushed without exception.

If that kind of force had continued any longer, all the energy would get focused on a single point, eventually creating a small black hole.

The enemy did not intend to go that far, thankfully.

Eliminating the majority of the troops, the magic had ceased.

But, with almost 100,000 dead, it'd be a miracle if any had survived.....

“I-it’s a monster. A single..... a single attack with that kind of magic.....

Even though it was in theory only.....

Even though the amount of energy needed was completely unrealistic, and had never been used before.”

Even Calgurio understood that much.

It was possible in theory, and was still in the experimental stages.

As there was no precedent, gathering up the best minds in the Empire, working with cutting edge technology, building and improving the theory, it was groundbreaking research on the highly anticipated concept of nuclear magic.

And they now saw it used..... and in the most perfect sense.

And that, by a single beast.

Demon Lord.

The reality of that title, gouged at Calgurio's brain.

Had they just declared war on something they must never challenge?

In the first place, to maintain a magic on that scale, even 10 elite mages wouldn't last.

Without clearly understanding the scale of that much energy, their concentration would break, leading to them suffering spontaneous combustion.

To even stop it in the process..... perfectly, it was definitely

the work of a fearsome Demon.

“But..... we still have the Magic Cancellor that can.....”

“No Calgurio-sama, we need to immediately order retreat.”

The man who had abruptly come inside the tent, advised Calgurio.

You’re out of line soldier, is what he would’ve said if he had not looked at the man,

“A-Are you by chance Krishna-dono?”

Sent by the Emperor himself, this man was an elite and a priceless asset for the war.

As someone he had challenged many times, Calgurio knew this man was undeniably a strong warrior.

That man was now in rags, the Empire's strongest Legendary armour he donned falling apart, with large holes in its upper part.

He had the appearance of having faced a fierce battle.

“Look, Bazan and Reiha are already gone. Colonel Kansas and Major General Minutes too.

And also..... 2 ‘Otherworlders’. There's monsters in the Labyrinth that easily took on all of us.

That nuclear magic just now, It probably wasn't the Demon Lord (Rimuru) either.

Multiple Arch Demon level enemies were reported to be seen in the Labyrinth.

And, there are even Demon Lord level ones.

That attack just now, likely came from one of those.

Now that you know this, I implore you to make the right decision, there is no shame!”

“Not the Demon Lord?

But a number of the same tiered Demon Lords, you say?!

So this is the power..... of this country.

If Storm Dragon Veldora comes out now..... we can't hope to win.

And Demon Lord Rimuru hasn't even moved himself, you say.....

Gather the troops! We're retreating!!”

Of the 3 Revival Charms that were confiscated from Shinji and co., one of them was secretly in the possession of Calgurio.

2 of them were taken in for research purposes, and one of those ended up with Krishna.

Being the Emperor's direct order, the researchers had no choice but to hand over their research materials.

One of the charms, they had completely broken down, and thanks to that last one, Krishna was able to miraculously revive.

With this the charm's effects were confirmed and coincidentally, the replica's effect had also been confirmed.

The troops in the Labyrinth, were truly wiped out.

A total of 350,000 soldiers, dead.....

But Calgurio did not have the time to become distraught.

Giving the still living a chance to escape this madness took priority.

They would need to regroup with The Magic Tank Platoon, and Aerial Fighter Legion's 400 Airships that were working separately from them.

At worst, they would have to completely retreat back to the Empire, but that was much better than getting annihilated here.

Calgurio decided to act now.

But, once again, too late.

"Kufufufufu. We can't have that now. I implore you to give me a bit of attention too."

The Devil had sneaked in, and was definitely not going to let go of his prey.

HQ was in panic.

Only one monster had invaded in.

But the aura he emitted was more powerful than anything that they had ever seen.

This demon who had the same height as them, had a presence much stronger than that of a ferocious dragon.

Moreover, it had come this far in without anyone suspecting a thing.

It was able to completely erase its enormous Aura.

The guards pointed their swords towards it.

But, with his body gone limp, Calgurio didn't possess the will to hold his sword anymore.

“Kufufufufu. You insects would face me in battle as equals?”

The red haired devil, Diablo laughed.

Calgurio glanced at Krishna, but the latter was already crouching down.

Sensing the enemy's absolute might, he had lost all hope.

Calgurio, betting his last bit of hope, tried to negotiate with Diablo.

“Excuse me, I am known as Calgurio.

The General of this army, and the highest authority in this room.

May you be kind enough so as to let us know your name?”

“Oya? You’re a polite one.

My ‘name’ is Diablo. Loyal servant of Demon Lord Rimuru.”

As he had guessed, this was a Named devil.

In the first place, something of its class would be an oddity if it didn’t have a name.

Confirming that the devil had intelligence and understood reason, Calgurio pressed forward with negotiations.

“Diablo-dono, we wish to offer surrender.

If we continue to fight like this, would your side not also suffer damage?

How about it?

Of course, we will pay any reparations, and never again think of stepping onto this land with the intention of war.

In fact, consider the Empire and Tempest allied nations!

We will never forget this kindness.

May we ask for audience with Demon Lord Rimuru? How about it?”

Looking at their current conditions, all 350,000 of the Labyrinth Invasion Force had been annihilated.

And, of those in the capital, more than half were dead or unable to fight.

With the other divisions being out of contact, including the

remaining 150,000 troops here, around 200,000 could still be saved.

It was the best course of action to protect them, what with the enemy having an overwhelming advantage, they would surely die.

Calgurio had made the decision to see Demon Lord Rimuru to try and negotiate a way out of this country.

This war had been their complete defeat.

They had underestimated the enemy by a long shot.

Their army was capable of taking down 3 of the old Demon Lords at the same time. (TN: No, its ok, we all know you can't even touch Milim-tan....)

Even with all the western countries' armies combined, they would only number a third of the Imperial forces.

All their confidence, and this was the result.

Under Demon Lord Rimuru, there were multiple Demon Lord level monsters.....

The best choice was to pay up the reparations, and ensure a future for themselves.

Almost 500,000 had already died, no doubt this was the end for Calgurio, but any more losses could even cause the Empire to collapse.

Calgurio was greedy, sure, but he wasn't foolish.

This was his reasoning.

If it meant that the Empire would survive, he was more than willing to sacrifice himself.

But, this time too, it was too late.

“Kufufufufu. You’re a bit too late now.

The only ones still alive are you lot here.”

Calgurio didn’t understand his words.

His advisors were the same, Diablo’s words didn’t convey any meaning.

But diablo payed no heed.

He snapped his fingers with a ‘Pachin!’ sound.

Which caused the tent to be blown away, and the scene to be burned into Calgurio’s eyes.

It was a sea of corpses.

As if sleeping, the soldiers had died instantly in the middle of work.

As if only their souls were taken out.....

No, not 'as if' but in reality, their souls had been stolen away without resistance but the Red Haired Devil, Diablo.

In the first place, Diablo had no reason to actually try to sneak into the enemy base.

It would be a pain to kill anyone who noticed him.

With that reason, while walking in, he reaped the souls of all the enemy soldiers with 'End of the World'.

Actually, 'Demon Lord's Ambition' was enough to do the job,

but then it would cause a ruckus.

Diablo never had any intention of letting the enemy go.

So he went and cleaned up the mess without hesitation.

Diablo was, in reality, a natural loner.

Because of that, he never took on any personal subordinates.

Useless tools, he would throw away.

Right now, a lesser demon, Venom, had been following him around, but if he was useful, he'd be put to use.

For Diablo, tools only had meaning in their utility

With that mindset, he cared not for useless underlings, and

moreover, wanted to be a useful tool for his master Rimuru.

`U , u..... U~OOOOOOOOOO!!'

Calgurio screamed, almost vomiting blood, and glared at Diablo.

His rage from the death of comrades had overcome any fear.

At which point, a brilliant armour slams into Calgurio, to try and calm him down.

The strongest armour, a remnant from the age of gods.

Gifted from the Emperor, it was a God-tier armour

It was the symbol of the Empire's strength, only the 4 generals were allowed to even witness its glory.

“Fuck you, Demon! I’ll fucking obliterate you!”

“Kufufufufufu, now that’s what I’m talking about.”

The final battle would begin with both parties leering.

But it would be wrong to call it an actual battle.

Calgurio was so much of a lesser organism compared to Diablo that, even if he was wearing the God-Tiered armour, it would make no difference.

A tool has meaning, only in the hands of its owner.

There is no sadder tale than an owner who can’t bring out the full potential of his tool.

Diablo had no need to actually fight against Calgurio, as it was merely a matter of reaping his soul.

150,000 Imperial troops had formed a base around the Labyrinth entrance.

Leaving a small number of superiors, every one of them had been eliminated without them having the slightest idea as to how.

Thus, the enemy invading Tempest were wiped out without achieving much of anything.

For now the crisis had been averted.

—— But was it ever really a danger, would depend on the person asked.

The Imperial invasion of Tempest, thus ended in failure.

Chapter 161: A demon lord's work isn't a god's

Calgurio opened his eyes while feeling a gentle warmth wrapped around himself.

(Wh-where is this?)

He couldn't remember exactly what he had been doing till now.

A silver haired girl, she looked about ten and wore an angelic smile, was busily working on something.

He looked to his side and saw an injured comrade — he guessed Krishna —, on whom the girl put her hand on. The hand released lights of all colors which went inside the injured comrade.

After some time, that person — it was Krishna after all — also woke up, and looked back at Calgurio.

Similar to himself, Krishna had also woken up in a state of confusion, also unaware of his current situation.

The silver haired girl continued to do the same task, without realizing that he and Krishna had awoken.

After having worked on the ~100 people in the room just like them, satisfied, she nodded, and faced Calgurio.

“Hey, you’re awake right? Feel sick? Can you tell me your name?”

The girl asked him in a casual tone.

No, he did not feel any discomfort.

One reason could be the healing effect of the girl’s cuteness, but the main reason was that her presence soothed any tension floating in the air.

Seeing Calgurio and the others being hesitant,

“Huh? Didn’t it work? I thought I followed the ritual perfectly.....”

The girl made a troubled face.

Apparently, he and the others had had some ritual performed on them, but his body did not feel anything strange.

To be precise, he did have some fatigue.

By now, he remembered that they were currently at war with Tempest.

“W-where is he? What happened to the red haired devil? Did we really survive?”

Shouted Calgurio.

With that statement, the others also finally remembered the events up to that point, and realized the strangeness of their current situation.

Indeed, Calgurio and the others were murdered by the devil Diablo.

His attacks being completely useless, Diablo's hand had pierced his chest and ripped apart his heart. Calgurio recalled that much.

That was why he doubted the fact that he was now alive.

“Oh, remember now? You remember your name?”

She asked him again.

“My name is Calgurio.

I am the general in charge of the Imperial Armoured Corps, and I was entrusted as the commander-in-chief for the operation this time.

The operation details are confidential, so forgive me, I cannot say.

Rather than that, are you the one who saved us?”

He said in a continuous breath.

To save them from their predicament meant she had to be very powerful herself.

They had been caught by a Demon, no, a Demon Lord.

To save them from that kind of threat, Calgurio couldn't imagine her as anything other than a 'Hero'.

She could be one of the Emperor's Personal Guards in the ranks of 1st to 10th, but the feat she had achieved alone raised doubts on that theory.

In fact, if she was a Guard, Calgurio would definitely recognize her face, and they would have been working together during the mission.

She was someone too strong for him to not know about.

“Hm? You know, we're the ones who took care of your little 'operation' you know?”

You're probably misunderstanding something, and I'll explain in detail, but, you are all dead.

Don't you remember all your soldiers died?

Well, some may have survived, but let's get to that later.

I see your memories are fine, the ritual was a success then.

Well, then.

Pleasure to meet you, I'm Rimuru.

Demon Lord Rimuru.

Currently acting as king of this country.

Regards. Also, I'll say this if you didn't figure it out yet, but I'm the one who revived you.

As for the details on that matter, you'll get to know soon enough.

Calgurio couldn't understand the words spoken to him and was in a daze.

When the meaning finally connected, Calgurio opened his eyes as wide as possible and carefully observed the girl from head to toe.

This girl was Rimuru.

She was the enemy they were supposed to defeat.

She was Demon Lord Rimuru, one of the current pillars of Octagram.

This little girl!?

Revived she says? Who? Us she says!?

Surprise and confusion, and mostly fear swirled around in Calgurio's heart.

But not only him, every revived person in the room shared the

same feelings.

They needed a bit of time to collect their lost marbles.

Leaving aside a confused Calgurio and co., I came out from the tent.

The 100 or so people inside were the ones who Diablo had killed, the army General and his advisors.

The ones most responsible for this invasion, so to speak.

I carefully tried out the revival ritual as an experiment, and it turned out great.

Of course, this is only to have them take responsibility.

Accordingly, we have erected a force field around the tent, and Souei is on guard duty.

Escape was impossible.

Well, as for the revival, it was only partial.

I had no reason to return their souls.

They attacked first, so dying serves them right.

But, for various reasons, I had to go and perform the revival ritual on them.

This ritual revived someone to a transient state.

After that time when Shion died, Raphael had begun to analyse the properties of the soul.

The Spirit Jewel I took from Clayman used human souls as its basic component.

It carried around 10,000 souls' worth of energy.

But, its power had a time limit, and it could only be used as a single burst of very high energy amplification.

According to Raphael's analysis, around 100 fused human souls could be used to make such an energy amplification jewel.

Despite its name, it wasn't that great an item.

The instant doping could be useful, but it wasn't wise to rely on it, so Raphael had broken it down to the soul level.

And because the process could be reversed, he put more time into studying the soul.

For all beings, souls had a quality and a quantity component.

Quality aside, flora and fauna had souls of very little energy.

Compared to that, the amount in human souls was enormous.

Whether this much energy was in any and all humans was not yet confirmed.

Were they actually using this energy? It depended on their Skills, which used such Spirit Energy.

Data engraved on the soul, would become one with the soul's bearer.

As for whether it was possible to input this data directly, it wasn't so simple.

First of all, there's the ego, which is enveloped by the Nucleic

Heart.

It is there that all the data is engraved.

The crystallizations of energy around the Nucleic Heart forms into the soul.

The Possession Jewel was a vessel on which this Heart was projected.

The Heart didn't possess its own energy, but the ego did.

So it was possible to have an ego without necessarily having a strong enough soul to utilize Skills.

And the Possession Jewel is able to use the Spirit Energy as a substitute for one's internal reserve of energy.

But that had its limits, considering that the quality of the

energy being different.

Well, it was a simple toy for enjoying the Labyrinth so the limits didn't matter.

The point is, even if the Nucleic Heart had Skill data engraved inside, without enough Spirit Energy, the Skills could not be used.

For reviving Calgurio and co. on this occasion, I used Possession Jewels.

Extracting the soul, and taking the Heart from it, I put it in a Jewel.

Making the Possession Jewels were simple, less than 1% of the person's Spirit Energy was used from their collected souls.

I didn't lose anything, but it was a laborious task.

I healed the corpses with magic and inserted the Possession Jewel.

And so the person's Nucleic Heart was returned.

It was easier said than done, but with Raphael-san's insane computational ability, it was a task made much easier.

He identified each individual, sorting through and picking from their genetic and spiritual data, almost instantly, so he should really be called -sensei rather than -san.

With this process, it was possible to reuse the body, and use the Possession Jewel to successfully achieve resurrection.

This method still had its flaws.

First, it greatly weakened the person in question.

Obviously, because I didn't include any of their Spirit Energy.

From now on, along with all their skills being sealed, magic usage could cause some problems.

But the strength of the original body was still the same, and if they never really relied on any Skills or magic, they were good to go.

And another flaw.

And I really couldn't do anything about it.

Those whose bodies didn't remain, could not be revived.

Obviously.

I wasn't an omnipotent God by any means.

With no physical data from the body to compare it to, I couldn't do anything with the soul data.

I could technically put them in automatons, but was that really worth it?

I didn't have enough automatons anyway.

I really didn't have any duty nor did I have any advantage in doing that much.

Let's just go with: they were unlucky.

If even a single body part remained, magic repair was possible—— It wasn't possible to reproduce the soul, so revival magic wasn't an option in that case—— but some of them didn't even have that much.

There were those completely reduced to ashes with Ultima's 'Nuclear Flame' and others had even their DNA destroyed with Testarossa's 'Death Streak'.

Yet others had died at the very spiritual level from unsurmountable fear.

This last group wasn't receptive of any healing magic, so I really didn't know what to do.

As a result, more than 200,000 people were impossible to revive.

200,000 out of the original 900,000 were really really dead.

Well, all of them would be dead normally, but its pretty lucky to get by with less than a quarter I'd say.

I really thought that Testa and co. went overboard, but then again, I never ordered to preserve the bodies.

The reason was simple.

If our troops got casualties while worrying about such things, it was meaningless.

It was an us or them situation, the us being more important than the them.

Or rather, I wasn't such a peace loving hippie nor did I have so compassionate a heart towards the enemy.

So, some of them not reviving was the least of my worries.

It really didn't bother me but..... having the sensibilities of a peaceful modern-day Japanese person, it was an indescribable feeling.

I didn't think I was wrong in my actions, but I still wasn't used to it.

So I hypocritically pray that souls rest in peace.

Even so, I won't be going any easier on others invading my domain, and will have them cower back in fear.

I had confirmed the results of the ritual on Calgurio and co.

Now to do it on a larger scale.

700,000 bodies were lined up at the entrance of the Labyrinth.

After the fighting was over, Gerudo went to get them.

The victims from other fights were also being collected.

The bodies there were all the ones we could recover.

Sacred Birthday.

Calgurio and co. who were still looking at me from the tent,

their eyes almost popping out in astonishment.

They might get their eyes permanently affixed that way.

Well, not that I cared.

Let's just get this over with.

I'd insert a Possession Vessel into each body.

With the help of Alderman's Holy Magic, the bodies were now perfectly restored.

Recently, everyone had been losing sleep from working so hard.

As a Ghost, Alderman, didn't have that need though.

That being the case, we were taking care of the bodies like in a production line.

Followed by, 〈Arcane Soul Grant〉 instead of 〈Arcane Soul Recall〉.

Unlike Soul Regeneration, this method was much more energy efficient.

There was a lot of data to be analysed for each person, but Raphael took care of it.

I left most of the details to Raphael-sensei.

It was a complex ritual that I likely could not perform alone.

Though from the outside, Calgurio and co.

probably thought I was the one doing all this.

Some of them even prostrated themselves as if worshipping some kind of God.

Hey now, that's making me uneasy so can you please stop?

But I bore it without complaint till the ritual was done.

And in that uneasy state, I spent around the next 24 hours performing 〈Arcane Soul Grant〉 on ~700,000 people.

The next day the revived people were fed.

The confusion right after revival wasn't too hectic, but it wasn't easy to manage either.

A huge amount of nabe, with various kinds of meat and vegetables thrown in, with a stew like distinctive taste, was

prepared.

Warm and with lots of ingredients.

For the Imperial troops, having calmed down and recovered their memories, this soup would be a source of liveliness and warmth beyond words.

Their hunger going unnoticed, the risen tensions now dissipated.

They realized that they had already been killed once by the Demon Lord.

But they were now alive.

The Demon Lord had said 'partial life'.

Rest assured. There would be no problem living normal lives.

There were no restrictions on love-making, or child-making.

But for doing anything opposite of the best interests of Tempest, of course there was a penalty!

A 'curse' inside the Possession Jewel inside them, would prevent any action as an enemy.

They had to completely understand that.

As everyone had calmed down, it was explained thus.

But the 'curse' was really not necessary, Calgurio said with confidence.

No one would be foolish enough to try this kind of thing again.

Several hundred years ago, the destruction caused by Veldora,

only caused fear to spread.

But felling a city, killing all the residents, was something men could achieve.

Was that why? Even with the fear, no one doubted the possibility of winning against the storm dragon.

Or rather, if some had survived, perhaps news of the real danger would have spread farther.

In that regard, maybe the mistake of this invasion would have been averted.

Having once died, they had been revived.

All by the hands of this Demon Lord-cum-God.

We foolish humans were reminded of our utter impudence.

No, is she really a Demon Lord?

Calgurio was doubting these base facts.

Krishna even changed his faith over to Rimuru-ism overnight.

Well since Calgurio was already doing that, he had no complaints.

The Demon Lord did say, 'partial life' but.....

In reality, there was no problem at all.

Certainly, using Skills was impossible, and magic was harder to perform.

But, his well trained body had remained unaffected.

He could age, and was allowed to live and procreate like any other humans.

Everyone was so thankful and awe-inspired that there was no doubt that all their enmity had vanished.

But there was a problem on another front.

Their positions were split on whether they should return back to the Empire.

One side arguing to go back for the time being.

The other, arguing to relocate to Tempest.

There was a square difference in opinion.

Both sides were reasonable, those with families would of course want to go back.

But if they expressed any poor choice in words, they might anger the Demon Lord.

They were given mercy, so they would obviously not try anything like that.

As Calgurio pondered on what to do, he was called in by the Demon Lord.

With a few advisors, he was given audience.

To the nervous Calgurio,

“Be at ease. I want to get your opinion on something.”

Laughed Demon Lord Rimuru, sinisterly, with the face of a lovely girl.

The conclusion: By the Demon Lord’s command, their opinion

didn't matter.

It was all conditional.

Currently, the Empire and Tempest were at war.

As no cease-fires had been announced, they were still officially a hostile nation.

There were no wartime treaties, nor was there any concept of POWs between the 2 nations. But, the revived Calgurio and co. had no intention of disobeying the Demon Lord.

Further, the war was still ongoing.

And even Calgurio understood that they couldn't be allowed leave in that situation.

Even if Calgurio couldn't, the Empire could still mobilize

more troops from the rear.

So evidently, they had to stay in Tempest till the war was over.

And then she spoke,

“Food isn’t free you know?

We can handle 300,000 by ourselves, but with 700,000, we needed to get it from other countries.

Therefore, those who eat shall be put to work!”,

Of those issues.

Certainly not a minor issue.

They were introduced to a General Gerudo, and under his supervision, the troops were to do construction work.

They would be undertaking a project to build a bustling city for more than 300,000 people.

Transporting iron-ore from the mine would be troublesome, so the decision was to build the city around the mine itself.

General Gerudo gullibly accepted the job.

“It appears that some of you want to stay here after the war is over, so I suggest you work diligently.

You look like a greedy bunch, good.

I want you to do large scale exports of automobiles, so build me a profitable and functional Industrialized city!”

Calgurio had no option to refuse, and the Demon Lord had spoken thus.

He didn't fully understand what he had to do, but he knew that something big was expected of them.

His spirits were high, but some hesitance remained.

He wasn't complaining, but was baffled at the monsters who obeyed the whims of their lord without question.

Make me a city!

They had to first start construction of a railway, according to the order.

General Gerudo laughed, saying it was great timing as he was short on hands.

You lead an army, so you're good at arranging personnel right? He said casually.

What is even going on in this country?

Calgurio instantly removed that thought, thinking it was rude to the Demon Lord.

Soon, he would be incessantly worked to the bone, but he didn't know that.

As Calgurio was leaving, Diablo came in.

“It has gone just as planned, my liege.”

I nod in response.

We had let the disoriented rat escape, making her believe the Imperial forces defeated.

With that, the army being wiped out — literally — would be the thought.

Krishna had come to me, as if confessing, with the news that the Emperor was trying to establish emergency contact with him, but I left that matter to diablo.

The body of the woman called Miranda wasn't found, so she was the rat, in other words, Yuuki's spy.

Most likely, she was one of the 3 bosses of Cerberus.

Calgurio was being controlled by her without him ever realizing.

As if conducting fraud, he was tempted by greed, but the man probably didn't realize.

Sensing Calgurio's eminent defeat, she made like the wind but..... was obviously detected by Diablo who had been there.

Furthermore, Souei who knows this forest like the back of his hand, was also observing, so there really was no sneaking away.

We had willingly let her go to pass along the information to the Empire and Yuuki.

If they requested peace now, that would be fine.

But if they still didn't plan on stopping, we would really finish them off this time.

Especially Yuuki, who was going to be a pain if let go.

Even if we make peace with the Empire, I want to get a hold of the bastard.

The war continues. We should hit them where it hurts.

The defensive was this time was our complete victory.

I threatened Calgurio with the matter of food, but the problem wasn't actually that big.

Recovery Potions were distributed, and a lot of our troops were hurt.

And a portion of the forest was being pioneered, so those were our losses.

But we did get 3 God-tier, Legendary armours.

And a whopping 940,000 human souls.

It was a pretty big victory.

I still have to choose who among my subordinates to evolve, but I'll announce it soon enough.

Of course, it'll be on the hush.

The war had yet not ended.

I of course knew about the 300 Airships coming from the sea route.

We can't relax yet.

Not to get drunk on a single victory, but some rewards and punishments were in order.

I don't think their loyalty had faded with my advent as Demon Lord, but I still want to test them.

After that's done, we'll take care of the sea route.

It is your turn this time.

In this way, Tempest fended off the Empire's invasion, and would move on to the counterattack.

Intermission: Shinji's Ponderings

Elder Gadra and Shinji were following the slime in front of them, hoping to meet the master of the Labyrinth.

Apparently, this Labyrinth would be where they worked.

“We accepted you in our country, but we’ll have you work it you wanna eat!” Shinji had been told.

The slime that moved with a ‘poyonpoyon’ of its body, but without making a sound, and emitted an air of elegance and majesty.

It may just be his imagination, but this slime didn’t seem like the regular kind which were considered the weakest of monsters.

After all, this is the slime that accepted exiles like them. It was the king of this country, Demon Lord Rimuru.

It looked as if he could beat it with a single strike, but that was the worst of ideas.

After all, walking beside the Demon Lord as his servant was a Demon releasing a bizarre aura.

That Demon was called itself Diablo.

Shinji couldn't tell, but Elder Gadra looked at Diablo, eyes wide open,

“This much power..... to think he has underlings at the Demon Lord level.....”

And said in astonishment.

He must have been pretty strong.

Shinji was told later that, surpassing the elite Arch Demons,

this being could essentially create true hell on earth.

Shinji was a member of the team that faced a devastating blow during the subjugation mission of the Arch Demon who caused the 'Lake Dyed in Crimson' incident. He couldn't help but turn white in the face at those words.

Anyway, both of them had nodded and agreed among themselves that they absolutely cannot anger Demon Lord Rimuru.

And so, they were walking behind this Diablo inside the Labyrinth.

The room they were guided to, had a certain Faerie.

"Yahho ~! Name's Ramiris! You guys are my new hands right?"

The little Faerie, flew right to their faces.

Around 30cm in height? She looked like a cute little girl.

“Ho-Holy guacamole, it’s a real live Fairy!”

Mark went all “Oh! Fantastic!” and got excited all by himself.

Shinji knew that feel.

But, Mark’s words had made the Faerie become conceited.

“Fufun! You, I like you. ‘Kay you guy are hired.

But remember! All my orders require absolute obedience!”

Puffing out her non-existent chest, said the tiny annoying Faerie.

She’s the type who just wants to play, Shinji deduced.

The Labyrinth was truly a queer place.

On one hand there were the super strong beings like Immortal King Adalman — or his right hand man Holy Knight Albert —, and on the other, there were innocent childlike Faeries fooling around.

Shinji was having doubts about working there, but in the end, they would be working under the master of this Labyrinth.

Mark was really happy, but unfortunately for him, they probably wouldn't be with her much longer.

(The master is probably Immortal King-sama. Seeing as he's old friends with Elder Gadra, there's no doubt.)

Shinji had thought.

The name Ramiris did ring a bell.....

Well it's fine, guessed Shinji and voiced his thoughts.

“Sorry, but we came here to work under the master of the Labyrinth.

I'd love to play with you later, but we have work——”,

Elder Gadra gave Shinji a chop on the head to stop him talking.

Shinji had no idea what he did wrong.

But ignoring the confused boy,

“If it isn't Ramiris-sama! My name is Gadra.

Please forgive this insolence!”

“Y-yea..... Is he alright?”

“No problem at all of course, he’s been trained hard!”

Conversed Ramiris and Gadra.

Seeing that, Shinji remembered that Ramiris was the name of a Demon Lord.

Mark and Xinh, apparently also remembered, and both stood at attention.

To the nervous bunch,

“Ah, you know her already?”

This is Ramiris. Your boss.

Don't be rude 'cos she's small, or else the secretary will get you."

And out of nowhere, the secretary had come out as Demon Lord Rimuru mentioned it.

Her name was Beretta, and she was the secretary-cum-bodyguard of Ramiris.

Seeing Beretta, with her automaton like appearance and masked face,

"What in the....."

Gadra moaned.

It seemed, there was some reason for this moaning, the trio thought.

So this masked Beretta also wasn't any small fry.

She was also someone worthy to be around the Demon Lord, a fearsome monster.

Shinji and co. had the job of monitoring the troops who would invade the Labyrinth.

These troops were, people whose side they were on until recently, the Imperial kind.

They didn't know most of them, but there some acquaintances among them.

It wasn't the best job in the world, but orders were orders.

Thinking thus, they continued their surveillance.

The first day, the invasion was going smoothly.

There was some intrigue though.

The structure of the maze was completely different form what Shinji and co. remembered.

So they asked,

“Well obviously, the 100 floors of the Labyrinth can be easily switched around!”

Demon Lord Ramiris, said matter-of-factly.

This Faerie was also in the surveillance room, looking at the images on the large screen.

It wasn't too surprising, but Ramiris was very friendly.

There was no tension or stiffness.

Demon Lord Rimuru looked friendly, but there was some hesitance in talking to him. On the other hand, Ramiris, would start the conversation herself, so it was much easier for Shinji and co. to get along.

Demon Lord Rimuru was in the main control room.

But there was another mysterious person there besides Ramiris.

He was reading with a bored expression.

Shinji recognized the book, having read that manga before, and wanted to comment — Was it okay to comment? — but desperately held himself back.

It was nostalgic piece and if possible, he wanted to ask to borrow it. But his voice wouldn't listen to him.

He was curious as hell, but the day passed without him being able to ask.

On a different note, they were told before starting, their pay was 3 gold coins per month.

So 36 gold per year, but there would be bonuses too.

Well, the bonuses depended on the boss's mood, so that wasn't reliable.

In the Empire, Shinji had a yearly salary of 70 gold, and Mark and Xinh also got around 50 gold so it was quite a big demotion.

It was almost half, but Shinji didn't complain.

The first year was the trial period, and they could get a raise based on performance in the next year.

They also provided food and health benefits, and things were cheap too.

Work clothes and a place to sleep, were also given.

Surprisingly, they got their own room, with a kitchen to the side, and even a toilet.

Unbelievably, it could even flush.

They had ranked up from dark age to modern day one-room mansions.

Even the Imperial capital, people didn't have single rooms with toilets.

A personal room with bath and toilet, would only be found in ultra-luxury hotels that charged 10 gold per night.

Plus, these toilets could flush.

A system made with magic, it used plentiful water to do its

thing.

A scary amount of benefits was given, so rather than complain about the pay, Shinji and co. were eternally grateful.

For Gadra, it was all so unimaginably convenient, he was speechless.

And work hours were also fixed.

Every day at 6:00 AM, they would go to take Ramiris, and have breakfast at the Elves restaurant at 6:30.

And lunch was on Ramiris too so they could order anything for free.

And at 3:00 PM in the afternoon, the work day would end.

Most stores were only open till 6:00 PM, so work should end

earlier, apparently.

It was a 9-hour work day, but there was a proper 1-hour break. They could also chat with the adventurers in the restaurant.

It was a very beneficial job.

On another note, dinner was on themselves.

They received an ID bracelet, that granted free movement in the Labyrinth, and in addition, a free pass to any inn food in the Labyrinth.

But, the Elves Restaurant cost money.

There was the expensive 1 gold meal, but the cheapest they served was a 3 silver coin meal. It was priced like luxury hotel food, but the taste didn't lose to the price.

Breakfast and Lunch was free —— and so was dinner, would be a thought that cost them dearly.

One time, they went out thinking they would get free food as Ramiris' friends.

That day, they reluctantly ordered the cheapest meal and somehow survived.

But, there were food places other than in the Labyrinth.

Just outside, Adventurers had set up all sorts of stalls.

There were yakiniku and taverns. And of course, bars serving alcohol, and although there was free inn food in the Labyrinth, it was better outside.

There were also their kitchens, so they could always cook at home.

They were getting used to life like that, but it was a story from a bit later.

On the second day, the invasion really started.

The mysterious person who was sitting around, bored, the previous day, looked very excited now.

He was apparently the Storm Dragon Veldora in human form.

Shinji was surprised, but that feeling wouldn't be the first one of them he had on that day.

This day, would be the most surprising day of his life.

After 2 hours had passed, Gadra was moaning intensely, while Shinji's trio were thankful for their luck.

They had realized their mistake in thinking Adalman and

Albert as the strongest in the Labyrinth.

Shinji and co. were given the task of finding knowledgeable ‘Otherworlders’ among the invaders, while helping out on other tasks.

They had to measure the strength and also the character of those ‘Otherworlders’.

This way, they were able to see the battles on each floor, and also, see the insanity.

“Hey? It was good that you listened to me and came here eh?”

Gadra’s voice sounded as if from far away, and the other 3 couldn’t do anything other than nod.

Floor 50 was the end, and 51 ~ 60 would be the return route.

The 3 of them who had imagined such foolish things were shedding tears at their idiocy.

It was no laughing matter, but they let out dry laughs.

If Gadra hadn't brought them here, they would be the ones on that screen.

They went stiff at the thought

The trio thanked Elder Gadra for his foresight from the bottom of their hearts.

Albert who they believed unbeatable was beaten.

Emperor's Personal Guards No. 17, Krishna, had broken Albert's sword which led to the defeat.

In reality, Albert had more skill with the sword, but this

sword that had hit the Legendary God-tiered armour, had broken.

Adalman, who needed Albert as a vanguard, now had to fight in close quarters combat which he was weak against.

Their combined strength broken, he also fell to defeat.

In a grumpy tone,

“Still too naïve you bag of bones!”

Gadra said in frustration as if talking about himself.

But the other three felt like the fight took place in another dimension and weren't able to make any comment.

Shinji and co. didn't realize, but seeing these fights was surely lucky for them.

If they ever fought such monstrous beings, the experience should definitely come in handy.

But, at that time, they just watched.

In the end, all 350,000 of the invaders of the Labyrinth were wiped out.

Even the insanely strong Guard, Krishna, was no match for the monster known as Zegion.

At the point when Krishna died, Shinji and co. didn't have the energy to react anymore.

Just fu~ck my shit ri~ght up.

Was their collective feeling.

Well, they did remember to do their jobs, and being

acquaintances, recommended Michelle and Raymond.

As well as surviving till the very end, the fact that they broke their fake Revival Charms, caught the eye of a certain Ramiris.

Thus, their current task of finding new 'Otherworlders' as assistant material was done.

Soon after, Elder Gadra and Adalman rekindled their old friendship, and the Elder would go on to work in in Labyrinth management.

And later on he would be recognized as one of the 10 Lords of the Labyrinth, and work in that position.

Shinji, Mark, Xinh, Michelle, and Raymond, all became assistants of Ramiris, and helped her with all sorts of experiments.

Well, the experiments were mostly playful, so they were having fun.

But there were some surprisingly good results from the research, so most people didn't think they were playing around.

“Well, I guess that's life.”

Shinji lets out.

As someone always being thrown around by, and at the mercy of life, it was truly a Shinji-like pondering.